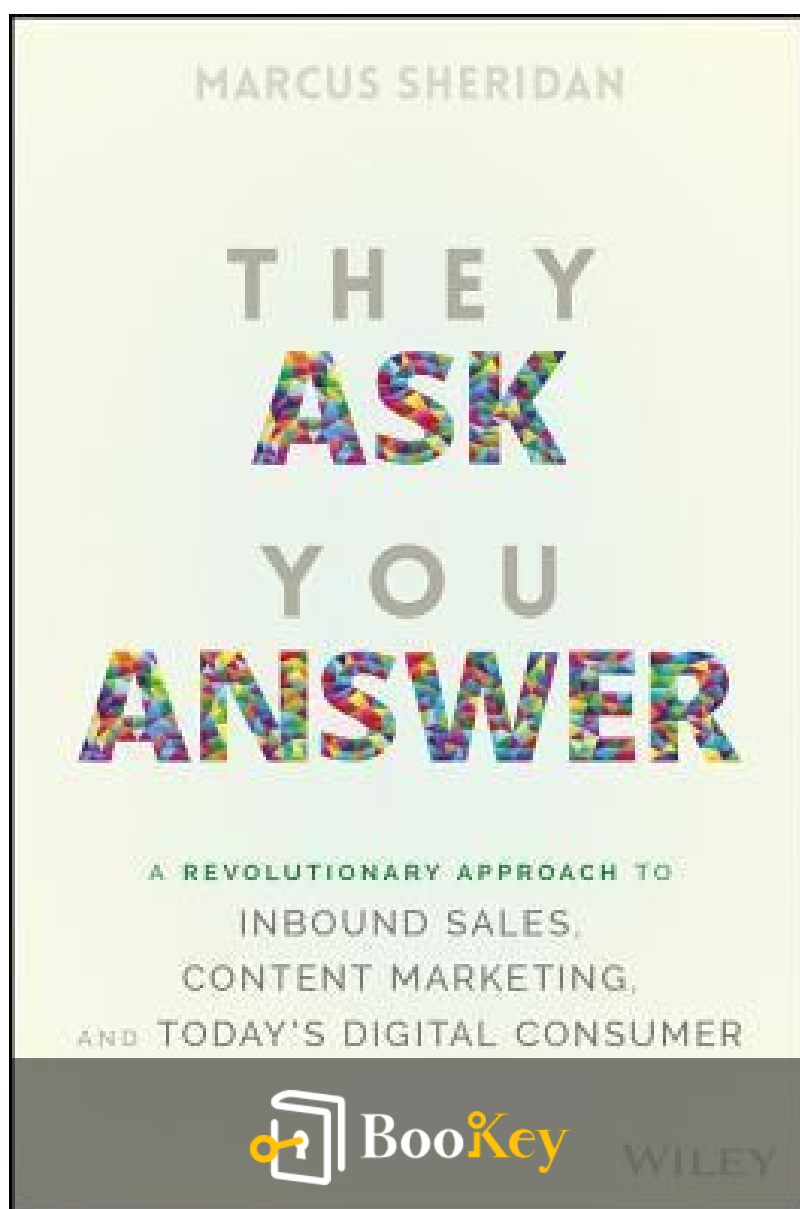


They Ask You Answer PDF

Marcus Sheridan



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About the book

In "They Ask You Answer," Marcus Sheridan presents a groundbreaking marketing strategy that empowers businesses to harness the full potential of the Internet. This practical guide reveals how traditional advertising methods may be wasting your budget while the key to success lies in high-quality content marketing. Drawing from his own experience of transforming a struggling pool company into one of the largest in the U.S., Sheridan illustrates how addressing customer questions can lead to unprecedented growth. By leveraging in-house resources to create valuable content, businesses can build trust, attract customers, and enhance their online visibility. Say goodbye to outdated tactics and become a trusted authority in your industry—start answering questions, and watch your business thrive.

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About the author

Marcus Sheridan, recognized by the New York Times as a “web marketing guru,” transformed his struggling swimming pool company, River Pools, during the economic downturn of 2008, a journey that has been chronicled in numerous publications worldwide. Since then, he has emerged as a leading global speaker and consultant in digital sales and marketing, partnering with countless businesses and brands to help them establish themselves as trusted authorities within their industries.

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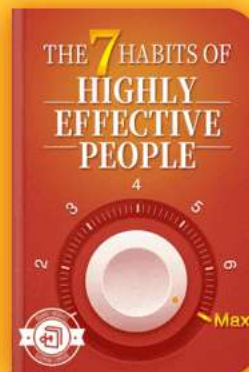
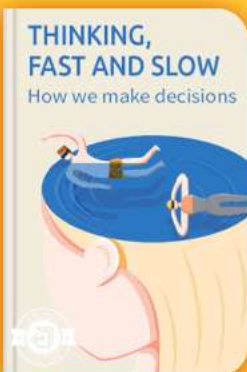


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Chapter 1 Summary : The Fall



Section	Summary
Personal Struggles Amid Business Failure	The author reflects on feelings of anxiety and hopelessness as his company's bank account is overdrawn, leading to tears and a realization that he has run out of solutions.
Path to Becoming a Pool Guy	After graduating from West Virginia University, the author, dissatisfied with his job, returns to Virginia and takes a temporary position at River Pools and Spas. He discovers a knack for the pool industry and considers partnership.
Economic Context from 2001-2008	During the early years of River Pools and Spas, favorable economic conditions fueled business growth in home improvement, with the real estate boom allowing easy access to lending for pool installations.
The Downfall in 2008	The financial crisis of 2008 leads to significant losses for River Pools, with canceled contracts and operational challenges, culminating in the author's deep personal crisis as bankruptcy looms.

Summary of Chapter 1: The Fall

Personal Struggles Amid Business Failure

The author opens with a poignant recollection of feeling

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overwhelmed by anxiety and hopelessness as he checks his company's bank balance, revealing it to be overdrawn. Despite this grim reality, he clings to a faint hope that the situation might improve. The emotional weight of failure in both business and personal life becomes overwhelming, leading to tears as he realizes he has run out of solutions.

Path to Becoming a Pool Guy

After graduating from West Virginia University in 2001, the author's initial career plan involved securing a job that aligned with his skills. However, dissatisfaction with his job near Washington, D.C. led him and his wife to return to their roots in Virginia, where he took a temporary role managing a retail store for River Pools and Spas, despite his hesitations about the pool industry. Unexpectedly, he begins to thrive in this role, learning about pools and quickly becoming knowledgeable enough to consider partnership in the company.

Economic Context from 2001-2008

During the early years of River Pools and Spas, the favorable economic conditions allowed for business growth in the

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home improvement sector, despite varying success. Real estate booms provided customers access to lending for pool installations, resulting in rapid expansion for River Pools.

The Downfall in 2008

The chapter culminates with the onset of the financial crisis in 2008, which brings unprecedented challenges for River Pools and Spas. After an encouraging start to the year, the collapse of the economic system leads to significant losses, including canceled contracts and an inability to sustain operations. The author faces the potential bankruptcy of the business he has dedicated himself to, resulting in a profound personal crisis marked by hopelessness and despair. Through this narrative, the chapter sets the stage for a larger discussion on resilience and adaptation in the face of daunting challenges.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: The author's journey reflects the harsh realities of entrepreneurship, illustrating the thin line between success and failure.

Critical Interpretation: While Marcus Sheridan's narrative emphasizes resilience and personal growth through adversity, readers should consider that the perception of turning points in one's career can vary greatly. He credited unforeseen circumstances and personal commitment to his eventual success in the pool industry. However, this perspective may romanticize the inherent unpredictability of business environments and risks involved; other businesses faced similar challenges yet did not recover. Expert critiques, such as those presented in "The Lean Startup" by Eric Ries, highlight the importance of evidence-based management over anecdotal success stories, suggesting that the author's view may not capture the full landscape of entrepreneurial plight.

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Chapter 2 Summary : A Massive Buying Shift and the Blur between Sales and Marketing



Section	Summary
Consumer Buying Patterns	Consumer buying behavior has shifted significantly, with about 70% of decisions made before engaging with a company, applicable to both B2C and B2B sectors.
Historical Comparison	A decade ago, only 20-30% of buying decisions occurred before company contact. The rise to 70% suggests potential for even higher future percentages.
Impact on Organizations	Marketing now plays a larger role in influencing sales, but companies often cut marketing funds instead of adapting to this reality.
Changing Business Dynamics	To thrive in the digital age, companies must adapt and listen to consumer needs, as seen with Zappos and CarMax.
Looking Ahead	The merging of sales and marketing will increase, emphasizing online sales channels. Businesses need to adapt to stay competitive.

Massive Buying Shift and the Blur between Sales and Marketing

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Consumer Buying Patterns

Over the past decade, consumer buying patterns have shifted dramatically. The traditional lines between sales and marketing have become indistinct, leading to a major change in how decisions are made. Research indicates that today, approximately 70% of the buying decision occurs before a customer engages with the company. This statistic holds true across both Business-to-Consumer (B2C) and Business-to-Business (B2B) sectors.

Historical Comparison

A decade ago, the percentage of the buying decision made before contact with a company was estimated to be between 20% and 30%. This significant increase to 70% raises questions about future trends, suggesting that we may see even higher percentages in the next decade.

Impact on Organizations

With this shift in consumer behavior, marketing has taken on a greater role in influencing sales than traditional sales teams.

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However, in challenging times, companies often cut back on marketing first, while hiring more salespeople when looking for growth. This reflects an outdated mindset that needs updating to align with current market realities.

Changing Business Dynamics

As businesses navigate the digital age, they must adapt to the evolving landscape. Companies that break old norms and respond to consumer expectations are thriving. Examples include Zappos, which changed shipping policies to better accommodate customers, and CarMax, which revolutionized the used car industry by listening to consumer needs.

Looking Ahead

The future will see an even greater merging of sales and marketing, with a continued emphasis on online sales channels. Businesses must prepare for these changes to remain competitive. The author shares personal experiences of successfully selling high-value products online, underscoring the necessity for adaptation in the face of shifting buyer behaviors.

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Example

Key Point: Consumer engagement prior to sales contact is crucial for success.

Example: Imagine you're planning to buy a new laptop. You start by researching online, seeking reviews and comparisons, which influences your preferences. By the time you finally visit a store, 70% of your buying decision is already made based on existing content. This showcases how imperative it is for businesses to produce informative, relevant content that aligns with consumer interests and buying stages.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: The blurring lines between sales and marketing indicate a deep consumer-driven shift in business dynamics.

Critical Interpretation: The argument that marketing now plays a pivotal role in driving sales may overlook the complexities of individual consumer engagement levels and decision-making processes. The author's claim, while supported by statistical evidence, should prompt readers to explore counterarguments regarding the effectiveness of traditional sales approaches, especially in industries that heavily rely on personal interactions. Research from sources like the Sales Management Association could provide insights into the continuing significance of direct sales strategies, suggesting that despite evolving consumer patterns, there remains value in personal sales techniques not captured by digital marketing alone.

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Chapter 3 Summary : This Book Won't Work for You If . . .

Section	Description
This Book Won't Work for You If	Identifies conditions that may limit the effectiveness of the book for certain businesses.
Consumer Behavior Shift	Emphasizes the importance of recognizing changing consumer buying patterns to benefit from the book.
Mindset Matters	Discusses the importance of having an open mindset towards new ideas and strategies.
The "We're Different" Phenomenon	Explains how the belief in a unique business can lead to misconceptions, yet most businesses share common needs.
Building Trust	Highlights that trust is crucial for business success and is a universal need across industries.
Challenge to the Reader	Encourages readers to remain open-minded and recognize similarities between businesses to improve operations.

This Book Won't Work for You If

Consumer Behavior Shift

This chapter emphasizes two critical factors that will determine the effectiveness of the book for your business. The first is the acknowledgment of changing consumer buying patterns. If you do not recognize these changes, the book may not be beneficial for you.

Mindset Matters

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The second factor relates to personal mindset. There are two types of people in response to new ideas: those who are open to possibilities and those who dismiss new strategies, believing their business is unique. The latter often claim that what works for others won't work for them due to their perceived differences.

The "We're Different" Phenomenon

Most people believe their business is “different,” which often stems from a desire to feel special. However, this belief can be misleading. Most businesses fundamentally share common needs, particularly the need to build consumer trust.

Building Trust

The author shares personal experiences from his swimming

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Chapter 4 Summary : The Discovery of They Ask, You Answer

Section	Summary
Financial Crisis and Reflection	The author faces financial ruin for his company and recognizes the urgent need for quick change to generate leads and sales to avoid bankruptcy.
Changing Consumer Behavior	The author observes a significant shift in consumer behavior, with increased reliance on the Internet for product and service information, altering the traditional sales dynamics.
The Ineffectiveness of Traditional Marketing	Traditional advertising methods prove ineffective, prompting the author to adapt and leverage online marketing for business growth.
Embracing the Internet	The author dedicates himself to learning online marketing strategies, including inbound, content, and digital marketing, realizing their necessity for adaptation.
Adopting a Consumer Mindset	Viewing marketing strategies from a consumer perspective, the author simplifies concepts and identifies that attracting customers through problem-solving builds trust.
Core Realization and Motto	The key insight gained is the importance of answering consumer questions, leading to the new motto "They Ask, You Answer," which influences businesses worldwide.

Chapter 4: The Discovery of They Ask, You Answer

Financial Crisis and Reflection

The author, facing financial ruin for his company, recognizes the urgent need for change. With fewer potential buyers due to the economy, he realizes the importance of generating leads and sales quickly to avoid bankruptcy.

Changing Consumer Behavior

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Amidst the stress, the author reflects on the evolving landscape of consumer behavior. He notices that people's buying and shopping habits have shifted dramatically, with an increasing reliance on the Internet for information. Consumers can now become experts on products and services at their fingertips, changing the traditional sales dynamic.

The Ineffectiveness of Traditional Marketing

The author's prior experiences with traditional advertising methods, like TV and newspapers, prove to be ineffective as their return on investment continues to decline.

Acknowledging this shift, he recognizes the critical need to adapt to leverage the Internet for business growth.

Embracing the Internet

Determined to save River Pools and Spas, the author immerses himself in learning about online marketing strategies. Discovering terms like inbound marketing, content marketing, and digital marketing, he realizes these concepts were initially overwhelming but essential for his adaptation.

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Adopting a Consumer Mindset

Without formal marketing education, the author views these strategies through the eyes of a consumer, simplifying them into actionable insights. He concludes that the essence of inbound marketing is to attract customers instead of chasing them, and that teaching and solving problems builds buyer trust.

Core Realization and Motto

Ultimately, the fundamental insight he gains is the significance of answering consumer questions. This realization shapes the company's new motto, "They Ask, You Answer," which transforms their approach and ends up impacting businesses globally.

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Example

Key Point: Embracing a Consumer Mindset in Marketing

Example: Imagine you're a potential buyer, researching a swimming pool for your backyard. You type questions into Google, seeking genuine guidance. Instead of flashy ads, you encounter helpful articles and videos directly addressing your concerns. This shift to answering customer queries and providing valuable insights is vital. It's about creating content that resonates with your audience's questions, ultimately building trust and guiding them through their buying journey.

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Chapter 5 Summary : “They Ask, You Answer” Defined

Section	Summary
What is They Ask, You Answer?	This philosophy emphasizes understanding customer thoughts, questions, and feelings, positioning companies as educators that address all inquiries from prospects and customers.
The Importance of Customer Insight	Companies adopting this approach aim to become authoritative figures in their industry, building trust and evolving based on customer insights, demonstrating effectiveness across various sectors.
Structure of the Book	The book is divided into four parts: Digital Marketing Impact, Sales Culture Influence, Implementation Guide, and Common Questions and Concerns, providing insights and guidance on the approach.
Conclusion	They Ask, You Answer is a transformative strategy that can redefine company operations, culture, and profitability, leading to long-term success.

What is They Ask, You Answer?

They Ask, You Answer is more than just a business strategy; it is a comprehensive philosophy that encompasses communication, company culture, and selling techniques. At its core lies a deep concern for understanding the customer’s thoughts, questions, feelings, and fears. Companies that adopt this philosophy position themselves as educators in their industry, committed to addressing all inquiries from prospects and customers, no matter how challenging they may seem.

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The Importance of Customer Insight

Organizations embracing They Ask, You Answer recognize their responsibility to become the go-to authority in their field. This proactive approach not only cultivates trust but also informs the strategic evolution of the business based on customer insights. This methodology leads to substantial implications for various companies, demonstrating its effectiveness across different sectors.

Structure of the Book

The book is structured in four main parts:

1.

Digital Marketing Impact

: Examines how They Ask, You Answer influences inbound and content marketing efforts.

2.

Sales Culture Influence

: Explores the methodology's effects on sales strategies and organizational structure.

3.

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Implementation Guide

: Provides a detailed roadmap for integrating this approach into your business, answering key questions about the process.

4.

Common Questions and Concerns

: Addresses typical queries businesses may have about adopting this philosophy, offering clarity and solutions to facilitate implementation.

Conclusion

Ultimately, They Ask, You Answer is a transformative approach that could redefine various aspects of a company's operations, culture, and profitability, setting the stage for enduring success.

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Example

Key Point: Understanding Customer Questions as Opportunities

Example: Imagine you're running a bakery. A customer emails you asking why your bread is more expensive than the supermarket. Instead of avoiding the question, you embrace it, responding with a detailed explanation of your quality ingredients and artisan methods. This engagement not only addresses their concern but also positions you as an expert in your craft, ultimately building a loyal customer base that appreciates transparency and values your commitment to quality.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: Customer-Centric Philosophy

Critical Interpretation: While the concept of They Ask, You Answer emphasizes understanding customer needs, it's essential to critically assess whether adopting a purely customer-centric approach may overshadow other strategic imperatives essential for a company's broader vision and long-term sustainability.

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Chapter 6 Summary : Brainstorming the Questions You Are Asked Every Day

6 Brainstorming the Questions You Are Asked Every Day

Now that the core philosophy for moving forward with River Pools and Spas is established, it's time for action. The author began by brainstorming all the questions received about fiberglass swimming pools over nine years. This exercise was productive, yielding over a hundred questions within thirty minutes due to constant customer engagement.

In the following months, the author and business partners created articles and videos to answer these questions, publishing them as blog posts on their website and uploading corresponding videos to YouTube. The driving force behind this process was a commitment to truly answer questions in depth, embodying a teacher's mentality focused on education without bias.

This brainstorming and content creation activity evolved into a crucial guide for many other sales and marketing teams. Every industry has numerous questions that prospects and

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customers seek answered when making buying decisions. Despite this, many company websites fail to address more than a few dozen of these inquiries, which presents a paradox: consumers expect ample information, yet businesses often prioritize self-promotion over addressing customer needs.

To put this into action, the author suggests having a brainstorming session to list every question ever posed by a customer or prospect, focusing on their fears, issues, and concerns. Once documented, this list can form the basis of a digital marketing editorial calendar, influencing the creation of articles, videos, and other content for the company website. If generating these questions proves difficult, it may indicate a disconnect with the ideal customer, necessitating a reunion with the sales and customer service teams to better understand customer inquiries.

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Example

Key Point: Addressing the questions customers ask can significantly enhance business engagement.

Example: Imagine you are a pool company owner sitting down with your team to brainstorm. You jot down every question a potential customer has ever posed, from 'What maintenance do fiberglass pools require?' to 'How long will my pool last?' You realize that over a hundred questions emerge, highlighting the depth of potential customer concerns. This session not only clarifies what your customers want to know but sets the stage for creating targeted content that answers these queries directly. By doing so, you shift from a sales-driven approach to an educational one, and just as you resolve their inquiries through informative blog posts and helpful videos, your customers begin to trust your brand more. They feel understood, which ultimately leads to higher conversions and brand loyalty.

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Chapter 7 Summary : The Ostrich Marketing Strategy

Ostrich Marketing Strategy

Introduction to Ostrich Marketing

Ostrich marketing is a term introduced in this chapter that describes a counterproductive strategy in business—similar to an ostrich burying its head in the sand to avoid problems. This metaphor illustrates how businesses often ignore pressing questions or concerns from customers, hoping they will disappear.

Understanding the Problem

Many businesses choose not to address difficult questions on their websites, opting instead to control the conversation during face-to-face interactions. This avoidance can stem from a fear that acknowledging issues may put the business at a disadvantage. However, this tactic reflects a fundamental

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misunderstanding of consumer behavior.

Impact of Ostrich Marketing

The chapter outlines the adverse effects of ostrich marketing:

- It does not build trust with consumers.
- It results in missed opportunities for engagement, such as phone calls or online purchases.
- It fails to generate interactions like filling out contact forms.

The Solution

The key takeaway is to avoid ostrich marketing by embracing the "They Ask, You Answer" approach. By addressing customer questions openly and honestly, businesses can build trust and foster stronger relationships with their prospects and customers.

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Example

Key Point: Understanding Consumer Trust

Example: Imagine you're shopping for a new car, and every dealer you approach dodges your toughest questions about warranties and repairs, making you skeptical. Instead, if one dealer openly discusses potential issues and offers transparent answers, it boosts your trust and confidence in their business. This shift from avoidance to open dialogue not only fosters trust but also transforms skeptical visitors into loyal customers.

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Chapter 8 Summary : The CarMax Effect

The CarMax Effect

Introduction to They Ask, You Answer

Understanding "They Ask, You Answer" goes beyond creating content to answer customer questions; it embodies a comprehensive business philosophy centered on consumer trust and adapting business models.

Consumer Trust Issues in the Used Car Industry

The used car industry is often associated with negative emotions such as distrust and high-pressure sales tactics. Consumers universally express fears regarding "lemons," haggling, buyer's remorse, and ensuring value. Historically, these fears were largely ignored.

CarMax's Revolutionary Approach

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CarMax emerged as a disruptor in the used car market by acknowledging the industry's trust issues and innovating to earn consumer confidence:

1.

No-Haggle Pricing

: CarMax introduced a single listed price for vehicles, reducing anxiety and building trust.

2.

Flat-Rate Commission for Salespeople

: CarMax implemented a one-commission structure, ensuring salespeople focused on serving customer needs over maximizing personal commissions.

3.

Five-Day Money-Back Guarantee

: This concept challenged industry norms by offering consumers the ability to return vehicles after purchase, addressing fears of buyer's remorse.

4.

Intensive Quality Control

: CarMax's stringent inspection process showcased their commitment to quality, reassuring buyers and building trust.

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Transparency

: By providing CarFax vehicle history reports, CarMax eliminated doubts about vehicle reliability.

The Consumer-Centric Model of CarMax

CarMax's success illustrates how understanding and addressing consumer fears can reshape an entire industry. They effectively transformed negative perceptions of the used car market while establishing themselves as a trustworthy retailer.

Industry Impact and Broader Application

CarMax's philosophy can serve as a model for various industries, emphasizing the importance of listening to consumers and evolving business practices based on their fears and expectations. This approach fosters trust as the cornerstone of successful business operations.

Conclusion

The key takeaway from the CarMax case study is that modern businesses must prioritize consumer concerns to

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cultivate long-lasting trust, ultimately solidifying their market position and pointing the way forward in their respective industries.

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Example

Key Point: Prioritize Consumer Concerns to Build Trust

Example: Imagine you are in a car dealership feeling overwhelmed. CarMax changes everything by offering a no-haggle price, so you already see the value without fearing negotiation or deception. Their flat-rate commission means their sales team is genuinely interested in finding you the right car, not just closing a deal. With a five-day money-back guarantee, any worry about buyer's remorse disappears. You can drive away feeling secure knowing that quality checks and transparency through vehicle history reports are part of your purchase experience. This fundamental shift towards prioritizing your concerns doesn't just make a sale; it builds a lasting trust that keeps you coming back.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: Consumer-Centric Approach

Critical Interpretation: CarMax's success illustrates the necessity of addressing consumer fears to foster trust, yet one must question if this model universally applies across all sectors. While CarMax effectively challenges conventional practices, other industries may face distinct consumer dynamics that resist such disruption. Relevant literature, such as 'Customer Experience 3.0' by John A. Goodman, highlights that not all businesses have the flexibility to adopt similar strategies. Thus, while Sheridan presents a persuasive argument for consumer-centric practices, the idea that this model can be universally applied warrants further scrutiny.

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Chapter 9 Summary : The Discovery of the Big 5

Section	Summary
Chapter Title	Chapter 9: The Discovery of the Big 5
Overview of Progress	Implementing the "They Ask, You Answer" strategy resulted in increased web traffic, qualified leads, and sales growth for River Pools and Spas.
Analytics Dive	An analysis of web analytics six months post-strategy implementation identified effective content types and engagement with the audience.
Identifying the Big 5	The analysis revealed five key content subjects essential for driving traffic, conversions, leads, and sales: 1. Pricing and Costs 2. Problems Versus Comparisons 3. Reviews 4. Best in Class.
Consumer and Business Paradox	Consumers prioritize the Big 5 during purchasing decisions, while businesses often avoid these topics, creating a disconnect in their strategies.
Next Steps	Upcoming chapters will explore each of the Big 5 topics in detail, offering strategies to build consumer trust and improve search engine optimization.

Chapter 9: The Discovery of the Big 5

Overview of Progress

After a couple of months of implementing the "They Ask, You Answer" strategy on the River Pools and Spas website, noticeable improvements were observed. Regularly publishing four to five content pieces each week led to increased web traffic and qualified leads. Sales began to emerge, indicating positive growth despite the economic

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climate.

Analytics Dive

Around six months into the strategy, an in-depth analysis of web analytics was conducted to identify effective content types. This exploration aimed to discern which types of content resonated with readers and drove results.

Identifying the Big 5

The analysis revealed five critical content subjects that significantly impacted traffic, conversions, leads, and sales:

1. Pricing and Costs
2. Problems Versus Comparisons
3. Reviews
4. Best in Class

These subjects are paramount for consumers and businesses

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Chapter 10 Summary : Content Subject

1 Pricing and Costs: Why We Must Talk about Money

Section	Summary
Introduction to Consumer Frustration	Consumers are frustrated by the lack of pricing information on company websites, leading to distrust and potential loss of customers.
The Importance of Transparency	Many businesses avoid discussing pricing due to concerns over variability, competitor awareness, and customer retention. However, customers prefer at least a general idea of costs.
Addressing the Justifications	Businesses should openly discuss pricing factors, which helps empower customers and build trust.
Consequences of Evasion	Avoiding pricing discussions damages credibility and customer engagement, while transparency fosters trust and loyalty.
Conclusion	Marcus Sheridan advocates for a transparent approach to pricing, which can enhance customer relationships and establish trust.

Chapter 10: Pricing and Costs: Why We Must Talk About Money

Introduction to Consumer Frustration

Consumers often feel frustrated when they can't find pricing information on a company's website. This frustration is linked to their desire for transparency and the feeling that companies might be hiding information. If customers can't

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find answers to their queries, they are likely to seek them elsewhere, risking loss of trust.

The Importance of Transparency

Most businesses, however, do not openly discuss pricing on their websites, believing that this practice could lead to various complications. There are three common justifications:

1.

Every Solution is Different:

Businesses argue that pricing varies significantly due to different variables. However, customers generally want at least a sense of potential costs instead of no information at all.

2.

Competitor Awareness:

Companies worry that discussing prices online will reveal their strategies to competitors. In reality, most companies are already aware of what others charge.

3.

Customer Retention Fears:

There is a belief that showing prices will scare off potential customers. In fact, not addressing pricing often leads to

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mistrust and customer abandonment.

Addressing the Justifications

The author suggests that businesses should navigate these concerns by discussing the factors affecting their pricing structure openly. For example, they could explain elements that drive costs down or contribute to higher prices, thus empowering consumers with information and establishing trust.

Consequences of Evasion

When companies avoid discussing costs, they miss the opportunity to engage customers effectively, baker at the expense of their credibility. Transparency is crucial for building trust, which ultimately leads to business loyalty.

Conclusion

In this chapter, Marcus Sheridan emphasizes the necessity for businesses to adopt a more open approach regarding pricing. By addressing consumer questions about costs openly, businesses can improve their relationship with potential

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customers and foster an environment of trust and transparency.

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Example

Key Point: Transparency is essential for building consumer trust regarding pricing.

Example: Imagine browsing a company's website, searching for information on a service that piques your interest. Instead of being greeted with clear pricing, you encounter vague statements and no indicative figures. Frustration builds as you wonder if they're hiding something or if you'll waste time getting quotes. This experience prompts you to click away and find a competitor who openly discusses their prices. In this scenario, greater transparency from the first company could have fostered trust and kept you engaged, highlighting the importance of having clear pricing displayed to build strong customer relationships.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: Transparency about pricing enhances consumer trust

Critical Interpretation: Sheridan posits that openly discussing pricing can help nurture trust and foster long-term customer relationships, yet this view may overlook the complexities of competitive markets where proprietary strategies often dictate pricing confidentiality. While transparency is generally valued, companies must also balance this with the risk of exposing sensitive information that could be advantageous to competitors. Supporting this notion, scholars like Kotler and Keller ("Marketing Management") emphasize the nuanced considerations businesses must navigate in pricing strategy, suggesting Sheridan's straightforward solution may not fit all contexts.

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Chapter 11 Summary : How One Article about Money Generated More Than \$3,000,000 in Sales

Chapter 11 Summary: How One Article about Money Generated More Than \$3,000,000 in Sales

Introduction to Pricing Concerns

For years, Marcus Sheridan received frequent inquiries from potential customers about the costs of fiberglass pools. Initially frustrated by this question, he realized that consumers wanted to understand prices before engaging further in the sales process. This shift in perspective led him to recognize that addressing pricing openly could significantly impact his business.

Creation of the Pricing Article

After realizing the need for transparency, Marcus created an article titled “How Much Does a Fiberglass Pool Cost?” on

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his company's website. In this article, he likened the purchase of a fiberglass pool to a car purchase, emphasizing the variability in options and associated costs. By explaining different packages and costs, he provided a clearer understanding of what potential customers could expect without explicitly stating exact prices.

Impact of the Article

Post-publication, the article quickly gained traction, with it ranking first in Google searches related to fiberglass pool costs within 48 hours. It drove traffic to the website, resulting in over 1 million new visitors and thousands of qualified leads. Ultimately, this single article led to more than \$3 million in additional sales for River Pools and Spas, demonstrating the powerful effect of addressing customer concerns openly and honestly.

The Power of Transparency

Marcus emphasizes that this article radically transformed his business and life, showcasing the importance of honesty and transparency in marketing. Many competitors avoided discussing pricing due to fear of losing sales or revealing

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their pricing structures, but River Pools' willingness to engage with these topics created a competitive advantage that appealed to educated consumers seeking trustworthy information.

Embracing Change in Marketing Strategies

Marcus advocates for businesses to move away from "ostrich marketing," where companies ignore essential customer questions. Instead, companies should willingly discuss costs, pricing, and related subjects, providing insights to educate prospective customers. This approach not only fosters trust but also enhances the leads' quality by attracting individuals genuinely interested in the business's offerings.

Conclusion

In conclusion, an open discussion about money—be it costs or pricing—not only meets consumer expectations but can also lead to substantial business growth. Companies that embrace this philosophy, as demonstrated by River Pools and Spas, stand to gain a significant advantage in their respective markets.

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Chapter 12 Summary : Case Study 1 High-End B2B Technology Company Generates More Than \$8,000,000 in Additional Revenue

Chapter 12: Case Study 1

High-End B2B Technology Company Generates More Than \$8,000,000 in Additional Revenue

Overview of Segue Technologies

Segue Technologies specializes in application development and IT support services for federal, commercial, and nonprofit sectors. They focus on customized solutions that improve efficiency and reduce costs, differentiating themselves from competitors through transparency and education.

Evolution of Segue's Business Model

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The company initially served the government sector before diversifying into commercial business. Ron Novak, the executive vice president, recognized the need to adapt their marketing strategies, which included enhancing their web presence after realizing that a solid website could attract commercial clients.

Embracing "They Ask, You Answer"

During an event in 2012, Novak learned about content marketing strategies based on addressing customer questions—key to transforming their marketing approach. By January 2013, Segue committed to involving all employees in content creation, emphasizing a "teacher's mentality" to better serve clients. Each employee was required to contribute to the content strategy through regular blog posts.

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Chapter 13 Summary : Content Subject

2 Problems: How to Turn Weaknesses into Strengths

Chapter 13: Problems: How to Turn Weaknesses into Strengths

In this chapter, Marcus Sheridan discusses the concept of "problems" as a critical content subject that influences consumer behavior. He emphasizes that when making purchasing decisions, consumers are often more concerned about potential issues than positive aspects of a product or service.

-

Consumer Behavior Insights

- When considering purchases, people frequently search for negative reviews or potential problems rather than positive endorsements. For instance, a buyer interested in a 2017 Ford Mustang may search for "2017 Ford Mustang Negative Reviews," reflecting their focus on risks.

-

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Real-Life Scenario: The Pool Industry

- Sheridan provides a personal example from his experience in the swimming pool industry. He illustrates a scenario where a client compares fiberglass pools with concrete pools. The competing salesperson from "Concrete Joe's Pools" raises concerns about the durability and quality of fiberglass pools, creating fear and uncertainty for the buyer.

-

Moral Dilemma for Buyers

- After receiving conflicting information, buyers face a dilemma: they may have a preference for the fiberglass pool but are now worried about the validity of the negative claims. This often leads them to conduct online searches related to the potential problems associated with fiberglass pools. The chapter underscores the importance of addressing consumer concerns directly and effectively in marketing content, as it can significantly influence their decision-making process.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: Consumer Focus on Problems in Purchasing Decisions

Critical Interpretation: While Sheridan argues that consumers prioritize potential problems over positive attributes, it is crucial to question this perspective since consumer behavior is complex and varies widely across different markets and individuals. Relying on anecdotal evidence, like his experience in the pool industry, doesn't universally apply to all buying situations. Research shows that factors such as brand trust, peer recommendations, and product quality can also heavily influence decisions (e.g., see 'Consumer Behavior: A Marketing Approach' by Parminder K. Ghuman). Thus, while addressing consumer concerns is vital, it is equally important to consider how various factors interplay in shaping consumer attitudes and behaviors.

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Chapter 14 Summary : Addressing the Elephant in the Room

Addressing the Elephant in the Room

Since my early days in the fiberglass pool industry, a recurring question was, “Marcus, be honest with me. What are the problems with a fiberglass swimming pool?” For years, I avoided this question, much like I did with inquiries about cost. However, upon adopting the “They Ask You Answer” philosophy, I decided to confront this issue directly.

My business partner, Jason, composed an insightful article titled “Top 5 Fiberglass Pool Problems and Solutions.” Many in our industry considered it outrageous to address such potential drawbacks, but this move differentiated us. Most competitors ignored these tough questions, despite the fact that consumers wanted answers.

The reluctance to discuss negative aspects stems from a common psychological hurdle in business known as "the elephant in the room." In the digital age, consumers are informed and capable; if they suspect issues with a product

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or service, they will likely uncover the truth.

As a business, you face a choice: let consumers discover these elephants themselves, resulting in a loss of trust, or proactively address them upon first interaction. In our article, we acknowledged that fiberglass pools may not be suitable for everyone. They may not be wide, long, or deep enough, and customization options might be limited. However, for those seeking a low-maintenance pool that lasts a lifetime and fits the available shapes and sizes, a fiberglass pool could be the ideal solution.

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Example

Key Point: Proactively addressing potential drawbacks builds trust and sets you apart from competitors.

Example: Imagine you're considering buying a swimming pool and are drawn to the sleek designs of fiberglass options. But deep down, you wonder about the long-term durability and effectiveness. As you research, you stumble upon a detailed article from a pool company that not only highlights the aesthetic benefits of fiberglass pools but also candidly acknowledges their limitations. This transparency captivates you. Instead of feeling like a fool for asking tough questions, you feel respected for being an informed consumer. Because they addressed common concerns upfront, your confidence in that company rises significantly. You end up choosing them over competitors who only focus on the positives, trusting that they'll be honest with any future needs or issues.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: Acknowledging customer concerns can enhance trust but may also backfire

Critical Interpretation: The core idea presented by Marcus Sheridan in this chapter revolves around the importance of transparency in business, particularly concerning customer inquiries about potential product downsides. While addressing such issues can build trust and cater to the informed consumer in today's digital market, it's crucial to recognize that this approach may not universally apply. Some businesses may find that candid conversations about their products' limitations could alienate skeptical consumers or inadvertently highlight weaknesses that competitors exploit.

Therefore, while Sheridan's 'They Ask You Answer' philosophy promotes openness and differentiation, it's worth considering that consumers' reactions can vary significantly based on context and the reputation of the brand. In this vein, sources like 'Consumer Behavior: Buying, Having, and Being' by Michael Solomon provide valuable insights into how consumers process information and form attitudes about businesses, emphasizing that transparency is not a one-size-fits-all

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strategy.

Chapter 15 Summary : How Talking about Our Problems Generated More Than \$500,000 in Revenue

15 How Talking about Our Problems Generated More Than \$500,000 in Revenue

The reaction to the article addressing problems related to fiberglass pools on our website mirrored the positive response garnered from discussing costs. Consumers expressed gratitude and trust, perceiving our candidness as a significant gesture. Over the past six years, more than 260,000 people visited our site searching for "problems" related to fiberglass pools, which translated into over \$500,000 in additional sales from that single article. This success stemmed from consumers appreciating our willingness to tackle difficult questions. When confronted with inquiries about potential issues with our products, it's crucial to acknowledge those concerns openly. If potential customers are voicing these questions, thousands likely share similar inquiries. Thus, it's advantageous for them to find answers on your platform rather than elsewhere.

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Putting It Into Action

Turn Your Problems into Strengths

To capitalize on this strategy, address the negative perceptions related to your products or services. Start by reflecting on two essential questions:

1. What criticisms does the competition highlight about our offerings?
2. What issues do consumers associate with our products or services?

After identifying these points, consider how you can transparently address them in your web content and sales process. This proactive approach helps in potentially transforming disadvantages into strengths, thus enhancing your brand's credibility and fostering consumer trust.

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Example

Key Point: Honesty about challenges builds trust and increases customer engagement.

Example: Imagine you're in the market for a fiberglass pool, feeling uncertain about its durability after hearing various complaints. You stumble upon a website that not only lists the common issues, like cracking or installation difficulties, but also provides honest solutions and expert advice on how to handle these problems. You feel reassured by their transparency and are more inclined to consider purchasing, ultimately leading you to convert into a valued customer. By addressing potential issues candidly, the business not only alleviates your concerns but also strengthens its credibility, drawing in similar customers who are looking for guidance.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: Transparency in addressing problems can lead to increased consumer trust and revenue.

Critical Interpretation: While the notion that openly discussing product issues can bolster sales seems convincing, it's essential to recognize that this approach may not universally apply to all industries or products. Customer reactions vary significantly based on context, and while Sheridan's example with fiberglass pools is compelling, it doesn't guarantee similar outcomes across different markets or consumer demographics (Thompson, 2016). Critics may argue that excessive focus on problems could actually deter potential buyers or create negative perceptions for some brands. Hence, one should critically evaluate the effectiveness of such strategies within their specific industry, consulting diverse case studies and consumer research to validate the applicability of Sheridan's tactics.

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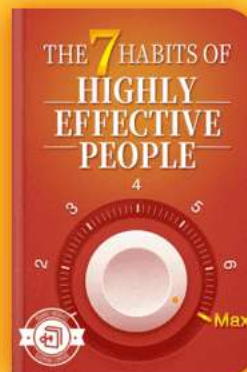


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Chapter 16 Summary : Case Study 2 An Equipment Financing Company Becomes a Digital David and Conquers the Industry Goliaths

Case Study 2: An Equipment Financing Company Becomes a Digital David and Conquers the Industry Goliaths

Introduction to Smarter Finance USA

Rob Misheloff's journey transformed his small financial loan information company into a powerhouse in the equipment financing sector. By utilizing the principles of "They Ask, You Answer," Misheloff carved out a significant niche among industry giants, using unique, transparent, and engaging content to build trust and educate clients.

Background of Smarter Finance USA

Starting in 2003 with a reverse-mortgage direct mail

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operation, Misheloff thrived on helping elderly clients access home equity. However, changes to the mortgage product in 2013 forced him to pivot and find a new market. Entering the equipment financing industry, he quickly observed rampant dishonesty, with many customers being misled by brokers and lenders.

The Formation of Smarter Finance USA

In January 2014, Misheloff launched Smarter Finance USA aimed at providing honest and thorough information about equipment financing. Early attempts at lead generation through spam emails and PPC advertising proved ineffective, leading him to explore content marketing strategies.

Discovery of They Ask, You Answer

Misheloff discovered the principles of They Ask, You Answer during a late-night reading session. Inspired, he immersed himself in content marketing strategies to connect his business with customer needs and questions, leading to meaningful engagement and growth.

Success through Education

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The first content Misheloff created addressed the dishonesty in the financing sector and educated potential clients about common scams and how to avoid them. His articles tackled industry truths with a humorous, transparent approach, building a reputation for trustworthiness.

Content Generation and Trust Building

In just two years, Misheloff's website traffic grew rapidly, from hundreds to over 25,000 visits monthly, and he amassed over 2,600 fresh contacts through direct engagement on the website. Misheloff's method emphasized comprehensive responses to customer queries and demand for clarity regarding pricing and costs, leading to significant lead generation.

Measuring Impact and Revenue Growth

By focusing on consumer education through detailed articles, Misheloff reported substantial revenue growth from his strategies, generating over \$144,000 in the first quarter of 2016 alone. While willing to sublet leads to partners rather than expand his internal team, he prioritized a lifestyle that

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supported his personal happiness over mere financial success.

Conclusion: Embracing Digital Opportunity

Rob Misheloff's story exemplifies how small businesses can overcome larger competitors through digital marketing focused on customer education and transparency. The principles of They Ask, You Answer empowered his business, leading to significant trust and revenue, showcasing the massive potential for transformation within competitive markets.

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Chapter 17 Summary : Content Subject 3 Versus and Comparisons

Chapter 17: Content Subject 3 - Versus and Comparisons

The Fascination with Comparisons

Consumers are deeply interested in comparing products and services before making a purchase decision. The accessibility of information has amplified this tendency, leading buyers to research multiple options rather than settling on a single choice.

Competitive Landscape in the Pool Industry

In the pool industry, competition often occurs not just among similar products but also between different types of pool builders, such as fiberglass versus concrete. Builders of fiberglass pools often faced criticism from their concrete and vinyl counterparts, which prompted potential customers to

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question the advantages of fiberglass pools over others.

The Mistake of Ignoring Key Questions

Initially, many businesses, including Sheridan's fiberglass pool company, avoided addressing frequent customer inquiries about the advantages of fiberglass pools. This led to lost business opportunities and wasted time, as those potential customers sought information elsewhere, often leading to confusion and mistrust.

Shift in Business Philosophy

Upon embracing the "They Ask You Answer" philosophy, Sheridan's company realized the necessity of addressing these pertinent questions directly on their website. This included creating unbiased content comparing fiberglass, vinyl liner, and concrete pools in a detailed article titled "Fiberglass Pools vs. Vinyl Liner Pools vs. Concrete Pools: An Honest Comparison."

Consumer-Driven Content

The response to this content was overwhelmingly positive,

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leading to increased web traffic and improved consumer trust. It became clear that when businesses openly discuss their competition and potential weaknesses, they can attract more informed customers and reduce the number of poor-fit prospects.

The Results of Transparency

Following the publication of the comparison article, search engines rewarded the company, positioning it as a top result for relevant search terms. This strategy not only generated significant revenue but also established the company as a trusted voice in the industry.

Action Steps for Businesses

Businesses are encouraged to document comparison-based questions they receive from prospects and customers. This could encompass products, brands, methods, or any relevant subjects. By addressing these inquiries transparently across digital marketing channels—such as blog posts, e-books, and webinars—companies can earn consumer trust and enhance their market presence.

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Chapter 18 Summary : The Critical Need for Unbiased Content

The Critical Need for Unbiased Content

Introduction

- Addressing customer comparison-based questions is crucial in building trust.
- The notion that businesses can't address these questions effectively due to perceived bias is incorrect.

Understanding Consumer Perceptions

- Consumers genuinely want to know business perspectives; they wouldn't ask if they didn't care.
- Businesses often overemphasize their strengths, leading to distrust.

Building Trust through Transparency

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- A practical example involves comparing fiberglass, concrete, and vinyl-liner pools.
- A successful method involves openly discussing the pros and cons, highlighting that fiberglass may not be the best fit for everyone.

Disarmament Principle

- Similar to negotiating in sensitive situations, sales communication must prioritize transparency to earn trust.
- Addressing potential biases early in discussions (such as acknowledging the company's preference for fiberglass pools) fosters an honest dialogue.

Importance of Being Unbiased

- Businesses should not shy away from addressing competitors and potential drawbacks to their offerings.

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Chapter 19 Summary : Content Subjects 4 and 5 Reviews and Best in Class

Section	Summary
Chapter Overview	This chapter discusses the importance of reviews and ranking content in shaping consumer purchasing decisions, based on Marcus Sheridan's experience with River Pools and Spas.
Identifying the Gap in the Market	Recognizing the absence of consumer guides for comparing pool manufacturers led to the creation of the "Best Fiberglass Pool Design Awards" article, enhancing engagement with consumers and manufacturers.
Impact of Reviews and Rankings	The published rankings changed industry perceptions, receiving positive feedback from manufacturers and becoming an essential marketing tool that built authority and trust for River Pools.
Successful Implementation	Continuously producing content that ranked pool designs helped River Pools dominate search engine results, driving significant traffic and generating millions in additional sales through effective SEO strategies.
Conclusion	The chapter emphasizes the need for businesses to create transparent, unbiased content to build trusted relationships and increase sales by addressing consumer needs and breaking conventional marketing norms.

Chapter 19 Summary: Content Subjects 4 and 5: Reviews and Best in Class

This chapter emphasizes an unconventional approach to business and consumer education, focusing on the significance of reviews and ranking content. It highlights the consumer's obsession with comparisons and the desire for reviews, which drive purchasing decisions. The author recounts his experience with River Pools and Spas, realizing that there was no authoritative source ranking manufacturers in the fiberglass pool industry, similar to platforms like Yelp

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or awards like Motor Trend's Car of the Year.

Identifying the Gap in the Market

- Acknowledging the lack of consumer guides for comparing pool manufacturers led to the innovative idea of producing a “Best Fiberglass Pool Design Awards” article.
- Spending hours studying different designs and crafting a structured ranking system fostered engagement with both consumers and industry manufacturers.

Impact of Reviews and Rankings

- Publishing the rankings changed perceptions within the industry, garnering unexpected responses from manufacturers, some of whom thanked the author while others sought personal consultation.
- The article did not just gain attention; it became a pivotal marketing tool, building authority and trust for River Pools among consumers.

Successful Implementation

- Continuous creation of similar content further solidified

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River Pools' online presence. Articles ranking pool designs consistently appeared at the top of search engine results, driving significant web traffic and establishing the brand as a resource for consumers.

- Keywords related to pool costs and design became top search terms leading potential buyers to the company, ultimately generating millions in additional sales.

Conclusion

The chapter reinforces that businesses must adapt to consumer needs by creating transparent, unbiased content that addresses common questions and concerns, leading to trusted relationships and increased sales. By breaking conventional marketing norms and openly discussing pricing, problems, and product comparisons, companies can effectively build authority in their industries.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: The importance of transparency in consumer education and building trust

Critical Interpretation: Marcus Sheridan's assertion that businesses should openly discuss reviews and comparisons as a means to foster consumer trust merits scrutiny. While this approach can promote transparency and engagement, it's essential to recognize that not all companies may achieve the same results, as differing markets and consumer behaviors can impact effectiveness. Furthermore, critics might argue that prioritizing rankings can lead to bias or manipulation, hence it's vital to consider various case studies on consumer behavior, such as those found in 'Contagious: How to Build Word of Mouth in the Digital Age' by Jonah Berger, to form a more comprehensive understanding of the dynamics at play.

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Chapter 20 Summary : Using Reviews to Establish Yourself as an Expert

Using Reviews to Establish Yourself as an Expert

In this chapter, the focus shifts to an unconventional strategy for building brand authority through review-based content. Marcus Sheridan reflects on a common sales scenario where potential clients inquire about alternative recommendations. Instead of responding defensively, he emphasizes the importance of answering such questions openly to build trust. After a disappointing sales meeting where a prospect asked for other pool builders, Sheridan decided to create a value-driven article titled “Who are the Best Pool Builders in Richmond, Virginia (Reviews/Ratings)”. Notably, he did not include his own company, River Pools and Spas, on that list. He explains that self-promotion in such contexts can erode credibility and trust.

By writing an honest review of competitors, Sheridan aimed to convey transparency and expertise. He argues that potential customers prefer to make their own judgments based on insights and facts rather than being told how great a

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company is. Through honest dialogue and openness about competition, businesses can position themselves as industry leaders and enhance their reputation. This approach aligns well with the core principles of content marketing—trust, honesty, and transparency.

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Example

Key Point: Transparency Builds Trust

Example: Imagine you're searching for a reliable pool builder for your backyard oasis, but instead of the usual self-serving claims, you come across a candid article that openly reviews various pool manufacturers, including both the positives and negatives of each. This piece not only includes River Pools and Spas, the author's company but highlights other builders that might better suit your needs. By doing so, the author has placed trust in you as a potential customer to make the best decision for yourself, demonstrating their confidence, expertise, and commitment to transparency in a competitive market.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: Establishing authority through competitor reviews can be beneficial.

Critical Interpretation: While Marcus Sheridan argues that openly discussing competitors in a review can enhance credibility and trust, it is essential to acknowledge that this approach may not work universally. Some businesses might find that such transparency does not yield the expected results or may even backfire if competitors misinterpret the intent. Moreover, the effectiveness of using competitor mentions in reviews to build authority depends on various factors, such as industry norms and consumer behavior. For instance, research has suggested that consumers often rely on self-promotional content to gauge expertise (B2B Marketing, 2021), indicating that some potential customers might prefer direct endorsements rather than comparative assessments. Therefore, while Sheridan's method offers an innovative perspective, it should be critically evaluated within the context of each unique business environment.

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Chapter 21 Summary : The Impact of Discussing the Competition

The Impact of Discussing the Competition

In this chapter, Marcus Sheridan recounts the profound effects of addressing competition in the pool construction industry through content marketing. His article titled "Who Are the Best Pool Builders in Richmond, Virginia (Reviews/Ratings)" consistently ranks first on Google for relevant searches, significantly improving visibility for his company, River Pools and Spas.

When potential customers researched competitors like Pla-Mor Pools, they often ended up on Sheridan's website, where they could access unbiased information. This approach not only answered common questions but also built trust with consumers, leading to substantial sales increases — one article alone generated \$150,000 in sales within its publication year.

Sheridan emphasizes the importance of transparency in consumer trust, arguing that ignorance is no longer a viable marketing strategy. Buyers will eventually discover

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information about competitors, so businesses should proactively provide clear and honest comparisons. The chapter highlights a story of a customer who initially considered Pla-Mor Pools but ended up choosing River Pools after reading Sheridan's forthright content. The key takeaway is that addressing competition can be an opportunity rather than a threat, as it facilitates discussions and builds customer relationships.

Putting It Into Action

1.

Create Review-Based Content

: Write articles comparing your business to competitors without disregarding their strengths.

2.

Be Transparent

: Acknowledge competitors, their offerings, and where you

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Chapter 22 Summary : Case Study 3

Small Retail Appliance Store Dominates Online and Makes Millions

Case Study: Yale Appliance's Success Story

Overview

In the competitive kitchen appliance market, you might assume major manufacturers like General Electric or Whirlpool lead the way. Surprisingly, the biggest thought leader is Yale Appliance, a regional retail store in Boston, Massachusetts, which has thrived since 1923.

Longevity through Consumer Focus

Yale Appliance has weathered tough economic challenges by listening to consumer needs and preferences. CEO Steve Sheinkopf embraced content marketing after attending the In Planet conference in 2004. He recognized the potential of using insightful content to manage online reputation and

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influence consumer conversations.

Embracing Content Marketing

In 2007, Sheinkopf launched a business blog to gain control over appliance-related conversations online. After initially seeing slight positive results, economic recession compelled him to refine his marketing strategies. This included exploring content marketing opportunities which were measurable and provided better returns than traditional advertising.

Transformation through Education

Sheinkopf adopted a customer-first approach, focusing on transparency and educating consumers about products. He emphasized producing informative content rather than promoting sales-driven narratives, which led to greater trust and engagement from potential buyers.

The Big 5 Content Strategy

Yale Appliance honed their marketing efforts around five essential content themes—cost and pricing, problems,

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comparisons, reviews, and best-in-class insights. This strategic focus helped them answer consumer questions directly and earn trust.

Measurable Success

The results were significant: Yale Appliance's digital presence exploded, doubling their web traffic, sales, and customer engagement year over year since 2011. Sheinkopf's commitment to effective content led to the opening of a second retail location without additional advertising expenditure.

In Summary

Yale Appliance showcases how focusing on customer education and transparency through content marketing can yield dramatic results, setting them apart in a landscape dominated by larger competitors. By answering consumer questions, embracing feedback, and promoting honest information, they have built a strong, trusted brand in the appliance industry.

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Example

Key Point: Embracing Customer Education and Transparency

Example: Imagine walking into a store seeking a new refrigerator. Instead of being bombarded with sales pitches, you encounter knowledgeable staff who prioritize sharing helpful information about energy efficiency, maintenance tips, and model comparisons. This focus on education not only empowers you to make informed choices but also builds trust in the brand, as you feel they genuinely care about your needs rather than just making a sale. This is the essence of Yale Appliance's success—by prioritizing customer education and maintaining transparency, they created a loyal customer base and stood out against larger competitors.

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Chapter 23 Summary : The Competition

Chapter 23: The Competition, The Bad Fits, The Customer

In this chapter, Marcus Sheridan emphasizes the importance of understanding three main factors that influence a company's willingness to adopt a consumer-centric approach to marketing and sales:

the competition

,

the bad fits

, and

the customer

. He introduces the concept of "The Triangle of Influence," illustrating how these groups impact business strategies.

The Competition

The competition is the most significant influence on what businesses choose to discuss or avoid, especially in terms of addressing key consumer questions. Sheridan reflects on how many companies fear transparency due to the competitive

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landscape, which can cause them to miss out on building trust with potential customers. He encourages businesses to openly discuss pricing and product issues despite the risk of competitors reacting to this information.

The Bad Fits

The second influential group consists of potential customers who are not a good fit for the business. Many companies often let the fear of scaring these prospects away dictate their communication strategies. Sheridan argues that recognizing and accepting that not everyone is a suitable customer is vital for long-term happiness in a business. He champions the idea that businesses should educate consumers on why they may not be the best fit, thereby saving time and effort for both parties.

The Customer

Lastly, the actual customers should be the primary focus for businesses. Ironically, they are often overlooked in favor of other influencing groups. Sheridan emphasizes that businesses should prioritize consumer needs and maintain transparency to foster trust and loyalty.

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Throughout the chapter, Sheridan illustrates these points with personal anecdotes from his experience with River Pools and Spas, showcasing how embracing honesty and openness ultimately led to success and trust building.

In summary, Sheridan's advice centers on overcoming the reluctance to address competition, acknowledging and managing bad-fit customers, and wholly focusing efforts on actual customers to enhance business success.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point:Emphasizing Transparency

Critical Interpretation:While Marcus Sheridan insists on the essential nature of transparency in business marketing strategies, it is critical to recognize that an approach prioritizing customer needs above all might not be universally applicable. For some industries, hyper-transparency, particularly regarding pricing and competitors, may lead to diminishing returns or competitive disadvantages, possibly resulting in severe setbacks. Competitors could leverage this openness to outmaneuver a company, highlighting an industry-specific caution against embracing his viewpoint wholeheartedly (Jones, 2019; Smith & Brown, 2020). Furthermore, businesses might face backlash from customers who, driven by misconceptions, may misinterpret transparency initiatives as a lack of security or quality commitment. Hence, while Sheridan provides valuable insights, it is invariably prudent for companies to evaluate their unique contexts and challenges before fully adopting this 'customer-centric' paradigm.

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Chapter 24 Summary : How They Ask, You Answer Saved River Pools and Spas

Chapter 24 Summary: How They Ask You Answer Saved River Pools and Spas

Impact of Content Marketing

In March 2009, River Pools and Spas faced potential business collapse. After discovering inbound and content marketing, they embraced the "They Ask, You Answer" methodology, compiling every customer question to create informative articles and videos.

Initial Struggles and Growth

Initially, the company received around 2,000 visitors monthly from paid ads, spending \$500 every two days on this traffic. However, three months into content creation, organic traffic doubled, enabling survival through the challenging financial year of 2009. By 2010, traffic and leads

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surged, leading to increased sales.

Traffic and Sales Milestones

The peak traffic months recorded significant growth, reaching 600,000 visitors by 2016, making River Pools and Spas the most trafficked swimming pool website globally. This growth prompted the company to start manufacturing pools, aiming to become the largest fiberglass pool manufacturer within the next five to seven years.

Advertising and Revenue Contrast

In 2007, the company generated \$4 million with a \$250,000 advertising budget. By 2014, they increased their revenue to \$5.5 million, spending just \$20,000 on marketing, demonstrating the effectiveness of content marketing strategies.

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Chapter 25 Summary : How Great Content Is a Total Game-Changer for Sales Teams

Chapter	Content Summary
Chapter 25: How Great Content Is a Total Game-Changer for Sales Teams	Marcus Sheridan discusses the integration of content marketing into sales teams using the "They Ask, You Answer" philosophy. Successful integration requires alignment between leadership, marketing, and sales. Key points include understanding buyers, content as practice, serving as a training resource, fostering "assignment selling," gaining deeper buyer insights, building trust, and shortening sales cycles. Embracing this philosophy leads to better sales processes and organizational alignment, fostering a culture of trust and efficiency.
1. Understanding Buyers	Enhances empathetic engagement by understanding buyer motivations and needs.
2. Content as Practice	Hones messaging and communication skills of sales representatives.
3. Training Resource	Serves as a guide for training, aligning sales practices with customer-centric communication.
4. Assignment Selling	Cultivates a culture of sharing educational materials during the buying journey.
5. Deeper Buyer Insights	Allows tailoring approaches based on prospect's online behavior through analytics.
6. Building Relationships of Trust	Establishes trust through valuable information even before initial contact.
7. Shorter Sales Cycles	Trust and education through content lead to reduced sales cycles and happier sales teams.

Chapter 25: How Great Content Is a Total Game-Changer for Sales Teams

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In this chapter, Marcus Sheridan emphasizes the importance of integrating content marketing into sales teams, particularly using the "They Ask, You Answer" philosophy. For this integration to be successful, alignment among leadership, marketing, and sales teams is essential. Understanding the "what, how, and why" of this strategy is crucial for salespeople and their organizations.

Seven Major Benefits of Sales Teams Embracing They Ask, You Answer

1.

Understanding Buyers

: Creating content compels sales teams to better understand buyer motivations, concerns, and needs, enhancing their empathetic engagement during the sales process.

2.

Content as Practice

: Content production provides valuable practice for sales representatives, honing their messaging and communication skills to effectively engage prospects.

3.

Training Resource

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: Content created serves as a guide for training the sales team, establishing a cohesive company doctrine that aligns sales practices with customer-centric communication.

4.

Assignment Selling

: The integration of content into sales creates a culture of “assignment selling,” where prospects receive educational, targeted materials throughout their buying journey.

5.

Deeper Buyer Insights

: Sales teams can utilize analytics to gain insights into prospect behavior, allowing them to tailor their approach based on a potential customer’s online activity.

6.

Building Relationships of Trust

: By providing valuable information through content, salespeople can establish trust with prospects even before the initial contact, leading to a smoother sales experience.

7.

Shorter Sales Cycles

: A foundation of trust and education built through content can shorten sales cycles, resulting in happier sales teams with more time for qualified leads.

In summary, embracing the content-driven philosophy of

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"They Ask, You Answer" can transform sales processes, create alignment within organizations, and ultimately lead to greater success. Implementing this approach helps foster a culture of trust, understanding, and efficiency, thereby enhancing the overall effectiveness of sales teams.

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Chapter 26 Summary : A Dramatic Discovery

Dramatic Discovery

Introduction to Website Engagement

- The author poses a crucial question about website engagement, asking how many pages potential customers would typically read before deciding to do business.
- The common response is “two or three pages,” suggesting that businesses undervalue the time prospects are willing to invest in gathering information.

The 2012 Discovery

- In 2012, the author conducted research comparing two groups of leads from their swimming pool company.
- One group filled out a quote form but didn't make a purchase, while the second group did buy after filling out the same form.

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Key Finding: The Power of Content Consumption

- The author discovered that those who read thirty or more pages of the website had an 80% purchase rate, compared to just 20% for those who read fewer pages.
- This statistic highlighted a significant correlation between content engagement and sales success.

Understanding Trust and Qualification

- Every piece of content consumed contributes to building trust and self-qualification among prospects.
- Engagement can be likened to dating, where multiple “dates” (or content consumed) lead to a clearer understanding of compatibility and interest in moving forward.

Implications for Sales Strategy

- The realization that increasing content consumption could dramatically improve closing rates led to a reevaluation of the sales process.
- The author encourages readers to consider how they might adjust their strategies if they knew that getting prospects to

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engage with thirty pieces of content would lead to high conversion rates.

Conclusion: Assignment Selling

- The insights garnered from this discovery lead to the introduction of the concept of assignment selling, which is to be further explored.

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Chapter 27 Summary : Assignment Selling

27. Assignment Selling

The Importance of Active Content Marketing

Just posting content on your website is insufficient for achieving marketing success. Businesses must actively engage their prospects and customers to ensure they consume the content, which can significantly impact sales.

Definition of Assignment Selling

Assignment selling is the intentional use of created content—whether text, video, or audio—to educate prospects regarding products and services. This process aims to address their major concerns, making them more prepared for sales meetings.

Example of Assignment Selling

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A swimming pool company transformed its sales approach by educating prospects before appointments. This involved sending educational resources like videos and e-books to prospects to prepare them, ensuring more productive meetings.

The Rights of the Teacher

By providing information and value, businesses earn the authority to ask prospects for engagement, which can feel audacious but ultimately enhances trust and readiness to buy.

Dealing with Obstacles

Challenges like a prospect's lack of time to review provided content can be tackled by emphasizing the benefits of being educated before making significant purchases. leading to

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Chapter 28 Summary : How One Remarkable Couple Changed My Perspective on the Power of Content to Sell

Chapter 28: How One Remarkable Couple Changed My Perspective on the Power of Content to Sell

Introduction to Content's Impact on Sales

The chapter explores the significant role of content in the sales process by recounting a personal experience that transformed the author's perspective on how customers engage with information before making buying decisions.

Mr. G's Extraordinary Engagement

Five years ago, while reviewing leads for his swimming pool website, the author discovered a lead from a man named Mr. G, who had viewed an astonishing 374 pages of their content after searching for "cost of a fiberglass swimming pool."

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This unprecedented engagement raised the author's curiosity and led to assumptions about Mr. G's intentions.

Mrs. G and Their Combined Research

The next lead was from Mrs. G, Mr. G's wife, who also researched swimming pools and viewed over 140 pages. Together, they consumed over 500 pages of content, showcasing an extraordinary commitment to understanding their potential purchase.

The Sales Appointment

The following day, the author met with Mr. G, who arrived well-prepared with a spreadsheet detailing his desired pool model and accessories. The author realized that his role was minimal, as Mr. G was already 99.9% decided. The meeting resulted in a \$5,000 deposit and a signed contract.

Lessons Learned about Consumer Behavior

This experience revealed that consumers actively seek information to feel comfortable with their purchasing decisions. The author emphasized that his selling efforts were

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minimal, highlighting the value of providing comprehensive, honest, and transparent content.

Conclusion: The Power of Content in Sales

The memorable appointment with the Gs underscored a critical lesson: effective content is the most powerful sales tool available today, enabling consumers to confidently approach buying decisions. This insight resonates across various industries, proving the importance of content in modern sales strategies.

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Chapter 29 Summary : Content Never Sleeps

Content Never Sleeps

Introduction

The assertion that "content is the greatest sales tool in the world" may seem bold, but it can be substantiated through its limitless potential versus the limitations of human salespeople.

The Power of Content

- Content has the ability to educate countless people simultaneously, unlike salespeople who can only reach those physically present.
- It operates 24/7, making it a tireless employee that doesn't demand raises or time off.
- Evergreen content can generate revenue long after publication, as seen with past articles that continue to attract

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customers.

My Sales Journey

- In 2007, I conducted 250 sales appointments to sell 75 pools, working over 60 hours a week with minimal family time.
- After implementing content-driven sales strategies, by 2013, I sold 95 pools with only 120 appointments, achieving a 79% closing rate.

Consumer Behavior Shift

- Customers now engage deeply with content, reading an average of 105 pages before making a purchase, contrary to past beliefs about customer engagement.
- This shift in behavior reflects broader trends across industries and demonstrates the effectiveness of a content strategy.

Impact on Sales Team

- Less skilled salespeople now achieve better results, going on fewer appointments yet closing more sales, which

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conserves time.

- The saved time allows salespeople to focus on developing meaningful relationships and pursuing personal interests.

Conclusion

The key takeaway is that content not only drives leads and sales but also significantly enriches the lives of employees by providing them with more time. Enhancing employee morale and culture ultimately leads to a positive impact in the business landscape.

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Chapter 30 Summary : Using Assignment Selling to Avoid Common Sales Pitfalls

Using Assignment Selling to Avoid Common Sales Pitfalls

Introduction to Assignment Selling

Chapter 30 of "They Ask You Answer" discusses the implementation of assignment selling as a strategy to mitigate common sales mistakes. It describes a typical scenario where a salesperson sends a follow-up email after not hearing back from a prospect, often phrased in a pleading manner that does little to advance the sales conversation.

The Ineffectiveness of Typical Follow-Ups

The author highlights how traditional follow-up emails can sound desperate and unproductive, akin to asking if the prospect still "loves" them. This approach is often ineffective

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as it does not bring value to the conversation or address the prospect's real concerns.

The Power of Assignment Selling

In contrast, a follow-up grounded in assignment selling is framed around offering additional resources (like videos or articles) that address specific questions or concerns raised by the prospect during previous discussions. This method:

1. Reassures the prospect by reminding them that their concerns are acknowledged and addressed.
2. Positions the salesperson as an expert who can guide the prospect through their decision-making process.

Encouraging Prospect Engagement

Using assignment selling prompts responses from prospects, which can be either positive or indicate disinterest. This

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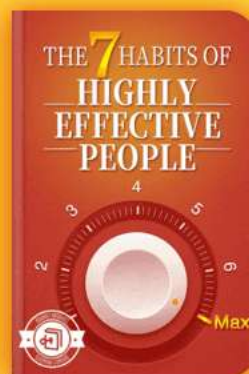
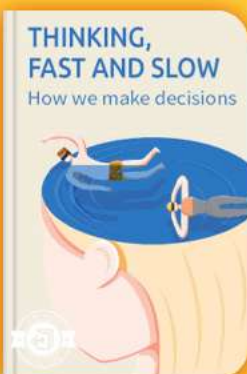


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Chapter 31 Summary : Using Assignment Selling to Determine Compatibility

Using Assignment Selling to Determine Compatibility

Introduction to Assignment Selling

The Sales Lion, a digital sales and marketing agency, employs an assignment selling process to ensure only compatible prospects are engaged. This process is crucial due to the high volume of leads received, and it focuses on qualifying clients before discussions occur.

E-Book Requirement for Prospects

To balance the prospect's understanding of services offered, the agency requires that any potential client reads their comprehensive 200-page e-book, "Inbound and Content Marketing Made Easy," before scheduling a consultation.

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This requirement sets a foundation for more informed and productive conversations.

Communication Strategy

Upon contact from a prospect, the agency responds with an email that emphasizes the benefits of reading the e-book, framed as a way to improve the upcoming conversation. This approach contrasts with a more presumptive tone about qualifying leads, showing a commitment to a mutually beneficial relationship.

Disarming Prospects

The response also embodies the principle of disarmament, allowing prospects to feel empowered in deciding if they align with the agency. This strategy subtly directs the focus on the agency's assessment of compatibility while making the prospect believe they have control over their buying decision.

Results of the Approach

Contrary to concerns about lengthy e-book reading deterring

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prospects, those who are genuinely interested often engage positively. Reading the e-book tends to filter out unsuitable prospects and lead to shorter, more meaningful sales cycles with those who appreciate the agency's philosophies.

Key Principles of Assignment Selling

1.

Teaching Opportunity

: Every sales email should provide valuable content, making it a learning moment for prospects.

2.

Content Awareness

: Sales teams must be well-versed in the content being produced and used in the selling process to ensure a cohesive strategy.

Conclusion

The implementation of assignment selling proves beneficial across various industries, promoting alignment between sales and marketing departments for mutual success without operational silos. The next chapter will delve deeper into the significance of this alignment.

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Chapter 32 Summary : Case Study 4

How a Start-Up Company in the Health Care Space Became the Thought Leaders of an Entirely New Industry

Summary of Chapter 32: Case Study 4 - How a Start-Up Company in the Health Care Space Became the Thought Leaders of an Entirely New Industry

Introduction

In this chapter, we explore the unique journey of Health Catalyst, a start-up in healthcare analytics, which carved a niche in a fledgling industry by utilizing the principles of inbound marketing and the "They Ask, You Answer" philosophy.

Background of Health Catalyst

- Founded in 2010, Health Catalyst develops infrastructure

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for healthcare organizations to identify wastage, improve patient care, and reduce costs.

- The company recognized an informational void in the online healthcare analytics sector, with no dominant voice or thought leader.

Marketing Strategy Implementation

1.

Bringing in Expertise

: Paul Horstmeier was appointed to lead sales and marketing efforts and emphasized the need for a content-driven approach.

2.

Adopting They Ask, You Answer

: Health Catalyst initiated the methodology by collaborating with the sales team to compile a list of common customer inquiries, integrating education as a key marketing component.

Phases of Execution

-

Phase 1

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: Aligning Marketing and Sales

- The company focused on leveraging the expertise of senior sales personnel to create educational content.

-

Phases 2 and 3

: Webinars and Industry Events

- They organized regular webinars and educational summits that emphasized learning over promotion, attracting hundreds of participants.

Success Metrics

- Health Catalyst quickly rose to the top in search engine rankings for targeted keywords.

- Their marketing efforts fostered collaboration across departments, encouraging a unified approach to content production.

Industry Transformation and Future Plans

- Health Catalyst positioned itself as a trusted source of unbiased information in the healthcare analytics space.

- Its commitment to educating the market led to significant growth, including exponential increases in website traffic,

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reaffirming the effectiveness of transparent marketing strategies.

Conclusion

Health Catalyst's approach illustrates how a focus on education, transparency, and responding to industry questions can lead to establishing a brand as a thought leader in a new market. Their success is a testament to the effective implementation of "They Ask, You Answer" principles, leading not only to a flourishing business but also to the transformation of industry standards in healthcare analytics.

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Chapter 33 Summary : The Power of Insourcing and Using Your Team to Create Incredible Content

The Power of Insourcing and Using Your Team to Create Incredible Content

Introduction to Content Production Challenges

Many organizations attempt inbound and content marketing by outsourcing content production to digital marketing agencies. While outsourcing can be beneficial, it often leads to challenges, particularly in accurately conveying a company's brand and story.

Limitations of Outsourcing

Agencies typically work under fixed deliverables, such as a set number of blog articles each month. This structure may restrict creativity and flexibility, preventing companies from producing content that truly reflects their brand. Successful

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companies generally operate without these constraints, allowing them to create more diverse and abundant content.

The Benefits of Insourcing

Insourcing, or utilizing existing employees to produce content, fosters a deeper understanding of the brand and sales messaging. Although this may lead to slower initial results due to the learning curve, the long-term outcomes are often significantly better. Insourced content is typically a more genuine reflection of the company.

Collaboration Between Sales and Marketing

For effective content production, it is essential that the sales team actively participates in the content creation process. This collaboration ensures that the messaging aligns with what prospects and customers expect, reinforcing brand

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Chapter 34 Summary : How Block Imaging Embraced a Culture of Insourcing

Summary of Chapter 34: How Block Imaging Embraced a Culture of Insourcing

Block Imaging's Journey

Krista Kotrla aimed to revitalize Block Imaging by implementing the principles of “They Ask, You Answer” to not only save the business but also to position it as a leader in medical imaging equipment. However, she faced resistance from sales and leadership, with common excuses being a lack of time and dismissal of responsibility.

Overcoming Organizational Silos

Both excuses illustrate a disconnect in recognizing the value of the proposed changes. Time is not a true barrier; rather, it reveals priorities. Those within organizations often fail to

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understand that modern sales and marketing dynamics have shifted. Krista's struggle is mirrored by many marketing professionals who seek buy-in from management and sales teams.

Eliminating Silos through Unified Vision

A pervasive issue is the disconnect between marketing and sales, where each department fails to work collaboratively, thus missing critical insights and contributions from each other. Krista recognized the need for every team member to participate in the content creation process, fostering a culture where everyone's voice and expertise matter.

Implementing Content Marketing Workshops

Marcus Sheridan's engagement at Block Imaging represented a pivotal moment where all departments could align under the teaching philosophy and understand their role as educators in the industry. This buy-in led to a collective effort to produce valuable content that contributed to the company's digital presence.

Impact of Insourcing

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The transformation at Block Imaging resulted in over fifty employees producing numerous articles and videos, reinforcing the idea that everyone can contribute to content creation. This embraced a culture of teamwork, eliminating silos and enhancing overall organizational productivity.

Measurable Results

By creating a unified team focused on teaching and education, Block Imaging saw significant revenue growth attributed directly to their content and marketing strategies. Krista reported \$20 million in sales directly tied to the efforts of insourcing and embracing content marketing.

Conclusion

The narrative of Block Imaging illustrates the importance of recognizing the value of every employee's contribution to the company's success and highlights the necessity of collaboration across departments. By insourcing content efforts, Block Imaging established itself as an industry leader, ultimately seeing substantial financial returns and fostering a strong company culture.

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Key Takeaways

- Time management is closely tied to perceived value in organizations.
- Silo mentality hinders growth; collaboration is crucial for success.
- Embracing a culture of content and transparency leads to trust and revenue growth.
- Insourcing enables all employees to contribute to content, enhancing overall corporate success.

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Chapter 35 Summary : Starting Off They Ask, You Answer with a Bang Company Workshops

Chapter 35: Starting Off They Ask, You Answer with a Bang - Company Workshops

In this chapter, the importance of workshops in fostering a culture that incorporates the "They Ask, You Answer" methodology is emphasized. The author emphasizes that building a strong content marketing culture requires more than just sending out emails or making announcements. Workshops can provide a unified vision and kickstart the transformation within an organization, allowing employees to understand the essential principles of content marketing.

Key Principles to Focus On

1.

Consumer Expectations Have Changed

: Attendees must adopt a “consumer” mindset to appreciate how their expectations have shifted regarding online

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information and sourcing.

2.

The Way Google and Other Search Engines Work

: Understanding that Google's goal is to provide the best answers for users' queries helps align content marketing strategies with consumer needs.

3.

The Way Consumers Search and the Big 5

: Focusing on five critical subjects—Pricing and Costs, Problems, Comparisons, Reviews, and Best in Class—can address the main queries consumers have.

4.

Group Brainstorm of Content Ideas

: Workshops should encourage brainstorming sessions to generate ideas based on common questions prospects ask daily.

5.

The Impact Content Can Have on Sales Process and Closing Rates

: Highlighting the significant role content plays in shortening sales cycles and enhancing lead quality will motivate team participation.

6.

Everyone's Voice, Talents, and Knowledge Are

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Critical for Success

: Marketing should not solely be the voice of the company; employees are valuable content contributors due to their expertise and interactions with customers.

7.

The Editorial Guidelines Going Forward

: Establish clear guidelines for how content is produced and expectations for involvement from team members.

8.

A Look into the Future

: Conclude the workshop with a recap of the principles and foster discussions on potential challenges in implementing the newfound culture.

The ultimate goal of these workshops is to create a cohesive understanding among employees that enables them to become trusted educators rather than traditional salespeople. This shift not only enhances customer experiences but significantly increases sales outcomes by ensuring that businesses are addressing the concerns and questions of their markets effectively.

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Chapter 36 Summary : The Content Manager Qualities, Hiring, and More

The Content Manager Qualities, Hiring, and More

Someone Must Own It

To successfully embrace content marketing and the philosophy of "They Ask, You Answer," an organization must have someone dedicated to owning this effort. This role can go by various titles such as Chief Content Officer, Content Marketing Manager, or Inbound Marketing Manager, but the essential requirement is existence within the organization.

Duties of a Content Manager (per Week)

A content manager's typical week may include:

- Producing at least three new pieces of content (5–15 hours)
- Managing company email marketing (1–3 hours)
- Analyzing site metrics, SEO, etc. (3–5 hours)

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- Engaging on social media (1–2 hours)
- Creating premium content (eBooks, webinars, etc.) (3–5 hours)
- Enhancing the website (2–4 hours)
- Continuous education (3–5 hours)
- Collaborating with the sales team (2–4 hours)

These responsibilities emphasize the significant time commitment required for effective content management.

Choosing the Right Leader of Your Content Marketing Efforts

When hiring a content manager, ensure they possess essential qualities such as a passion for writing, editing skills, the ability to conduct interviews, social media proficiency, video editing skills, and others that contribute to a successful content marketing strategy.

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I've learned. Highly recommend!

Alex Walk

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Chapter 37 Summary : On the Importance of Tools Measuring Return on Investment, the Power of HubSpot, and More

Section	Summary
Business Philosophy and ROI Measurement	"They Ask, You Answer" focuses on listening to customer needs, generating relevant content, and addressing marketplace problems while measuring ROI through the right tools.
The Role of HubSpot and Digital Marketing Tools	HubSpot enhances marketing efficiency by tracking efforts, lead behavior, and optimizing SEO, leading to better-informed marketing decisions and increased revenue.
Key Benefits of Using HubSpot	Continuous ROI Measurement: Identify revenue-driving leads and sales sources. Lead Behavior Tracking: Understand lead interactions with content. SEO Tracking: Monitor and adjust keyword strategies. Website Testing: Optimize elements for better conversion rates.
Valuing Educational Content	Creating educational content builds credibility and strengthens customer relationships by addressing industry questions.
The Power of Assignment Selling	Sales personnel provide educational content to prospects before meetings, enhancing the buyer's experience and increasing sales closure rates.
Creating a Culture of Learning	Companies should encourage employee involvement in content creation to ensure alignment with organizational expertise and values.
Conclusion: Long-Term Impact	Applying these principles can improve revenue, customer relations, and market position; using tools like HubSpot enhances measurement of digital marketing effectiveness.

Chapter 37: On the Importance of Tools Measuring Return on Investment, the Power of HubSpot, and More

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Business Philosophy and ROI Measurement

"They Ask, You Answer" is a business philosophy that emphasizes the importance of listening to customer questions, providing relevant content, and solving marketplace problems. To implement this successfully, organizations must prioritize shared buy-in, departmental alignment, clear vision, and the generation of quality content. A central question that businesses need to address is whether their efforts yield monetary returns, highlighting the necessity of measuring Return on Investment (ROI) through proper tools.

The Role of HubSpot and Digital Marketing Tools

Marcus Sheridan discusses how HubSpot transformed his business by enabling effective tracking of marketing efforts. The tool provides insights for measuring ROI, tracking lead behavior, and optimizing SEO. This leads to informed decisions that enhance marketing effectiveness, ultimately translating into increased revenue.

Key Benefits of Using HubSpot

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1.

Continuous ROI Measurement

: Businesses can trace the origin of leads and sales to specific pages or content, allowing precise evaluation of what drives revenue.

2.

Lead Behavior Tracking

: Detailed insights on how leads interact with content help sales teams connect better with prospects.

3.

SEO Tracking

: Businesses can monitor their keyword rankings and adjust strategies accordingly.

4.

Website Testing

: Advanced analytics enable testing different elements of a website to enhance conversion rates.

Valuing Educational Content

Educational content not only serves as a marketing asset but also facilitates a deeper understanding of customers' needs. Organizations that produce content addressing common

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industry questions can significantly enhance their credibility, leading to better customer relationships and increased sales.

The Power of Assignment Selling

"Assignment selling" is a strategy where sales personnel equip prospects with educational content prior to meetings. This approach ensures that leads are informed, enriching the buyer's journey and resulting in higher sales closure rates.

Creating a Culture of Learning

For successful implementation of the "They Ask, You Answer" strategy, companies must foster a culture that values insourcing content creation. Involving employees in content production ensures that the produced material truly reflects the organization's expertise and values.

Conclusion: Long-Term Impact

The consistent application of these principles can dramatically improve a company's revenue, customer relationships, and overall market standing. Organizations are encouraged to adopt tools like HubSpot to measure their

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effectiveness and ensure their digital marketing strategies generate tangible outcomes. By fostering a culture that embraces content marketing, businesses can become trusted authorities in their respective fields.

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Chapter 38 Summary : How Do I Find More Time to Make This Work within My Organization?

Chapter 38: Finding Time for Content Marketing in Your Organization

Introduction

Companies often struggle to find time for content marketing, hindering their success. However, effective strategies exist to produce content more efficiently.

Transforming Emails into Blog Posts

Every email answering customer questions can turn into a blog post. Many businesses generate ample content through daily correspondences that go unused. By simply BCC'ing the marketing team on such emails, organizations can create a content reservoir and break down silos.

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Use Voice Recording for Content Creation

Business owners often communicate better verbally than in writing. Recording conversations on the go and sending them for transcription can generate quick and valuable blog posts. Interviews with experts can also yield rich content.

Team Blogathons and Videoathons

Organizing blogathons or videoathons encourages teamwork in content creation. For instance, an organization can dedicate a day for everyone to focus on producing various content types, which significantly boosts output.

Hire a Content Manager

It's crucial to appoint someone responsible for content marketing, ensuring seamless integration across teams. This individual will drive content production and align marketing strategies.

Leverage Insider Expertise

Employees who communicate with customers can create

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valuable content. Insourcing knowledge from various departments enriches content quality and provides insights that resonate with target audiences.

Tailor Communication Styles to Employees

Recognizing that employees have varied communication preferences can enhance content creation. Some may excel in writing while others may prefer video. Leveraging these strengths can improve efficiency.

Utilizing Video Content

Creating video content directly at job sites can engage audiences and answer common questions in real-time. This approach saves time and can generate substantial traffic.

Stop Inefficient Practices

Identify and eliminate marketing efforts that do not yield substantial returns. Companies need to focus on strategies that contribute to growth and discard ineffective practices.

Assessing the Core Issue: Time or Value?

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Often, when employees claim they lack time, it may stem from a lack of understanding of content marketing's value. Leaders should inspire their teams to grasp the importance of these efforts.

Conclusion

Companies can effectively find time for content marketing by utilizing existing resources, fostering teamwork, and embracing a culture of content creation. The principles of efficiency and collaboration lay the foundation for successful content marketing initiatives.

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Chapter 39 Summary : Just How Important Is Video to Inbound and Content Marketing? How Does It Relate to They Ask, You Answer?

Chapter 39: The Importance of Video in Inbound and Content Marketing

The Significance of Video

Video content is increasingly vital in inbound and content marketing, often surpassing textual content in effectiveness. Several statistics support this claim, such as:

- Including video in emails can boost click-through rates by 200–300%.
- Adding video to landing pages can increase conversion rates by 80%.
- Mobile video consumption is doubling yearly.

Given its impact on engagement and conversion, businesses must not only adopt video content but also integrate it into all aspects of their operations.

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Everyone is a Media Company

In the current digital landscape, all companies are essentially media companies. Consumers prioritize their questions and concerns over whether a business likes or utilizes video content or not. They seek transparency, answers, and visual representations of what they are purchasing.

A personal anecdote illustrates this: while shopping for a boat, the author found most manufacturers failed to engage effectively, showcasing videos focused more on brand prestige than on consumer insight.

Visual Engagement is Essential

Video must become a central part of a company's marketing strategy because, to consumers, if it can't be seen, it doesn't exist. By creating a culture that embraces visual storytelling

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The Concept



This book donation activity is rolling out together with Books For Africa. We release this project because we share the same belief as BFA: For many children in Africa, the gift of books truly is a gift of hope.

The Rule



Earn 100 points



Redeem a book



Donate to Africa

Your learning not only brings knowledge but also allows you to earn points for charitable causes! For every 100 points you earn, a book will be donated to Africa.

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Chapter 40 Summary : How Long Will It Take They Ask, You Answer to Work?

Section	Summary
Chapter Title	Chapter 40 Summary: How Long Will It Take They Ask, You Answer to Work?
Key Question	How long will it take to see results from implementing content marketing?
Importance of Culture	Establishing a culture of listening, teaching, and prompt action requires time, resources, and commitment.
Content Marketing Approach	Companies should produce 2-3 new pieces of content weekly, addressing key buyer questions with participation from all departments.
Five Stages of Content Marketing Success	Months 1-3: Hit “Publish” and Engage Sales Team - Essential content production begins. Months 2-5: Searchers and Search Engines Recognize You - Improved visibility and organic traffic result. Months 3-6: Lead Generation Begins - Increase in qualified leads as engagement grows. Months 18-36: Generate Sales and Revenue - Higher sales figures correlate with content effectiveness. Months 18+: The Snowball Effect - Momentum grows, leading to increased visibility, leads, and sales.
Overall Emphasis	Content marketing requires substantial dedication, but success typically becomes apparent within 2-3 years.

Chapter 40 Summary: How Long Will It Take They Ask, You Answer to Work?

In this chapter, the author addresses a common question from companies considering the implementation of content marketing under the philosophy of "They Ask, You Answer"—how long it will take to see results. Establishing a

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culture of listening, teaching, and prompt action requires time, resources, and commitment, but it is invaluable when executed effectively.

Doing Content Marketing the “Right” Way

The chapter outlines that successful content marketing varies significantly across companies and industries. It assumes the company is producing at least two to three new pieces of content weekly, addressing key buyer questions, and encouraging full participation across all departments, guided by a clear mission statement.

Five Stages of Content Marketing Success

1.

Months 1-3: Hit “Publish” and Get the Sales Team Engaged

- Consistent content production is essential. During this initial phase, companies begin to gain traction by producing Big 5 content addressing essential questions from customers.

2.

Months 2-5: Searchers and Search Engines Realize

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You Exist

- As companies establish a content rhythm, search engines begin to favor their content, enhancing visibility and driving increased organic traffic.

3.

Months 3-6: Finally, You Get Leads

- Content should lead to an uptick in qualified leads as potential customers increasingly engage with the website.

4.

Months 18-36: Generate Sales and Revenue

- Content marketing efforts should culminate in higher sales figures. The effectiveness of these efforts can be assessed through tracking sales back to specific content pieces.

5.

Months 18+: The Snowball is Rolling Down the Mountain

- With consistent effort, content marketing begins to yield greater momentum, resulting in a virtuous cycle of increased visibility, leads, and sales.

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Overall, the chapter emphasizes that while content marketing requires substantial dedication, success typically becomes apparent within two to three years as companies cultivate their approach to customer engagement and education.

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Chapter 41 Summary : Is Content Marketing and They Ask, You Answer Just a Fad?

Chapter 41: Is Content Marketing and They Ask, You Answer Just a Fad?

In this chapter, Marcus Sheridan addresses the skepticism surrounding content marketing, questioning whether it will still be relevant in the future as more businesses try to adopt it. He emphasizes that the misunderstanding of what content marketing truly is has led to inaction among many companies, putting them at a competitive disadvantage.

What Exactly Is Content Marketing?

Content marketing is fundamentally about earning trust through teaching. It involves using valuable information to help consumers solve their problems and addressing their questions honestly. These principles have existed for a long time but have gained prominence in the digital age, where the ability to connect and communicate effectively can determine

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a brand's success.

The Enduring Importance of Trust and Transparency

Throughout the discussion, Sheridan asserts that trust and transparency will continue to be vital to how consumers engage with businesses. Trends in consumer behavior indicate an increasing demand for companies to provide clear, honest answers to common questions, reinforcing the value of content marketing strategies.

Conclusion: A Lasting Principle

The chapter concludes that content marketing is not merely a trend; it is a fundamental principle of effective communication with consumers that will endure in the future. By focusing on teaching and addressing consumer needs, businesses can build lasting relationships and maintain relevancy in a rapidly evolving market.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: Content marketing's perceived permanence versus its future viability.

Critical Interpretation: While Sheridan posits that content marketing is an enduring principle of effective communication, one must critically evaluate whether it can truly sustain its relevance in an ever-evolving digital landscape. Critics argue that as technology and consumer behaviors shift, the strategies underpinning content marketing may need to adapt or risk becoming outdated (Bennett, R., & Rundle-Thiele, S. (2013). The role of trust in the impact of e-marketing tools on customer buying behavior.). This raises questions about the absolute nature of Sheridan's claims and highlights the necessity for businesses to remain agile in their communication strategies.

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Chapter 42 Summary : How Can I Keep My Team Engaged in the Content Production Process?

Chapter 42 Summary: How Can I Keep My Team Engaged in the Content Production Process?

In this chapter, Marcus Sheridan emphasizes the importance of fostering a creative and engaging environment for teams involved in content production. Merely instructing team members to "start blogging" is inadequate for cultivating a sustainable culture around content creation. Drawing inspiration from Krista Kotrla of Block Imaging, he presents strategies to motivate employees and ensure their consistent participation in content marketing efforts.

Ten Ways to Keep Your Employees Motivated to Participate in Content Marketing

1.

Focus on Bottom-of-the-Funnel Questions

: Addressing buyer questions that lead to sales conversions

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helps produce immediate results and content that resonates with potential customers.

2.

Recognize and Reward Team Members

: Highlight the contributions of team members and provide recognition to create an environment where individuals feel appreciated and motivated.

3.

Share Cross-Department Success Stories

: Encourage team members to share success stories in meetings, emphasizing collaboration and the positive impact of content marketing across departments.

4.

Celebrate Milestones

: Publicly recognize achievements such as articles reaching a certain number of views, which fosters an atmosphere of accomplishment.

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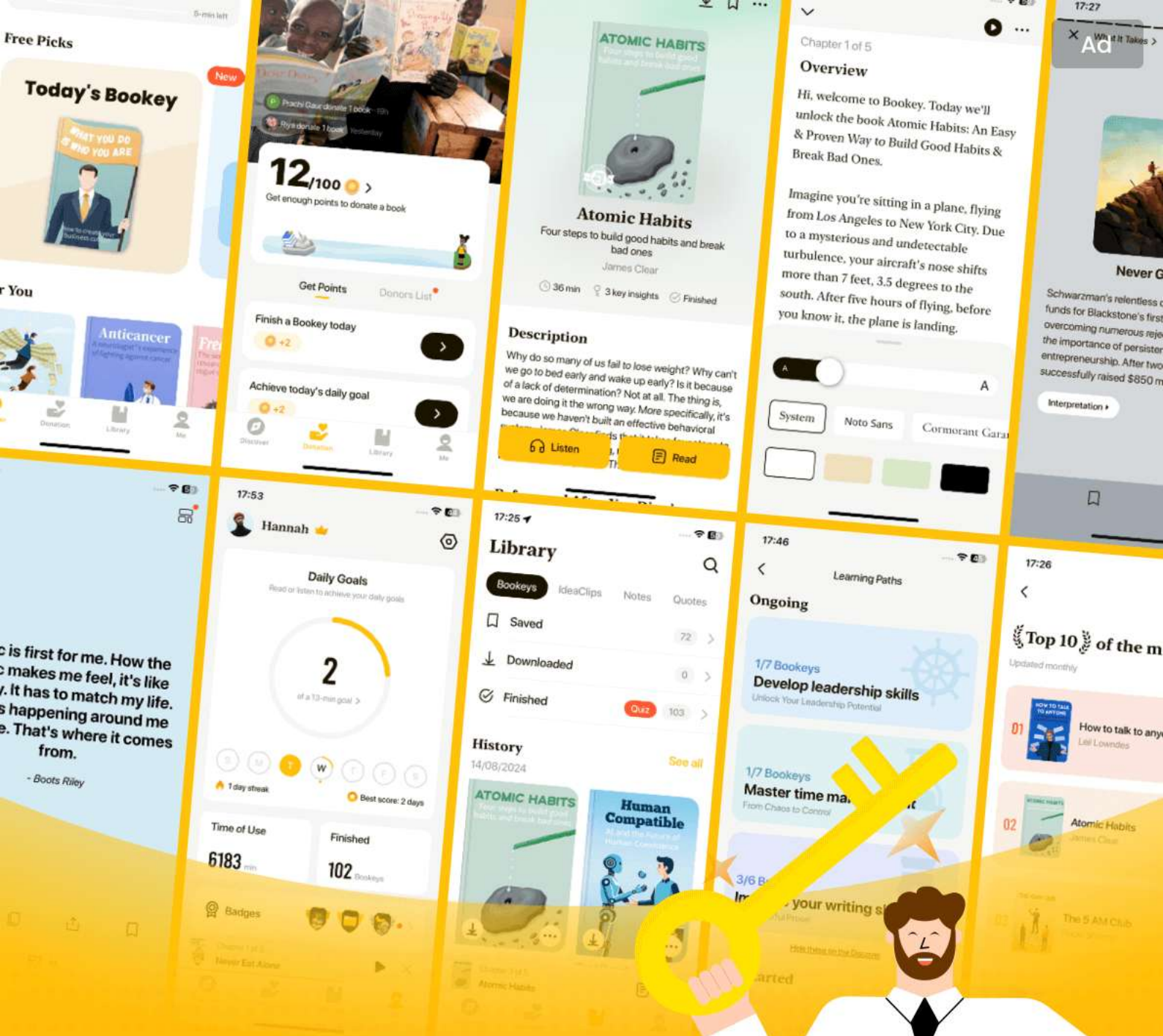
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Chapter 43 Summary : “I’ve Been Told If We’re Not Adding Anything New to the Conversation, Then We Shouldn’t Be Talking about It”

Chapter 43: The Value of Repetition in Conversation

The Myth of Originality

In the digital marketing sphere, a common misconception is that if someone has already discussed a topic, adding additional perspectives is pointless. This belief neglects the historical significance of repeated ideas and communication.

The Importance of Personal Expression

In sharing ideas—even if they are not original—we bring our unique experiences and language to the table. This personal touch often resonates with audiences and encourages them to take action.

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Mutual Benefits of Sharing Ideas

Writing and discussing established concepts can yield benefits for both the speaker and the audience. The speaker gains clarity and communication skills, while the audience may find inspiration and actionable insights. Many have shared success stories after embracing this philosophy, affirming its positive impact on business growth and personal fulfillment.

Learning from Historical Examples

The redundancy observed in influential texts, such as the Gospels of the New Testament, exemplifies the idea that multiple perspectives can enrich understanding. Had authors opted not to share their insights due to existing narratives, the historical landscape could have been vastly different.

Your Unique Voice Matters

It is essential for individuals and companies to articulate their viewpoints—what the author refers to as "The Gospel According to You." Customers and prospects desire to

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understand personal beliefs and motivations. This practice not only enhances communication but also fosters greater trust and engagement with the audience.

Conclusion: The Cycle of Improvement

By producing content and sharing ideas, individuals not only contribute to the conversation but also develop into better communicators and business professionals. The act of expressing thoughts is a pathway to growth for everyone involved, emphasizing the enduring value of participation in ongoing discussions.

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Chapter 44 Summary : A Revolutionary Marketing Strategy

Revolutionary Marketing Strategy

As I reflect on the past seven years of my journey, it feels surreal. I transitioned from a struggling pool guy nearly losing my business to speaking globally and aiding other businesses in their growth. This transformation allowed me to be a more present father and husband, resulting in greater happiness for my family.

In 2013, a significant turning point occurred at a conference in Dallas, where a reporter approached me about how we saved River Pools through simple strategies: listening, teaching, and transparency. Initially, I underestimated the importance of this interaction, but after a detailed phone conversation with the reporter and a subsequent photo shoot, my life changed dramatically.

Four days later, an article titled "A Revolutionary Marketing Strategy: Answer Customers' Questions" was published in the New York Times' small business section. While the concept of answering customer questions is not inherently

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revolutionary, its practical application proved to be transformative. The article became the most shared piece for that section, generating an overwhelming response from business owners worldwide.

I received over a thousand emails of encouragement, with most expressing disbelief at the simplicity of our approach. Yet, simplicity is powerful; it enables anyone to adopt effective strategies for their business by genuinely caring for customers and addressing their needs.

The other recurring sentiment in the emails was a sense of empowerment. Many readers felt I had given them the permission to implement the strategies they had always believed in. As we conclude this discussion, I urge you to trust your instincts and pursue these insights. Become the best teacher, obsess over your customers' questions, respond with honesty, and ultimately win their trust.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: The author emphasizes the value of transparency and customer-centric strategies in marketing.

Critical Interpretation: While Marcus Sheridan promotes the idea that simply answering customer questions can revolutionize business practices, it is crucial to consider that such strategies may not apply universally across all industries. The effectiveness of his approach heavily depends on specific market dynamics, customer expectations, and the competitive landscape. Therefore, while his insights serve as a valuable starting point for many, they should be adapted and critically evaluated in light of differing business contexts. For a more nuanced view on customer engagement and marketing strategies, sources like 'The Lean Startup' by Eric Ries or 'Contagious: How to Build Word of Mouth in the Digital Age' by Jonah Berger should be consulted to consider alternative perspectives.

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Parent-Child Communication

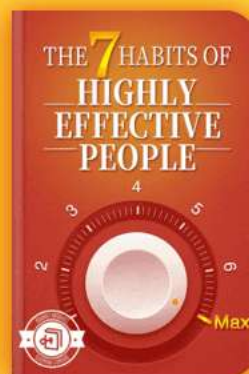
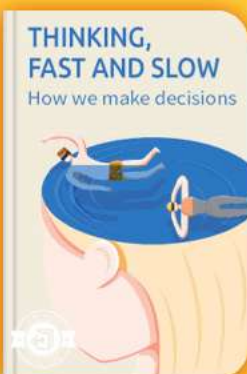


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Best Quotes from They Ask You Answer by Marcus Sheridan with Page Numbers

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Chapter 1 | Quotes From Pages 25-66

- 1.I could feel the anxiety and sense of hopelessness start to overcome me.
- 2.My business was a failure. My family life was suffering.
And for a guy who sees himself as a problem solver, I was out of answers.
- 3.You see, no one ever says, 'I want to be a pool guy when I grow up.'
- 4.But life is a funny thing. As soon as I started at River Pools, I quickly realized I didn't know much about the industry.
- 5.I learned. I read. I studied. And I dug deep into the industry.
- 6.It was a difficult time in my life.

Chapter 2 | Quotes From Pages 67-71

- 1.Consumer buying patterns have gone through a

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monumental shift over the past decade.

Specifically, the line between 'sales' and 'marketing' has been completely blurred, if not totally erased.

2.Today, on average, 70 percent of the buying decision is made before a prospect talks to the company.

3.But no longer are we able to say this. And no longer can businesses and brands continue to do things the way they've always been done.

4.They clearly understood consumers had changed, and they knew they had to react or get left behind.

5.If you adhere to what you read in the following pages, you'll at least be prepared for what comes next, whatever that may be.

Chapter 3 | Quotes From Pages 72-76

1.If you do not believe there is a change in the way consumers behave, there really is no reason to continue reading at this point.

2.The first person (or business), when they hear a new idea,

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suggestion, or business strategy, responds with: 'Sure, I can see how that's possible.'

3.The 'we're different' phenomenon.

4.Every business has a single tie that binds them all together when it comes to consumers and buyers, and that is trust.

5.Instead, ask yourself the simple question, 'But, is it possible?'

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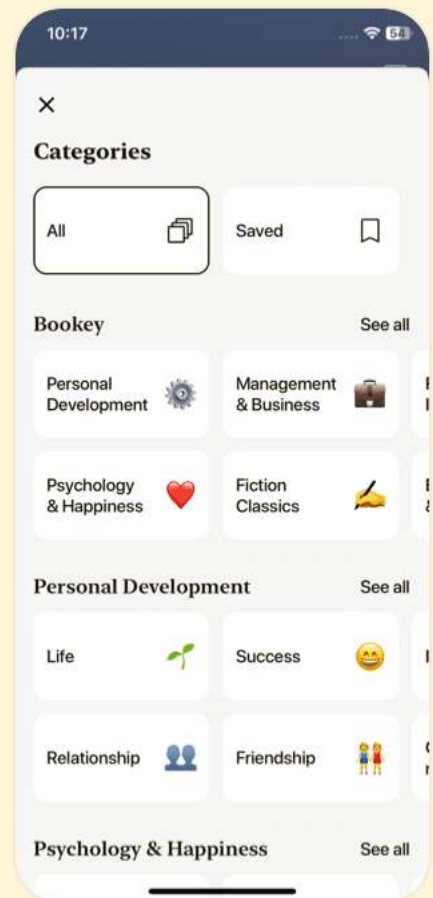
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Chapter 4 | Quotes From Pages 77-81

- 1.If we were going to save the company, we needed a miracle, and it had better occur fast.
- 2.I was now turning to the Internet for everything. If I had a question, I went to Google and asked.
- 3.No longer was the 'old-school' way of advertising working.
- 4.I didn't view the Internet from an MBA's standpoint. I didn't have years of formal business, sales, or marketing education. Rather, I saw it from a consumer's mind-set.
- 5.The core thought: Marcus, just answer people's questions.
- 6.Little did I know that this shift, and the new motto, would go on to affect businesses all over the world.

Chapter 5 | Quotes From Pages 82-85

- 1.They Ask, You Answer starts with an obsession:
What is my customer thinking?
- 2.When an organization embraces They Ask, You Answer, they believe it's their duty to be the teacher, the go-to source within their particular industry.
- 3.It's a moral obligation to do this, regardless of whether the

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question is perceived as good, bad, or even ugly.

4. Because they are so keenly in tune with what the marketplace is thinking, feeling, and asking, they see where their business model needs to go, evolve, and head toward.
5. This is a way of doing business that could revolutionize everything about your company, your culture, and your bottom line.

Chapter 6 | Quotes From Pages 86-129

1. Every industry has hundreds of questions about what prospects and customers want to know when they're making a buying decision.
2. As consumers, we expect to be fed great information. As businesses, we like to talk about ourselves and therefore don't focus on what our prospects and customers are thinking about, worrying about, and asking about.
3. If I was on a sales appointment, as soon as the prospect would ask me a question, my immediate thought was, 'Have I answered that on our website yet?'
4. It is time to disrupt the status quo and lead change. It is

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time to grow an organization that you can be proud of, and that buyers trust.

5. We now saw ourselves as teachers, and understood that if we just listened well, and were willing to answer, things would turn around.

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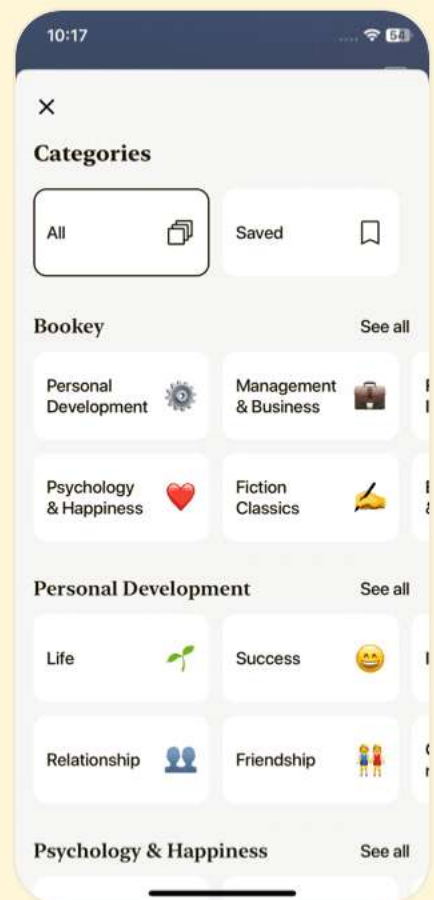
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Chapter 7 | Quotes From Pages 130-132

1. The ostrich does not engender trust.
2. In our digital era, the ostrich does not win.
3. The solution? Don't be the ostrich. Do whatever it takes to earn their trust.

Chapter 8 | Quotes From Pages 133-207

1. They Ask, You Answer is a business philosophy.
It's the willingness to be so focused on and obsessed with consumer questions, wants, desires, and needs that you're willing to change and evolve your entire business model around these elements.
2. CarMax did two things other used car companies weren't willing (at least at the time) to do: Admit their industry had a problem (no consumer trust). Ask themselves what it would take to earn that trust back.
3. Simply, put, the greatest companies and modern-day rule makers are obsessed with consumer fear, and they allow that fear to dictate their entire business model.
4. In our digital and visual world, one thing is certain: If you

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don't show it, it doesn't exist.

5.They become the rule makers. And the competition? Well, they become the rule followers.

Chapter 9 | Quotes From Pages 208-211

- 1.After about six months of They Ask, You Answer, I took the time to take a deep dive into our Web analytics in an effort to pick up on any patterns that may have been occurring.
- 2.What I discovered was profound. Basically, there were five types of content subjects (or types of questions) that seemed to move the needle with readers more than anything else...
- 3.As consumers, we often obsess over these five subjects when considering a purchase. As businesses, we generally ignore or even hide from these questions.
- 4.Although you may be confused about how to understand and implement the Big 5 in your business, the following chapters cover each individually and show you specific ways you can address these five critical subjects...

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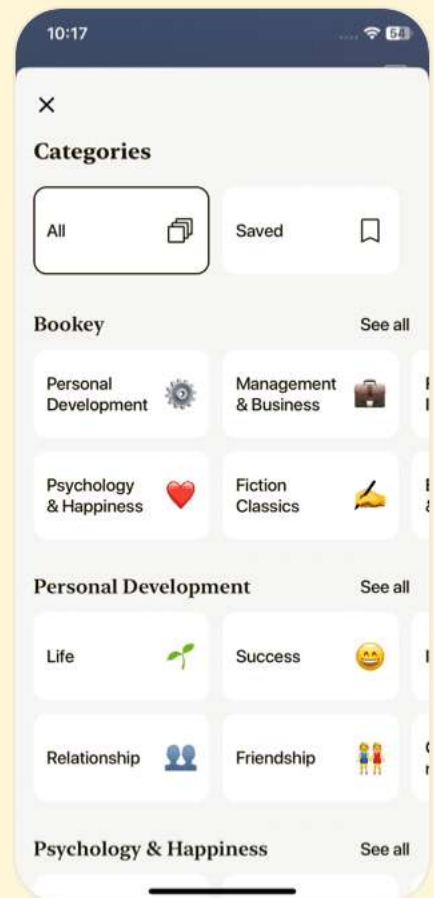
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Chapter 10 | Quotes From Pages 212-287

1. When you're researching a company and their products and services, the moment you feel like anyone is hiding anything from you, all trust is lost.
2. But if we look at this at an even deeper level, you're upset because you know that the business knows the answer to the question. And because you know that they know the answer, you now feel like they are hiding something from you.
3. Our loyalty is to the honest and open teacher focused on our problems.
4. When we don't get [answers], we get upset and leave.
5. It doesn't matter whether they are B2B or B2C businesses, or whether they are product or service-oriented, only a small percentage ever address the question of pricing and costs.
6. Every solution is different. Our prices vary.
7. If we discuss pricing on our website, our competitors will

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find out what we charge.

8.If we show what we charge, we'll scare customers away.

Chapter 11 | Quotes From Pages 288-368

- 1.We saw immediate action on two fronts. Within days of posting the article on our website, we noticed an increase in qualified, productive conversations with leads who contacted us. Many people commented on how impressed they were to, "finally", find a company that was willing to discuss the subject of cost and price.
- 2.Think about that: \$3 million in sales simply because we were willing to explain to prospective customers that the cost of a fiberglass swimming pool depends on several factors. Without exaggeration, this single article saved my business.
- 3.But the funny thing is, we never specifically stated how much a fiberglass pool costs. We simply answered the question the best we could. We were honest. We openly discussed the industry as a whole.

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4. When it comes to money, you cannot be the ostrich with your head in the sand. You must be willing to address the most important questions—regardless of whether you're a service, product, value driven, and so on.
5. It's about trust. And believe it or not, every business can do it, as we now explain.

Chapter 12 | Quotes From Pages 369-480

1. It was almost like an experiment just to see if we could even do commercial work. Fortunately, we ended up landing some pretty large clients.
2. We were slightly ahead of the curve of the defense contractors in that we actually saw the value in having a good website and having good content.
3. I had kind of a 'light-bulb' moment. The first thing I thought was, 'Man, I feel stupid. I should have been doing this years ago.'
4. Each employee was tasked with writing at least one blog per quarter, for a total of four blog posts per year. We wanted to get everyone involved.

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5. Before we started this process, we had less than 1,000 visitors a month to our website, and within three months of the workshop, we had over 30,000.
6. If we bring on four or six new clients each year, that's actually a lot, because the size of our business deals are pretty large. A typical deal for us is anywhere from a quarter million to a million dollars.
7. When we first started doing inbound marketing and They Ask, You Answer, we were getting around 1,000 visits to the website each month. Last month we had 85,000.

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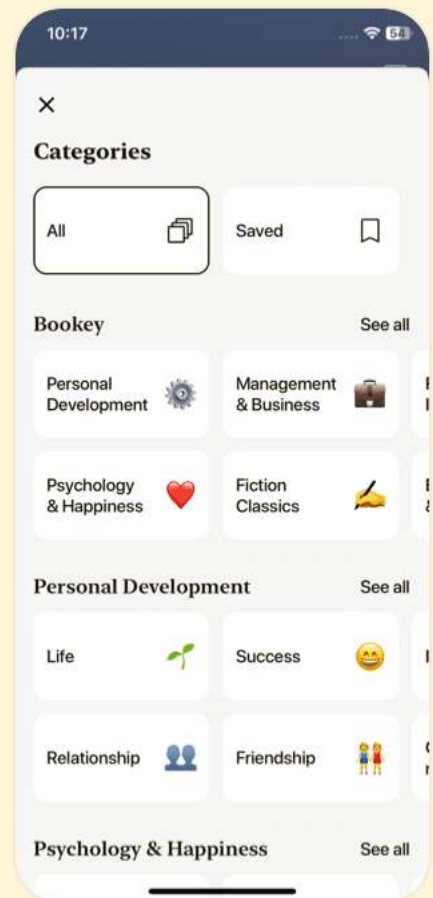
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Chapter 13 | Quotes From Pages 481-484

1. When people buy, they worry more about what might go wrong than what will go right.
2. As buyers, although we want to know the good, bad, and ugly, we are mostly concerned with the ugly.
3. You might think I'm exaggerating with this scenario, but it's true. I saw it hundreds of times during my years selling swimming pools.

Chapter 14 | Quotes From Pages 485-487

1. 'How many of our competitors were addressing that question on their websites? Of course, the answer is none.'
2. 'Consumers are not dumb; nor are they ignorant.'
3. 'You can allow the consumer to discover your elephant(s) themselves and, in turn, lose trust in you.'
4. 'The minute they walk in the front door (or the virtual front door), you can say, "Here's our elephant. Do you have a problem with it?"'
5. 'Buying a fiberglass swimming pool might not be for you.'



Chapter 15 | Quotes From Pages 488-579

1. People trusted us because we were willing not only to address, but to embrace, the elephant in the room. And that, in and of itself, is power.
2. The reaction to the problems post on our website was very similar to the cost piece. In both cases, consumers expressed their gratitude and ultimately gave us their trust.
3. What was the result of that post? Well, in simple terms, over the past six years more than 260,000 people have visited our website because their search criteria related to 'problems' with fiberglass pools.
4. This one article has generated well over \$500,000 in additional sales since the day it was published.
5. How many times over the years have prospective customers questioned you about any of the potential problems or issues they may experience with your products or services?
6. Wouldn't it be better if they were getting those answers from you?

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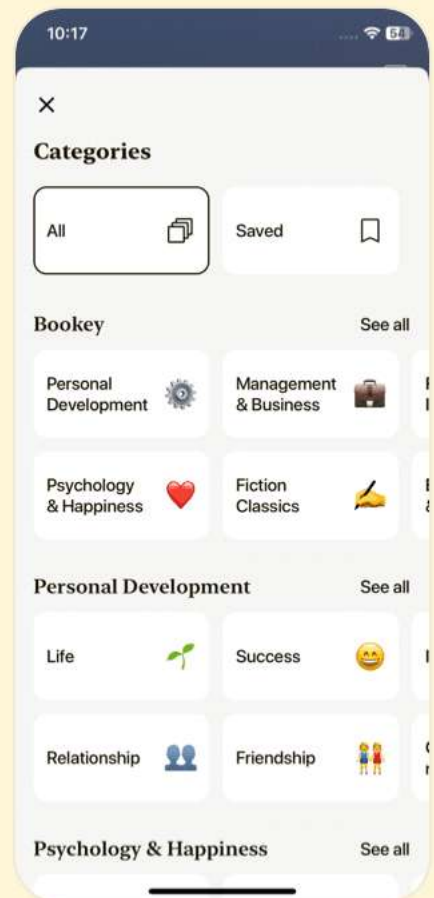
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Chapter 16 | Quotes From Pages 580-708

1. I actually ended up reading the entire book that night. It was the first time in my life I had ever read a book and said, ‘This is literally going to change my life.’
2. Just obsess over your customer. Figure out what they’re thinking, asking, and going through. Then have the guts to address it.
3. I take subjects that have very low keyword value (aren’t necessarily searched by many people) and make these huge articles out of them.
4. When you’re not paying for the leads, you have to ask yourself: ‘Am I more interested in maximizing my profits, or my happiness?’
5. They’re going to get their answers from somewhere, so wouldn’t you prefer they get their answers from you?
6. It’s such a dirty industry. It’s unregulated, and so people will outright lie to customers.

Chapter 17 | Quotes From Pages 709-823

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- 1.Consumer ignorance is no longer a viable sales and marketing strategy.
- 2.Ignoring it only destroys trust.
- 3.Let's assume our prospects and customers know every single other possible solution, possible vendor, and possible competitor out there.
- 4.If we conduct our business that way, and design all of our sales and marketing messaging to be aligned with this philosophy, the possibilities are literally endless.
- 5.Once we embraced They Ask, You Answer as a company, it became obvious we needed to address this major question.
- 6.What would help a great deal is to find some kind of unbiased information that explains each pool in detail and then backs off—letting me (or the customer) make the final decision.
- 7.It's what we all do—a classic case of ostrich marketing.
- 8.Each project is different, and therefore costs vary. They didn't want their competitors to see their pricing...

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9. This single article saved my business. It saved my home. It saved the homes of my two business partners. It also saved the jobs of all of our employees.
10. They clearly understood consumers had changed, and they knew they had to react or get left behind.

Chapter 18 | Quotes From Pages 824-936

1. ‘Consumers do want to know what your business believes about these types of questions; otherwise, they wouldn’t ask you the question in the first place.’
2. ‘But the response you give them...now that’s where you’ve got to overcome this incessant need to brag, exaggerate, and only focus on why your company (or product, service, and so on) is the greatest thing since sliced bread.’
3. ‘They Ask, You Answer’ is a business philosophy. It’s an approach to communication, company culture, and the way we sell as a business.
4. ‘Disarmament is arguably the least understood element of great communication and copy—online and offline.’

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5. 'In our digital era, the ostrich does not win. The ostrich does not engender trust.'

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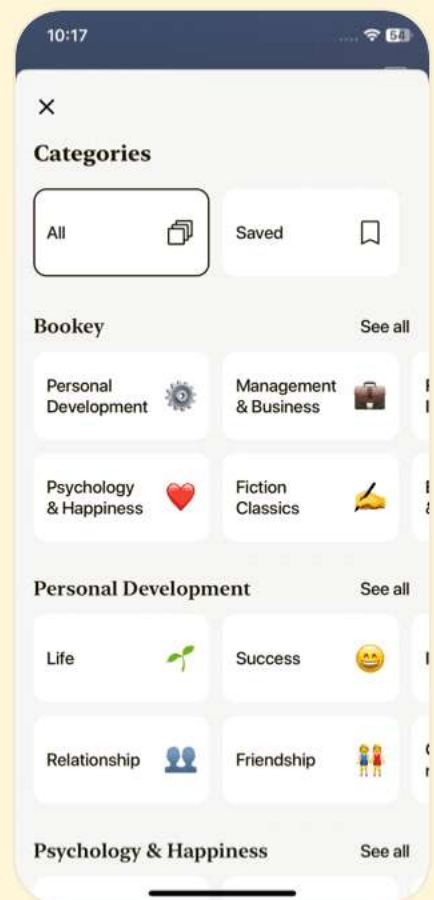
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Chapter 19 | Quotes From Pages 937-1057

1. After all, the most successful business innovations of the digital age happen time and time again when an organization elects to take the road less traveled, ultimately clearing a new path and a new way of seeing ‘the way it should be done.’
2. We’re also obsessed with reviews. Whether it’s a website like Yelp, Angie’s List, or even a print publication like Motor Trend and its Car of the Year award, we are a society that cares about pecking orders.
3. We’ll better help consumers if we address these questions openly and honestly, rather than turning a blind eye in hopes that they’ll magically go away.
4. It was during this time my mind again shifted back to the core principles of They Ask, You Answer, and I thought, Consumers want to see these types of ranking systems. And they certainly want to know the best swimming pool shapes and sizes for their needs. Therefore, if they want them, it’s my job to give it to them.

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5. But once I published it in an open forum, and they saw people were paying attention, now they couldn't help but to take notice.

6. Consumers ask for it, smart businesses answer it—and often change history in the process.

Chapter 20 | Quotes From Pages 1058-1062

1. If someone starts reading that article, where are they? That's right—they are already on my site.

2. Never one to shy away from being blatantly honest about the competition, I provide you with a list of some of the companies that have a solid inground swimming pool building history in the Richmond area.

3. Rather, what consumers want is to look at your works, judge them, and then make their own decisions on just how great a company really is.

4. Honesty and transparency are self-evident, and when done with the right intentions, have a profound influence on the business, brand, and bottom line.

Chapter 21 | Quotes From Pages 1063-1189

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- 1.If someone wants to know who your competitors are, roughly, how long will it take them to figure it out? Maybe five seconds... if they're slow!
- 2.Consumer ignorance is no longer a viable sales and marketing strategy.
- 3.That lady bought a \$50,000 swimming pool from us... because she had a common question and we were the ones that had been willing to answer it.
- 4.They clearly understood consumers had changed, and they knew they had to react or get left behind.
- 5.We're not special, at least in the most fundamental sort of the word... Trust is the only tie that binds all businesses together.
- 6.The reality is this: if you embrace a culture of answering questions, your business will prosper.
- 7.We are able to serve more people in our industry than ever before with less stress.
- 8.Marcus, I don't know why you wrote that article, but thank you.

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9.They Ask, You Answer is a revolutionary approach to inbound sales, content marketing, and today's digital consumer.

10.We focused on gaining consumer trust, no matter what title the person has on the other end.

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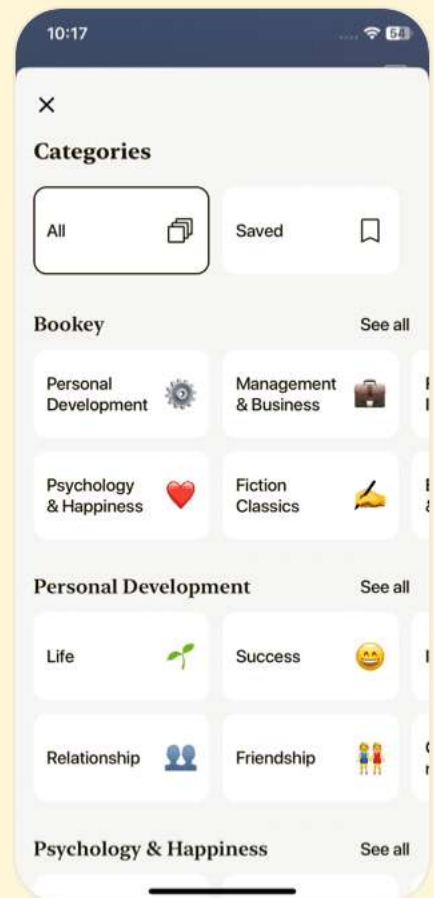
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Chapter 22 | Quotes From Pages 1190-1360

- 1.They turned to their customers and started paying close attention to the habits, problems, and needs of appliance consumers.
- 2.I've never been sold on advertising, even though we were doing some radio and television ads, and buying space in the Boston Globe.
- 3.The recession forced Sheinkopf to reevaluate his business goals and plans.
- 4.Simply put, they care only about becoming the most trusted source in the world for consumers when it comes to appliances.
- 5.Yet, while they were busy concentrating on that messaging (getting their features in front of buyers) they were ignoring the elephant in the room.
- 6.Rather, than pushing a one-size-fits-all solution for their clients, Segue customizes solutions based on the specific needs of each of their clients.
- 7.It was time to get our arms around this whole Internet thing

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and discover how it could save River Pools and Spas from bankruptcy.

8.They don't want to do business with you; they want to do business with someone who will answer their questions honestly and completely.

9.Once we came to this realization, our company motto took a dramatic shift...That motto was: 'They Ask, You Answer.'

10.What I'm trying to sell is truth and honesty.

Chapter 23 | Quotes From Pages 1361-1518

1.Sadly, despite the overwhelming evidence that has been shown herein, most people and organizations who read this book will not take such a transparent, consumer-centric approach to their sales and marketing efforts.

2.In many ways, it's a case of double jeopardy.

3.Teachers see the world differently. That's just a fact.

4.Consumer ignorance is no longer a viable sales and marketing strategy.

5.You can lead a horse to water, but you cannot make it

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drink.

6. When all is said and done, they are the only ones who truly matter.

Chapter 24 | Quotes From Pages 1519-1525

1. Everything you have read up to this point in the book saved our company and helped make it what it is today.
2. What is crazy about all of this is that we are just a small swimming pool installation company in Virginia with about thirty employees, and yet we're dictating the education of swimming pool shoppers all over the world.
3. Since that moment, I've seen again and again how, when it comes to great marketing and communication, the moment a business or brand tries to sound smart is generally the moment they start to look stupid.
4. Think like a teacher. Obsess not just over their questions, but the way you answer them. It will make all the difference.

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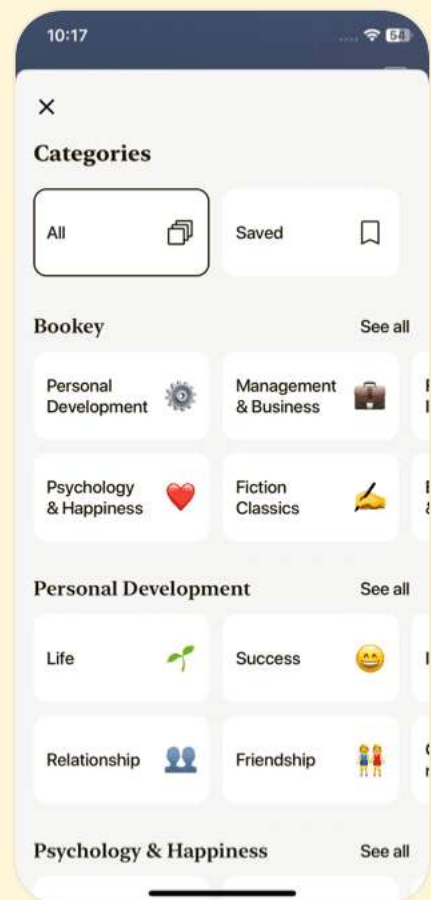
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Chapter 25 | Quotes From Pages 1529-1685

1. Producing Content Forces Us to Understand the Buyers and the Way They Think.
2. Producing Content is Magical Practice for Sales Messaging.
3. Great Content Means More Trust, More Trust Means Shorter Sales Cycles, Shorter Sales Cycles Equal Happier Sales Teams.
4. Sales Teams Can Learn What Prospects and Customers Truly Care About...Before They Even Enter the Sales Funnel.
5. Assignment Selling It's a Crying Shame Just How Silo-Driven Many Organizations Are.
6. With Content, the Relationship of Trust Can Be Built with the Sales Person (and Company), Long Before the First Sales Meeting.
7. Company Content Acts as the Guide for All Training, Messaging, and So On.

Chapter 26 | Quotes From Pages 1686-1690

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1. What you're really saying when you say that you can only envision a prospective customer reading (on average) two or three pages of your site is this: 'Marcus, doing business with us is worth about five minutes of someone's time.'
2. We discovered that if someone read thirty or more pages of the website before the initial sales appointment, they would buy from us 80 percent of the time.
3. Every time someone consumes a piece of your content, the trust factor continues to rise.
4. If you go on enough dates with someone, eventually, you'll get 'married.'
5. If all you had to do was get a prospect to consume thirty pieces of your content, and they would buy from you 80 percent of the time, what would you do differently?

Chapter 27 | Quotes From Pages 1691-1888

1. You must find ways to actively help your prospects and customers read and view your content if you're going to truly move the needle.

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2. Assignment selling is the process of intentionally using information that you have created... with the purpose of resolving the major concerns and questions of the prospect.
3. The rights of a teacher are greater than those of the person who does not teach.
4. If, becoming educated with respect to your products and services is not a variable in a prospect's buying decision, it almost always means they are basing their decision on what to buy solely on price.
5. In business, consumer ignorance is no longer a viable sales and marketing strategy.
6. The best sales professionals have not only heard most questions a prospect could ask, they tend to answer them the same way each time.

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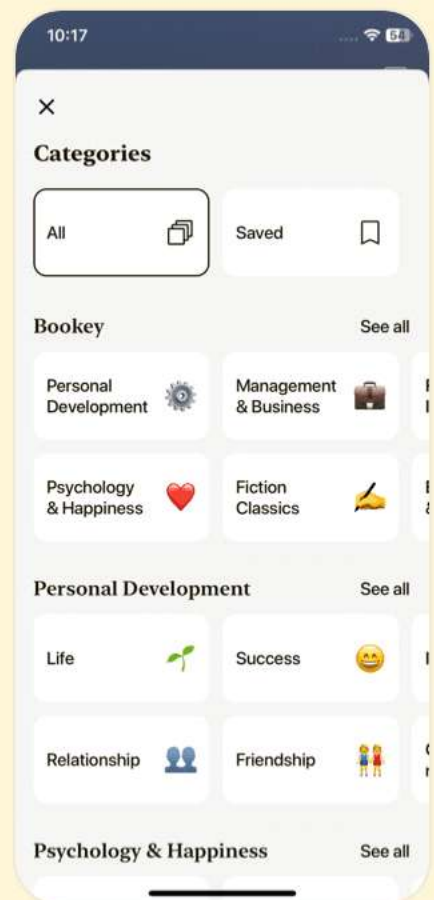
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Chapter 28 | Quotes From Pages 1889-1893

1. How much selling had I actually done that day?

The answer, of course, is none.

2. If you think about how you buy things, and how much research you do when you're serious about what you're buying, you'll see that you are likely grossly underestimating people's willingness to become comfortable with their buying decisions through the power of great, helpful information.

3. Content—assuming it is honest and transparent—is the greatest sales tool in the world today.

Chapter 29 | Quotes From Pages 1894-1900

1. Content—assuming it is honest and transparent—is the greatest sales tool in the world today.

2. Content can teach 1,000; 100,000; or even 1,000,000 people at a time. Its scope and reach have no limits.

3. Content never sleeps. It can work for you 24/7/365.

4. A single piece of content can continue to work for you long

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after you've even forgotten about it.

5. Instead of having to go on 250 sales appointments, our salespeople now go on fewer than half that number; yet they have dramatically higher closing rates than I ever had.
6. When you look at the power of content, it is not just about leads, traffic, and sales. It is not just about building your brand, either. It is about giving your company, your staff, and your salespeople more time.
7. If you can give this incredible gift (of time) to your employees, then not only do employee morale and overall culture improve, but you are making a serious impact on the world in the process.

Chapter 30 | Quotes From Pages 1901-1905

1. 'Don't hesitate to let me know.'—that e-mail might as well be called a 'Please-don't-break-up-with-me' letter... it's completely ineffective.
2. In order to further help you with these concerns, I've attached to this e-mail a video and an article that

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specifically address each.

3. When we meet someone in a sales situation and give them our pitch or proposal, we generally believe we have properly addressed their concerns.
4. Time is your greatest asset in business and in life, and a candid answer saves you precious time.
5. Every successful client we have worked with... has adopted the principle of using content in their sales process.

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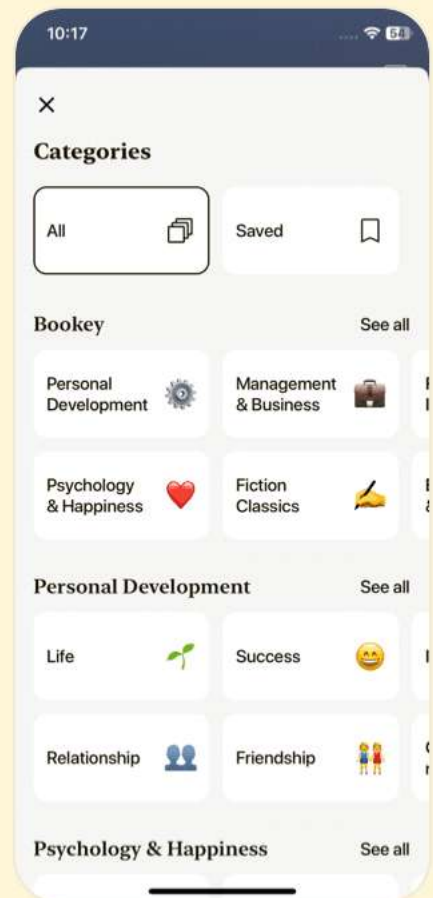
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Chapter 31 | Quotes From Pages 1906-1911

1. We want to make sure we're dealing with informed and educated clients versus those who really have no clue as to what we are and the services we provide.
2. If you read this, and feel good about what you see herein, you will know that we are a good fit for you as well as your needs.
3. The most successful salespeople in the world understand that one of the great keys to sales is helping the prospect feel like they are the ones making the buying decision.
4. Every email sent out by your company's sales team is a teaching opportunity.
5. If they hate me, that's fine. We skip the phone conversation, acknowledge that it's a bad fit, and save each other time.

Chapter 32 | Quotes From Pages 1912-2133

1. We were advocating something that was very new to the healthcare industry. We knew we needed to

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educate the market.

2. Rather than push their way onto the stage, Health Catalyst was able to build the stage.
3. Only about 30 percent of people actually trust brands. So, for the most part, you have to start from the perspective that nobody trusts what you're saying.
4. It was so easy to catch the vision. We were fortunate in that the subject matter experts that we had on our team were the subject matter experts nationally.
5. Our content team has grown. I have a core team, and I have a separate team that just writes case studies.
6. We have about seventy-seven strategic keyword phrases that we target, and we own almost all of them.
7. We were so committed to making it an analytics event and not a sponsored event that we asked everyone at the very end to vote if they thought it was a vendor event or an analytics event.
8. The transparency of their motives and their pledge to cultivate a culture instead of building a brand has made

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them the trusted thought leaders in their space.

9.Success for us meant...building a marketing strategy based on education, teaching, and transparency that transformed into a culture.

10.We were able to serve more people in our industry than ever before with less stress. We have more time and energy for our families and friends.

Chapter 33 | Quotes From Pages 2137-2141

1.The creative flexibility to simply produce great content, in all its forms, without the limitations of a contract or deliverable, is a powerful, powerful thing.

2.The question of producing your own content versus having someone else do it for you is much like the principle of the artist: Not until the artist is holding her own paintbrush can she truly produce her own masterpiece.

3.Ultimately, if you want to be heard above the noise of your industry, you can't just be average. You can't be like everyone else in your space. You must do more, and you

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must do it better.

4. All of this leads to the opposite of outsourcing your company's content, something we call insourcing, which we define as: The process of using your existing employees and their knowledge about your services and products to produce educational content for the marketing department.

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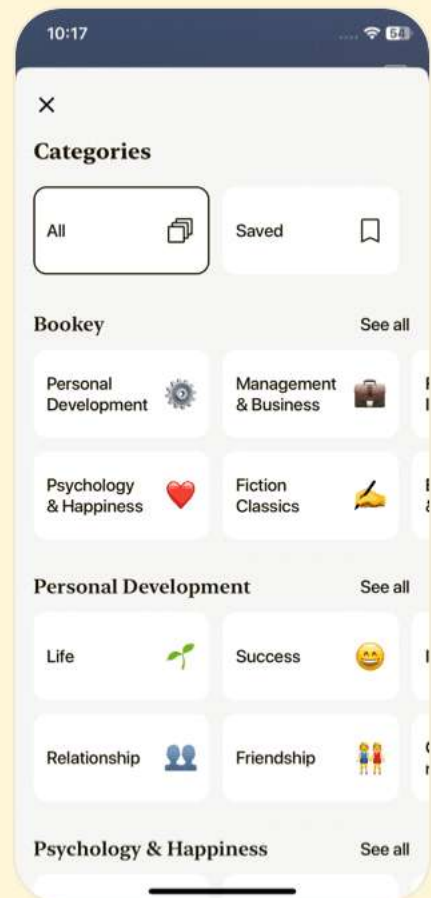
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Chapter 34 | Quotes From Pages 2142-2358

1. In life, when someone tells you they 'don't have time,' what they're really trying to tell you, without actually telling you, is, 'That thing you just explained to me is not as important to me as it is to you.'
2. The funny thing is, whenever we as humans or businesses see the value of something, we quickly start to make the time.
3. Without question, though, the story of marketing departments not getting help from the rest of the team is prolific throughout the entire world today.
4. When companies think this way, anything is possible.
5. Because of Insourcing and Content Marketing, we can account for at least 20 million in sales we otherwise would never have gotten.

Chapter 35 | Quotes From Pages 2359-2598

1. All this being said, cultures aren't built on e-mails, announcements, and mission statements.

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2. Your team must understand the what, how, and why of They Ask, You Answer so as to allow what is a 'program' in many people's eyes to eventually become a culture.
3. The key to this section of the workshop is to help every person realize the goal of Google—and other search engines—is to give its customer (the searcher) the best, most specific answer to their question.
4. Regardless of how good, bad, or ugly the question may appear, if the marketplace is asking it, you must address it.
5. It's about trust. And, believe it or not, every business can do it, as we now explain.
6. You have to ask yourself the simple question, 'But, is it possible?' If you do, I can promise you the information found within these pages will have a dramatic impact on your business, and maybe even your life.
7. As for me, all I can do is chuckle, knowing the simplistic power and impact of They Ask, You Answer.
8. I just want to do it the inbound way.

Chapter 36 | Quotes From Pages 2599-2863

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1. You need a content manager. Someone must own this effort and dedicate all their time to it, assuming you truly want to get exceptional results.
2. Either you do this right or don't do it at all. You wearing another hat is only going to cause you more stress and produce little results...
3. Producing great content is a full-time job, and someone has to own it...
4. You can always teach a great writer to be a good marketer, but you can't always teach a good marketer to be a great writer.
5. Consumer buying patterns have gone through a monumental shift over the past decade. Specifically, the line between 'sales' and 'marketing' has been completely blurred...
6. Those who listen to the consumer and change their business model—regardless of what others may say—set the standard for their space. They become the rule makers.
7. You must be willing to address the most important

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questions—regardless of whether you’re a service, product,
or value driven...

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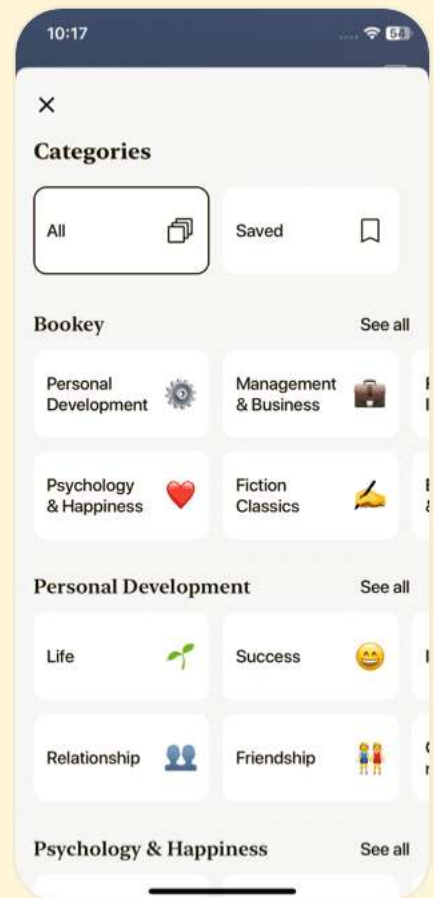
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Chapter 37 | Quotes From Pages 2864-3127

1. But, after all of this is done, it's critical that a business can answer the following question: But did it make us any money?
- 2....without it helping you to seriously generate more revenue for your company, it's not worth the price tag on the cover.
- 3.... the principle of showing ROI has been a major part of this book and the case studies herein.
4. When I was a struggling pool guy on the brink of losing my business in early 2009, I spent quite a bit of time reading about digital marketing...
- 5....there must be shared buy-in. Departments must be aligned. Everyone needs to understand the underlying vision.
6. You will see again and again that the simplest changes in words, messaging, colors, and design matter—and therefore deserve your attention as a business.
7. You see, the fact is, as businesses, we must make money. And then we must turn a profit.

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8.If your organization is going to spend the time, resources, and money needed to make content marketing and They Ask, You Answer work, there absolutely should be an ongoing understanding of the company's return on investment (ROI).

9.Having a culture of testing within the digital side of your business... you'll see again and again that the simplest changes matter.

10.It's for this reason that with digital marketing, tools do matter—a lot.

Chapter 38 | Quotes From Pages 3131-3400

1.Every Single E-mail You Ever Send Out That Answers a Question Very Well May Be a Blog Post.

2.Start Talking to Yourself Out Loud—a Lot.

3.Stop Doing the Thing That Does Not Bring the Greatest Returns.

4.Is It about Time, or Is There Something Else Really Going On Here?

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- 5.If You Don't Show It, It Doesn't Exist.
- 6.When you bring in other voices, you become more than just a company; you become a community of experts.
- 7.We've had several analysts give us an overall market review of our company, and they always put us at the top of the list.
- 8.In 2007, when home values were inflated, we did about \$4 million in business. In contrast, if you fast-forward to 2014—we did about \$5.5 million in business, and spent roughly \$20,000 on advertising and marketing.
- 9.Truth is, truth is truth, and it wasn't mine to keep.
- 10.Time is your greatest asset in business and in life, and a candid answer like, 'I'm not interested,' saves you precious time.

Chapter 39 | Quotes From Pages 3401-3666

- 1.Folks, video is big. And when it comes to They Ask, You Answer, video (and visually-based content), in many ways, is dramatically more important than textual-based content.

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2. In the eyes of the consumer, if they can't see it, it doesn't exist.
3. Everyone is a media company, whether they like it or not.
4. We must show our story, not just tell it. We need to show our company culture, not just explain it.
5. It's the essence of disarmament: honesty and transparency are self-evident, and when done with the right intentions, have a profound influence on the business, brand, and bottom line.
6. They are the ones who will allow you to live in financial peace. And no one else.
7. Content—assuming it is honest and transparent—is the greatest sales tool in the world today.
8. If you ignore the problem (or question), it will go away, but it doesn't. Ignoring it only destroys trust.
9. The moment a business thinks it wants to do business with everyone is the moment that business starts to become very, very unhappy.
10. If you're thinking, like a business owner and not a

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teacher, you are likely to struggle with this process.

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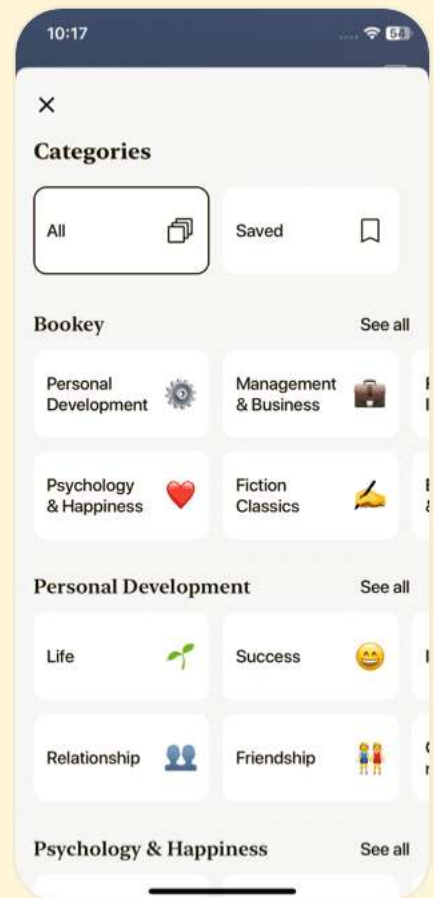
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Chapter 40 | Quotes From Pages 3667-3926

1. Creating a culture of listening, teaching, and then acting upon it isn't easy. It takes time, tools, resources, and major dedication. It's also quite worth it when done right.
2. A real transformation in your organization is possible if you're willing to do these three things: produce content, address consumer questions, and unify team participation.
3. The companies that embrace the reality of consumer trust, and let go of the obsession that 'we're different,' that's when great things are brought to pass.
4. I knew I'd spent the entire previous year trying to rally people around [the content marketing vision], Marcus accomplished companywide in less than six hours.
5. The reality is this: consumer ignorance is no longer a viable sales and marketing strategy.

Chapter 41 | Quotes From Pages 3927-4185

1. This lack of understanding as to what content marketing really is has led to inaction, and a

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greater divide between themselves and their competitors—those who are willing to accept today's consumer and shift the way they market and sell accordingly.

- 2.They Ask, You Answer is simply the process of teaching and problem-solving so as to earn buyer trust.
- 3.Simply put, if they want them, it's my job to give it to them.
- 4.The moment a business thinks it wants to do business with everyone is the moment that business starts to become very, very unhappy.
- 5.But the reality is the best companies understand that just because something looks right doesn't mean it is right, nor does it mean changes aren't needed.
- 6.Those who listen to the consumer and change their business model—regardless of what others may say—set the standard for their space.
- 7.When you look at the power of content, it is not just about leads, traffic, and sales. It is not just about building your

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brand, either. It is about giving your company, your staff, and your salespeople more time.

8. In our case at the Sales Lion, we have found certain activities to be very effective, as well as a few things you should be paying close attention to.

9. As businesses, we must generate a profit. Having person look at a proposal.... improve the morale of the employees.

10. And ultimately, I think that's very important for team members to own it, and that same person is key in getting everyone else involved.

Chapter 42 | Quotes From Pages 4186-4450

1. Simply saying, "Everyone, start blogging," will never be enough... There must be more.

2. Everyone, from sales, engineering, leadership, human resources, administration, project management, and general counsel and the entire accounting team were there.

3. We now saw ourselves as teachers, and understood that if we just listened well, and were willing to answer, things would turn around.

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4. Sharing information and empowering buyers became embedded in our culture.
5. It feels like we've been given a second chance at life.
6. But it's a principle that has been around since the beginning and is not going anywhere anytime soon.
7. It's critical to get creative.
8. When all is said and done, they are the only ones who truly matter.
9. In the eyes of the consumer, if they can't see it, it doesn't exist.

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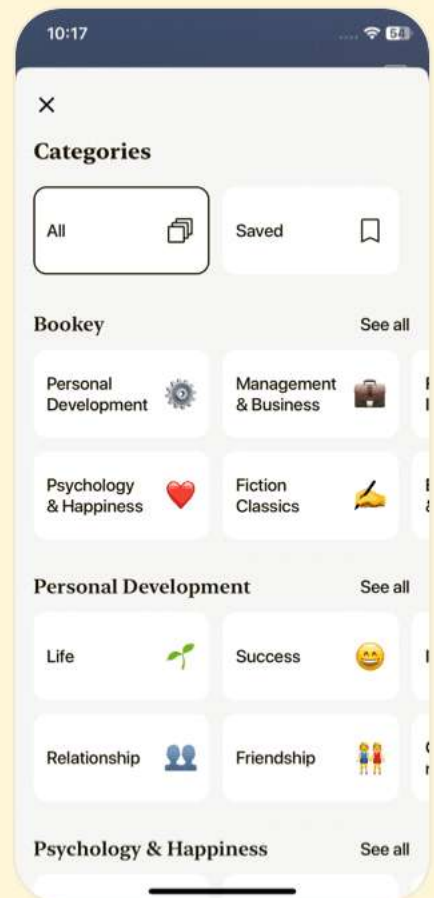
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Chapter 43 | Quotes From Pages 4451-4455

- 1.If someone has already said something, then it's a waste of time for someone else to add their two cents, especially if they're not adding anything "new" to the conversation.
- 2.You see, at this point in the 21st century, most everything we say is a repeat of what someone else has already said.
- 3.By producing content, regardless of how many times it has been said, we become better people, better employees, better sales professionals, and better communicators.
- 4.Your prospects and customers want to know your thoughts and feelings. They want to know what you believe and why you believe it.
- 5.Look at the most popular book of all time: the Bible.
Anyone who has read the Books of Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John knows these Gospels are very similar.

Chapter 44 | Quotes From Pages 4456-4459

- 1.Believe it, or not, I'm home way more now than I ever was as a struggling pool guy. Simply put, we

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are happy. We are blessed.

2. Yes, it was simple. But simple is good. This way, anyone, including you, can apply what we did at River Pools and Spas to your business.
3. Marcus, I feel like you've now given me permission to do that which I've always felt we should be doing.
4. Be the best teacher in the world. Obsess over their questions. Answer with fierce honesty. And win their trust.

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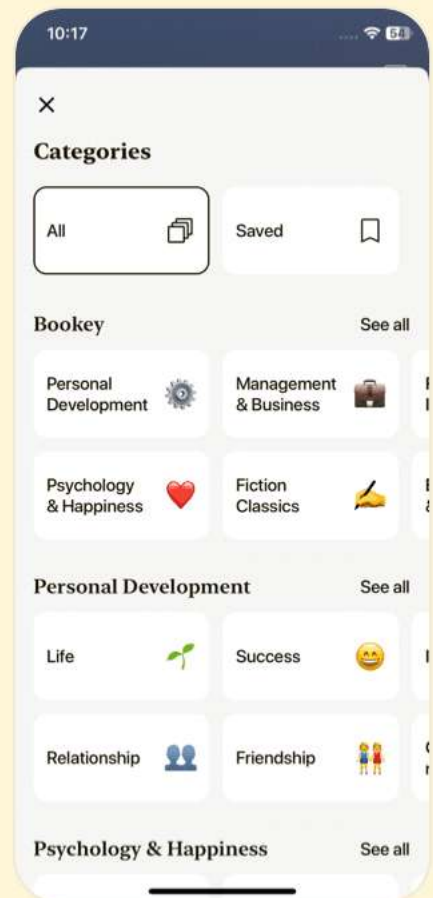
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Chapter 1 | The Fall| Q&A

1.Question

What was the author's emotional state as he drove home after a long day at work?

Answer:The author felt overwhelmed by anxiety and hopelessness, culminating in tears as he confronted the reality of his failing business and its impact on his personal life.

2.Question

How did the author's career path change after college?

Answer:Initially, the author aimed to find a job after graduation but ended up managing a pool company unexpectedly, which led him to a new career in an industry he had not initially considered.

3.Question

What does the author illustrate about the nature of problem-solving?

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Answer: The author portrays problem-solving as a fundamental aspect of his identity, yet he admits feeling out of answers during a particularly challenging time, highlighting the struggle between self-perception and reality.

4.Question

What lesson does the author convey about unexpected career changes?

Answer: The author suggests that unexpected career paths can lead to unanticipated growth opportunities, emphasizing the importance of adaptability and a willingness to learn.

5.Question

What was the impact of the economic collapse in 2008 on the author's business?

Answer: The economic collapse severely affected River Pools and Spas, leading to massive losses, depletion of savings, and ultimately a struggle to keep the business afloat.

6.Question

How did the author respond to challenges in the pool industry?

Answer: Faced with a lack of knowledge, the author

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proactively sought to learn about the pool industry and became knowledgeable enough to earn respect and trust from both customers and partners.

7.Question

What does the author mean by saying some questions in life are best not asked?

Answer:The author implies that certain questions can expose vulnerabilities or painful truths, especially when they relate to personal struggles, suggesting a need for understanding and sensitivity from loved ones.

8.Question

What was a pivotal moment in the author's professional life?

Answer:A significant moment was when he accepted an invitation to become a permanent partner at River Pools and Spas, which he initially viewed as a temporary role.

9.Question

What does the author's experience reveal about resilience in business?

Answer:The author's journey illustrates that resilience often

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involves learning from failures, adapting to changing circumstances, and staying committed to one's goals despite setbacks.

10.Question

What transformation did the author undergo during his time at River Pools and Spas?

Answer:The author transformed from someone uncertain and inexperienced in the pool industry into a knowledgeable expert who played a crucial role in the business's operations and strategy.

Chapter 2 | A Massive Buying Shift and the Blur between Sales and Marketing| Q&A

1.Question

What is the fundamental shift in consumer buying patterns over the past decade?

Answer:Consumer buying patterns have dramatically shifted, with 70% of the buying decision made before prospects engage with a company, blurring the lines between sales and marketing.

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2.Question

How does the current statistic of 70% affect businesses?

Answer: This statistic signifies that companies need to adapt their marketing strategies, as potential customers are already informed and have largely decided before even contacting the sales team.

3.Question

What questions might we ask to understand the future of buying decisions?

Answer: Looking ahead, one might wonder if future statistics will show even higher percentages of decisions made prior to sales contact—possibly reaching 80%, 90%, or even 100% as consumer research progresses.

4.Question

Which department is increasingly seen as critical for sales success in the new marketplace?

Answer: Marketing is increasingly viewed as having a greater impact on actual sales, shifting the traditional perspective that sales departments were primarily responsible for closing deals.

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5.Question

What challenges do companies face when trying to adapt to these new realities?

Answer:Companies often face resistance because traditional methods have been ingrained for over a century, making change both necessary and daunting.

6.Question

Can you give an example of a company that successfully adapted to changing consumer patterns?

Answer:Zappos revolutionized online retail by offering free shipping both ways, defying industry skepticism. Their success led competitors to adopt similar practices.

7.Question

What does the author suggest about fear in the context of these changes?

Answer:Though some may see the rapid changes in consumer behavior as scary, they can also be viewed as significant opportunities for businesses to innovate and thrive.

8.Question

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How did the author's own company adapt to these changes?

Answer: The author's pool company was able to sell high-value products remotely, demonstrating how understanding consumer trends can lead to extraordinary results in sales.

9.Question

What should businesses focus on to prepare for the evolving marketplace?

Answer: Businesses should focus on understanding and adapting to consumer behavior and the blurred lines between marketing and sales to succeed in the future.

Chapter 3 | This Book Won't Work for You If . . . | Q&A

1.Question

Why is it important to recognize the shift in consumer buying patterns?

Answer: Recognizing the shift in consumer buying patterns is crucial because it directly influences sales and marketing strategies. If you don't acknowledge

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these changes, you risk becoming outdated and ineffective in your approach to attracting and satisfying customers.

2.Question

What mindset is essential for benefiting from the insights in this book?

Answer:The essential mindset is one open to change and willing to challenge the status quo. You must be prepared to reconsider traditional beliefs and approaches, asking yourself, 'Is it possible?' rather than dismissing new ideas outright.

3.Question

How can the desire to feel special impact business perception?

Answer:The desire to feel special can lead business owners to believe their companies are fundamentally different from others, which may prevent them from seeing commonalities across industries. This mindset can hinder their ability to adopt effective strategies that prioritize consumer trust, a

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critical component for success.

4.Question

What common factor unites all businesses, regardless of size or industry?

Answer:Trust is the common factor that unites all businesses.

Regardless of whether a company is B2B or B2C, or offers products or services, building and maintaining consumer trust is essential for sustained success.

5.Question

What challenge does the author pose to readers regarding their business strategies?

Answer:The author challenges readers to confront their preconceived notions and be receptive when faced with suggestions that may seem unconventional. The goal is to not hastily reject new approaches but instead explore their potential applicability.

6.Question

How does the author's experience underline the importance of trust in business?

Answer:The author's experiences, both in the swimming pool

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business and with his consulting company, highlight that success is founded on gaining consumer trust. Regardless of the type of business, focusing on trust ensures better consumer engagement and sales outcomes.

7.Question

What should business leaders do when presented with new ideas that seem impossible to implement?

Answer:Business leaders should resist the urge to dismiss new ideas. Instead, they should evaluate them critically by asking, 'But is it possible?' This introspective approach can lead to adaptations that improve their business practices and strengthen consumer relationships.

8.Question

How does acknowledging commonalities across businesses benefit companies?

Answer:Acknowledging commonalities allows companies to adopt proven strategies that foster trust and engagement. It encourages a focus on shared consumer behaviors rather than an isolated view that can limit innovation and growth.

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Chapter 4 | The Discovery of They Ask, You Answer| Q&A

1.Question

What prompted Marcus Sheridan to look for a new way to save River Pools and Spas?

Answer:Facing imminent financial ruin due to decreased sales, Marcus realized that the traditional ways of advertising were becoming ineffective. He felt the urgency to explore alternative methods to garner leads, given the drastic changes in consumer behavior driven by the Internet, which he saw as an opportunity rather than just a challenge.

2.Question

How did Marcus Sheridan redefine his approach to marketing?

Answer:He shifted from traditional marketing tactics to focusing on inbound and content marketing, emphasizing the importance of teaching and problem-solving for potential customers. This approach stemmed from his understanding that addressing consumer questions directly could build trust

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and attract buyers.

3.Question

What is the core message behind 'They Ask, You Answer'?

Answer:The phrase encapsulates the idea that businesses should focus on answering customer questions transparently. By being a resource for consumers—providing education and solutions—they can earn trust and foster relationships, ultimately leading to increased sales.

4.Question

What role did consumer behavior play in the development of the 'They Ask, You Answer' philosophy?

Answer:As consumers became more informed and empowered through the Internet, they sought information and answers prior to making purchasing decisions. Marcus recognized that businesses needed to adapt to this shift and prioritize addressing these inquiries to remain relevant and competitive.

5.Question

How did Marcus Sheridan's perspective as a consumer

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benefit his business strategy?

Answer: Instead of relying on traditional marketing jargon or methods, his consumer-centric viewpoint allowed him to relate to his audience authentically. This enabled him to simplify complex marketing strategies into actionable insights focused on answering consumer questions, which became the cornerstone of his company's success.

6.Question

What were the initial steps Marcus took to understand and utilize digital marketing?

Answer: He dedicated extra time to reading articles and watching educational videos about leveraging the Internet for business growth. Through platforms like HubSpot, he educated himself on concepts like inbound and content marketing that were previously unfamiliar to him.

7.Question

In what ways did the internet change the landscape of business for Marcus Sheridan?

Answer: The Internet shifted the power dynamics in

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marketing, making traditional methods less effective. Marcus saw it as a tool for direct communication with consumers, allowing businesses to engage more authentically and provide valuable information, thereby attracting leads rather than chasing after them.

8.Question

Why is the idea of being a 'teacher' significant in Marcus's business approach?

Answer:By adopting the role of a teacher, Marcus aimed to offer value through education, fostering trust and credibility with potential customers. This shift was crucial in guiding River Pools and Spas towards successfully adapting to a new market demand driven by informed consumers.

Chapter 5 | “They Ask, You Answer” Defined| Q&A

1.Question

What is the core philosophy of 'They Ask, You Answer'?

Answer:The core philosophy is an obsession with understanding the customer's thoughts, feelings, inquiries, and fears, leading businesses to be the

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go-to source for answers in their industry.

2.Question

How does adopting 'They Ask, You Answer' impact a business's culture?

Answer:It fosters a culture where being a teacher and providing clear answers is seen as a moral obligation, shifting the focus from mere sales to genuine customer understanding and education.

3.Question

In what ways does 'They Ask, You Answer' influence marketing efforts?

Answer:It guides companies in their inbound or content marketing strategies, ensuring that the content created is directly aligned with the questions and needs of the customer.

4.Question

Can you describe how 'They Ask, You Answer' affects the sales process?

Answer:It transforms the sales approach by encouraging transparency and addressing potential customer inquiries

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upfront, leading to a more trust-based relationship between sales teams and prospects.

5.Question

What elements of a business does 'They Ask, You Answer' touch upon?

Answer:It transcends marketing and sales, impacting branding, company culture, and overall business strategies, promoting a holistic approach to responding to customer needs.

6.Question

Why is it crucial for companies to understand what their customers are asking?

Answer:Understanding customer inquiries ensures that businesses can adapt and evolve their offerings, staying relevant and competitive in an ever-changing marketplace.

7.Question

How does the 'They Ask, You Answer' methodology benefit a company long-term?

Answer:By consistently addressing customer questions and concerns, companies build trust, loyalty, and a strong brand

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reputation, enabling sustained growth and success.

8.Question

What common concerns do businesses have when adopting this philosophy?

Answer:Businesses often worry about the feasibility of implementation, how to shift internal culture, and the potential impact on existing practices and profitability.

9.Question

What is the ultimate goal of implementing 'They Ask, You Answer'?

Answer:The ultimate goal is to strengthen a business's positioning in the market by being responsive to customer needs, thereby ensuring long-term success and resilience.

Chapter 6 | Brainstorming the Questions You Are Asked Every Day| Q&A

1.Question

What inspired Marcus Sheridan to start documenting customer questions?

Answer:Marcus realized that understanding customer inquiries was crucial for effective

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communication and building trust. By sitting down late one night at his kitchen table, he brainstormed over a hundred questions he had encountered in his nine years selling swimming pools. This large volume of customer interactions highlighted the need for a more structured approach to address buyer concerns.

2.Question

How did documenting questions evolve into a business philosophy?

Answer: Marcus and his partners used the questions to create informative content, transforming them into articles and videos. This practice became a central component of their marketing strategy and eventually led to the 'They Ask, You Answer' philosophy. It emphasized the importance of addressing customer concerns comprehensively, embodying a teaching mentality to earn trust.

3.Question

What is the paradox Marcus identifies regarding consumer expectations and business messaging?

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Answer: Marcus notes that while modern consumers expect to be provided with information, many businesses focus more on self-promotion rather than addressing buyer questions. This disconnect can hinder trust-building, which is essential for effective business practices.

4.Question

What was the major takeaway from Marcus's brainstorming session about customer questions?

Answer: The major takeaway was that every industry has countless questions from potential buyers, and addressing them thoroughly can significantly influence purchasing decisions. Businesses must focus on providing informative answers to bridge the gap between customer uncertainty and trust.

5.Question

Why did Marcus view each consumer's question as an opportunity rather than a distraction?

Answer: Marcus regarded each question as a chance to educate and engage with customers. By answering

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comprehensively, he positioned himself as a trusted advisor, which ultimately led to increased sales and customer loyalty.

6.Question

What does the 'They Ask, You Answer' philosophy entail?

Answer: This philosophy is about prioritizing customer inquiries and concerns in all business operations. It encourages companies to adopt a teaching role, openly addressing any and all questions a customer might have, thus fostering trust and enhancing the customer experience.

7.Question

How can businesses apply the principles from Marcus's experiences?

Answer: Businesses can implement brainstorming sessions to collect customer questions, then create content that answers those questions thoroughly. They should also ensure that all team members understand the importance of focusing on customer needs and knowledge, rather than only promoting their own offerings.

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Chapter 7 | The Ostrich Marketing Strategy| Q&A

1.Question

What is 'ostrich marketing' and why is it detrimental to businesses?

Answer:Ostrich marketing is the strategy of ignoring customer questions and concerns, akin to an ostrich burying its head in the sand, believing that by avoiding the issue it will go away. This approach is detrimental because it undermines trust—consumers dislike feeling ignored and seek transparency. In a digital age where information is readily available, avoiding these questions can lead to lost sales, reduced customer trust, and ultimately, failure to engage effectively with potential buyers.

2.Question

How can businesses overcome the challenges posed by ostrich marketing?

Answer:To overcome ostrich marketing, businesses should embrace the 'They Ask, You Answer' philosophy. This means

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proactively addressing customer questions and concerns directly on platforms like websites or blogs. By offering transparent answers and valuable content, businesses can build trust, showcase expertise, and improve customer relationships. The more openly businesses communicate, the better they can connect with their audience, leading to increased sales and customer loyalty.

3.Question

Why is transparency important in a digital marketing strategy?

Answer: Transparency is crucial in digital marketing because today's consumers value authenticity and honesty. With so much information at their fingertips, potential customers compare brands and make informed decisions based on trustworthiness. By being transparent about products, services, and addressing concerns honestly, businesses can differentiate themselves from competitors using ostrich marketing, ultimately leading to better customer relationships.

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4.Question

Can you provide an example of how addressing difficult questions can lead to success?

Answer:Yes! For example, a home renovation company might typically avoid discussing the high cost of projects on their website. However, by openly discussing project costs and providing clear estimates, they can demystify the renovation process for potential clients. Customers appreciate this honesty and are more likely to reach out for consultations, enhancing trust and ultimately leading to more successful sales conversions.

5.Question

What are the consequences if a business continues using ostrich marketing?

Answer:If a business continues to implement ostrich marketing, it risks failing to connect with consumers, leading to declining sales and loss of market share. As consumers become increasingly disillusioned with brands that ignore their questions, they will turn to competitors who provide the

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information and transparency they seek, thus damaging the brand's reputation and long-term success.

6.Question

What is the main takeaway from the chapter regarding marketing strategies?

Answer:The main takeaway is to avoid ostrich marketing by proactively addressing customer inquiries and concerns.

Embracing the strategy of 'They Ask, You Answer' can significantly enhance your marketing effectiveness, build trust with your audience, and ultimately lead to increased sales and customer loyalty.

Chapter 8 | The CarMax Effect| Q&A

1.Question

What is the main philosophy behind 'They Ask, You Answer'?

Answer:It's a business philosophy that emphasizes being highly focused and obsessive about understanding consumer questions, wants, desires, and needs, to the extent that a company is willing to

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evolve its entire business model around these elements.

2.Question

How did CarMax gain trust in the used car market?

Answer:CarMax gained trust by implementing 'no-haggle pricing' which simplified the sales process for consumers, and by establishing a flat-rate commission structure for its sales team, thereby aligning their incentives with customer satisfaction rather than personal profit.

3.Question

What innovative policy did CarMax introduce to eliminate buyer's remorse?

Answer:CarMax introduced a five-day money-back guarantee, allowing customers to return their purchased vehicle if it wasn't right for them within the first week.

4.Question

How does CarMax address the fear of buying a 'lemon'?

Answer:They demonstrate a rigorous inspection process for their vehicles and provide a CarFax report for each car, thus ensuring that customers feel reassured about the quality and

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history of the vehicles.

5.Question

What can other businesses learn from the CarMax model?

Answer:Other businesses can learn the importance of listening to consumer fears and concerns, addressing them head-on, and fundamentally changing their business strategies to build trust with customers.

6.Question

How does 'They Ask, You Answer' propose businesses should approach questions from customers?

Answer:Businesses should adopt the mindset of being teachers, focusing on answering every question that prospects or customers may have, thereby establishing themselves as trustworthy sources in their industry.

7.Question

What significant change has occurred in consumer buying patterns according to the text?

Answer:There has been a monumental shift in consumer buying patterns, where approximately 70% of buying

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decision-making occurs before a consumer even contacts the business, indicating that businesses must adapt their marketing strategies accordingly.

8.Question

What is the consequence of ignoring consumer questions and concerns in marketing?

Answer: Ignoring consumer questions leads to a lack of trust, ultimately resulting in lost sales and missed opportunities for businesses.

9.Question

How does CarMax exemplify a shift in the used car industry?

Answer: CarMax's approach exemplifies a shift by not only addressing but actively eliminating common fears associated with buying used cars through transparent policies and practices that foster trust.

10.Question

What is the 'CarMax Effect' as described in the text?

Answer: The 'CarMax Effect' refers to the substantial and positive change in consumer trust and sales performance

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achieved by companies willing to acknowledge consumer fears and adapt their business practices in response.

Chapter 9 | The Discovery of the Big 5| Q&A

1.Question

What impact did publishing content have on River Pools and Spas' website traffic and leads?

Answer:Publishing four to five pieces of content each week on the River Pools and Spas website resulted in increased web traffic, more leads, and even a few sales. This activity educated potential customers, making them more qualified by the time they approached for a purchase.

2.Question

What are the 'Big 5' questions consumers often search for when making purchasing decisions?

Answer:The 'Big 5' questions include: 1) Pricing and Costs
2) Problems Versus Comparisons 3) Reviews 4) Best in Class
5) Overall insights into these subjects significantly influence consumer behavior across all industries.

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3.Question

How do businesses generally respond to the 'Big 5' questions compared to consumers?

Answer:While consumers obsess over these questions before making purchases, businesses often ignore or hide from them, hoping they will go away or only addressing them in direct interactions with buyers.

4.Question

Why is it critical for businesses to address the 'Big 5' in their strategies?

Answer:Addressing the 'Big 5' not only builds trust with potential customers but also improves visibility to search engines, which is essential for driving traffic and leads.

5.Question

What can be expected in the following chapters after introducing the 'Big 5'?

Answer:The following chapters will cover each of the 'Big 5' subjects in detail, providing specific strategies for businesses to effectively engage with these critical topics, thereby enhancing their market presence and relationship with

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Chapter 10 | Content Subject 1 Pricing and Costs: Why We Must Talk about Money| Q&A

1.Question

Why is it important to talk about pricing on a company's website?

Answer:Customers overwhelmingly feel frustrated when they can't find pricing information, as it signals a lack of transparency and can erode trust in the brand. Discussing pricing helps to establish trust and demonstrates that a company values its customers' right to know.

2.Question

What emotions do customers experience when pricing is not addressed on a business's website?

Answer:Frustration and distrust are the main emotions felt when customers cannot find cost-related information. They feel like their time is wasted and perceive the business as hiding information from them.

3.Question

What are the three common reasons businesses avoid

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discussing pricing on their websites?

Answer:1. 'Every solution is different; our prices vary.' 2. 'If we discuss pricing, our competitors will know what we charge.' 3. 'Showing prices will scare customers away.'

4.Question

How can businesses address the claim that their prices vary for different solutions?

Answer:While it's true that solutions may vary, businesses can provide potential pricing ranges and explain factors affecting pricing, which helps set proper expectations for customers.

5.Question

Why is the argument 'if we show pricing, it will scare customers away' seen as flawed?

Answer:This perception is flawed because customers prefer honesty. They are more scared by a lack of pricing information, which breeds doubts and may lead them to seek alternatives elsewhere.

6.Question

How can one earn trust through transparency about

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pricing?

Answer:By openly discussing costs and pricing, businesses can eliminate doubts and show customers that they have nothing to hide. Transparency about pricing creates a foundation for trust, leading to more customer engagement.

7.Question

What is the significance of the question 'Do you talk a lot about the cost of your products or services on your company site?'

Answer:This reflective question encourages businesses to consider their own practices regarding transparency. If they do not mention pricing, they may lose potential customers to competitors who do.

8.Question

How can businesses overcome the issue of competitors finding out their pricing?

Answer:In practice, most companies are already aware of each other's pricing, so it is more important to focus on educating customers to build trust than to hide information

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that is likely already known.

9.Question

Can discussing pricing and costs actually increase customer inquiries and sales?

Answer:Yes, by proactively answering their pricing-related questions, businesses can position themselves as trusted resources, which often results in increased customer inquiries and ultimately higher sales.

10.Question

How does the concept of 'They Ask, You Answer' apply to pricing discussions?

Answer:This concept emphasizes that businesses should listen to and respond to customer concerns and queries, including about pricing, ultimately fostering trust and increasing the likelihood of closing sales.

Chapter 11 | How One Article about Money Generated More Than \$3,000,000 in Sales| Q&A

1.Question

Why is it important to discuss pricing openly with customers?

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Answer: Discussing pricing openly satisfies a key consumer need for transparency and trust.

Customers want to know how much things cost before investing their time and effort into learning more about products or services. By addressing pricing, businesses can avoid losing potential customers frustrated by vague or hidden costs.

2.Question

What was the impact of writing the article about the cost of fiberglass pools?

Answer: The article generated over \$3 million in sales for River Pools. It quickly became one of the top-ranking articles on Google for relevant searches, attracting over a million new visitors and converting many into leads and customers simply because it answered the question of cost openly and honestly.

3.Question

What common myths do businesses believe about discussing costs?

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Answer: Businesses often believe: 1) every solution is unique and costs vary significantly, making it hard to provide estimates; 2) disclosing pricing lets competitors discover their rates; and 3) openly discussing prices may scare potential customers away.

4.Question

What does the principle 'They Ask, You Answer' mean?

Answer: It emphasizes the importance of addressing the common questions and concerns of consumers, particularly regarding costs. Businesses adopting this philosophy strive to educate and inform their customers rather than avoiding tough topics.

5.Question

What results did River Pools experience after embracing transparency in pricing?

Answer: After acting on their openness about costs, River Pools saw a dramatic increase in qualified leads and customer trust. Many prospects expressed appreciation for a company willing to discuss pricing, ultimately leading to

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increased sales and business sustainability.

6.Question

How can companies improve their content marketing based on this chapter?

Answer:Companies should identify common consumer questions related to pricing and costs, create content that answers these questions thoughtfully, and ensure this content is accessible on their websites. This transparency can significantly enhance lead quality and customer trust.

7.Question

What is the role of consumer trust in today's marketplace according to the author?

Answer:Consumer trust is essential for businesses to thrive. The modern consumer seeks transparency and honesty; companies that successfully build trust will see better engagement, loyalty, and ultimately, sales.

8.Question

What lesson does the author convey regarding traditional business practices and consumer needs?

Answer:The author argues that many traditional business

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practices, such as avoiding discussions about money, are outdated. Forward-thinking businesses recognize that addressing consumer needs, especially around pricing, is critical to maintaining competitiveness in a rapidly evolving marketplace.

9.Question

What practical step can companies take today based on the insights from this chapter?

Answer:Companies should begin by listing major products and services, identifying the most significant pricing questions they receive, and creating content that explains these factors transparently. This proactive approach can lead to better informed customers and stronger sales.

10.Question

How does being open about pricing affect customer relationships?

Answer:Being open about pricing fosters trust and encourages customers to engage with a company rather than turn to competitors. When customers feel informed and

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empowered, they are more likely to make a purchase decision and view the company favorably.

Chapter 12 | Case Study 1 High-End B2B Technology Company Generates More Than \$8,000,000 in Additional Revenue| Q&A

1.Question

What was the pivotal moment for Segue Technologies in adopting a new business philosophy?

Answer:The pivotal moment for Segue Technologies occurred during a workshop led by Marcus Sheridan in January 2013. This workshop highlighted the importance of content and transparency through the 'They Ask, You Answer' philosophy. Ron Novak realized the simple but powerful concept of answering customer questions and embraced it, leading to a significant shift in their business model.

2.Question

How did Segue Technologies generate over \$8 million in additional revenue?

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Answer:Segue Technologies generated over \$8 million in additional revenue by implementing a robust content marketing strategy based on the 'They Ask, You Answer' philosophy. They focused on creating informative content that addressed customer questions, optimizing their website for higher traffic, and enhancing lead quality. Their efforts led to a substantial increase in website visitors, from less than 1,000 to over 30,000 per month.

3.Question

What role did employee involvement play in Segue's content strategy?

Answer:Employee involvement was crucial to Segue's content strategy. Ron Novak mandated that every employee contribute to the company's content strategy by writing at least one blog post per quarter. This collective effort of knowledge sharing empowered the employees, enriched the content diversity, and helped drive traffic and leads to the site.

4.Question

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Can you explain what 'They Ask, You Answer' means?

Answer: 'They Ask, You Answer' is a business philosophy that centers around understanding and addressing the questions, concerns, and needs of customers. This approach emphasizes transparency, education, and being a reliable source of information for consumers, which builds trust and ultimately drives sales.

5.Question

What were some initial challenges Segue faced before adopting new strategies?

Answer: Initially, Segue Technologies was experiencing comfortable growth through organic means but struggled with website traffic and attracting new clients in a more competitive commercial space. Their marketing efforts relied heavily on word of mouth and networking, and they did not effectively utilize their website or content to capture new leads.

6.Question

How did Segue differentiate itself from its competitors?

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Answer:Segue differentiated itself from competitors by embracing transparency and addressing important yet often overlooked questions within the industry, like pricing and services, which other competitors shied away from. This approach established them as thought leaders and educators in the tech space.

7.Question

What changes did Segue make to improve the quality of leads generated from their website?

Answer:To improve lead quality, Segue altered their contact forms to solicit more specific information, thus reducing the number of leads but increasing the quality of each lead. They shifted focus towards attracting ideal customers instead of just increasing traffic.

8.Question

What was the significance of the content published by Segue and its impact on growth?

Answer:The content Segue published, particularly articles addressing popular consumer questions, led to significant

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organic traffic growth and increased lead generation. Their top-ranking articles helped establish trust and credibility, resulting in a dramatic increase in both traffic and subsequent conversions.

9.Question

What lessons can be drawn from Segue's approach to content marketing?

Answer:Lessons from Segue's approach include the importance of listening to customer needs, being transparent about pricing, involving the entire team in content creation, and continuously optimizing content for better engagement and lead quality. These practices can lead to remarkable business growth and customer relationships.

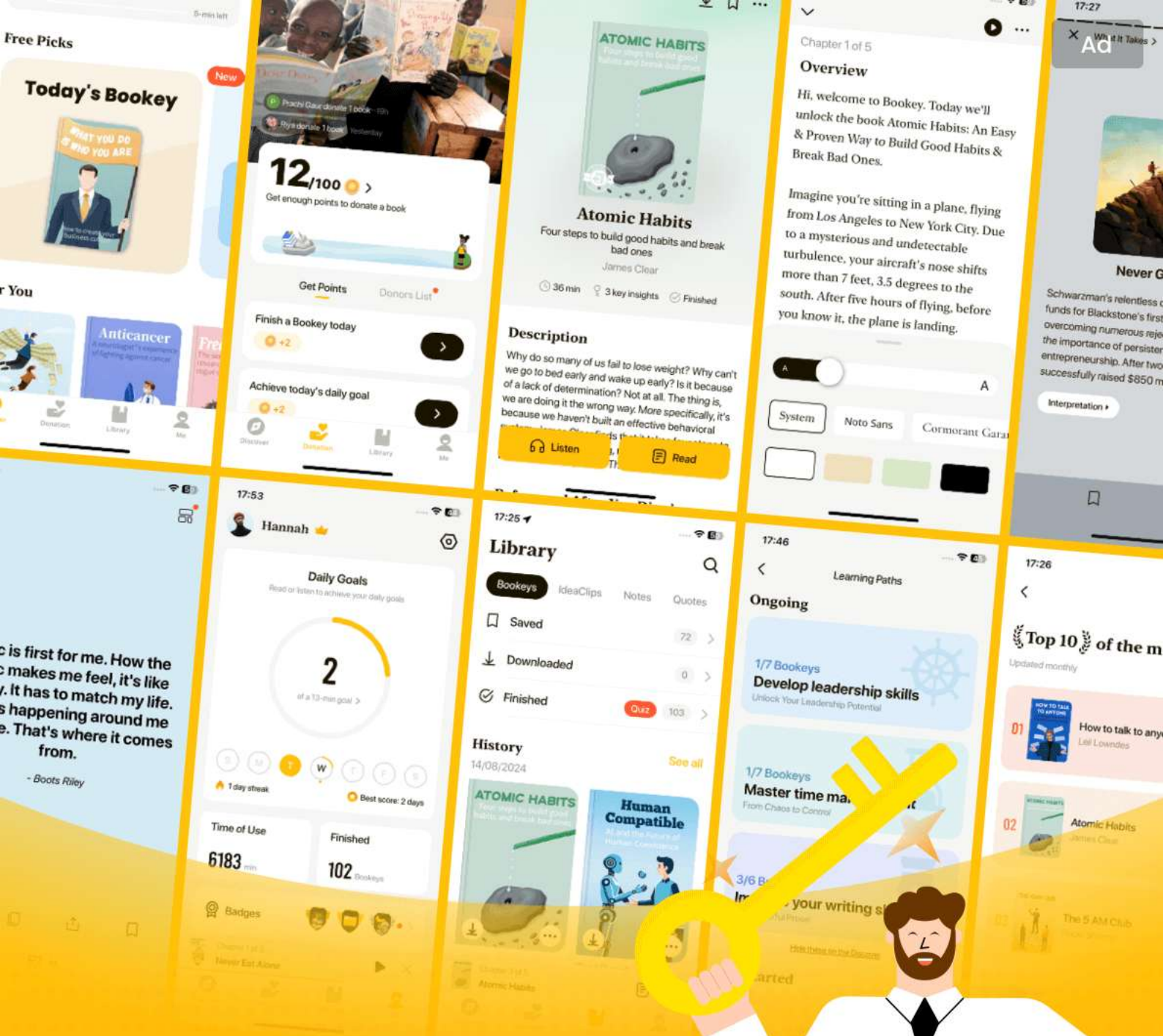
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Chapter 13 | Content Subject 2 Problems: How to Turn Weaknesses into Strengths| Q&A

1.Question

Why do consumers focus on negative reviews instead of positive ones when making a purchase?

Answer: Consumers are inherently risk-averse, often worrying more about potential negatives than the positives when buying something. For instance, someone considering a car purchase will likely search for 'negative reviews' to understand potential problems they might face, rather than just seeking out the good things about the car.

2.Question

What is the challenge faced by a salesperson when competitors highlight the weaknesses of their product?

Answer: A salesperson's challenge arises when competitors, like Concrete Joe in the pool example, exaggerate the weaknesses of their product to sow doubt in the customer's mind. This can create a moral dilemma for the buyer who may like the product but now fears potential issues, forcing

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them to seek negative information online.

3.Question

How can understanding consumer fears shape content strategy for businesses?

Answer:By recognizing that consumers prioritize their concerns about potential problems, businesses can create content that directly addresses these fears. For example, addressing common concerns about fiberglass pools and outlining their strengths can help alleviate buyer hesitation and increase sales.

4.Question

What should a business do to convert consumer concerns into strengths?

Answer:A business should proactively address common worries by providing transparent information about their products, including potential weaknesses and how they mitigate them. This builds trust with consumers and presents the business as honest and customer-focused.

5.Question

Why is it important to acknowledge weaknesses in a

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marketing strategy?

Answer: Acknowledging weaknesses allows a business to build credibility with its audience. When a company openly discusses potential issues with their product, it shows confidence and can mitigate skepticism, leading to stronger consumer trust and ultimately making the positives more compelling.

Chapter 14 | Addressing the Elephant in the Room| Q&A

1.Question

What is the significance of addressing the elephant in the room in business?

Answer: Addressing the elephant in the room means openly acknowledging and discussing potential problems or concerns regarding your product or service. This approach builds trust with consumers, as it shows transparency and honesty. When you address these concerns upfront, instead of allowing customers to discover them on their own, you

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strengthen your brand's credibility and relationship with your audience.

2.Question

How did Marcus Sheridan and his team approach the question about problems with fiberglass pools?

Answer:Instead of evading the question, they embraced it by writing an article titled 'Top 5 Fiberglass Pool Problems and Solutions.' This proactive approach allowed them to directly address consumer concerns, making potential buyers feel informed and respected. By doing so, they stood out from competitors who overlooked such topics.

3.Question

Why do consumers appreciate businesses that address their concerns directly?

Answer:Consumers appreciate directness because it empowers them with knowledge. When businesses address potential issues, it dismantles any doubt or mistrust the customer may have. This transparency fosters a stronger bond between the customer and the business, ultimately

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leading to more informed purchase decisions and customer satisfaction.

4.Question

What potential drawbacks of fiberglass pools did Sheridan acknowledge?

Answer: Sheridan acknowledged that buying a fiberglass swimming pool might not suit everyone. He mentioned that some people may find fiberglass pools too narrow, not customizable enough, or not deep enough for their preferences. By presenting these considerations, he was realistic and honest about the limitations, helping consumers make choices that align with their needs.

5.Question

How can addressing elephants in the room impact a company's reputation?

Answer: Addressing elephants in the room can significantly enhance a company's reputation. It demonstrates integrity and a customer-first mentality, which can lead to increased customer loyalty and positive word-of-mouth promotion.

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Companies that openly discuss potential downsides and transparently provide solutions can differentiate themselves as trustworthy and customer-centric.

6.Question

What was the overarching lesson from this chapter regarding customer communication?

Answer:The overarching lesson is that honest, transparent communication regarding challenges or limitations is essential in building trust and credibility with customers. By addressing difficult questions, businesses can not only enhance their reputation but also empower their customers to make informed decisions, ultimately leading to greater satisfaction and loyalty.

Chapter 15 | How Talking about Our Problems Generated More Than \$500,000 in Revenue| Q&A

1.Question

What key benefit did the author discover from embracing problems in their content?

Answer:Embracing problems allowed the author to build trust with consumers, resulting in over

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\$500,000 additional revenue from a single article addressing those problems.

2.Question

How did talking about problems transform consumer trust?

Answer:By openly discussing potential problems related to fiberglass pools, the author positioned their company as transparent and trustworthy, leading consumers to feel more confident in their purchasing decisions.

3.Question

What did the data reveal about online behavior regarding consumers' concerns?

Answer:Data showed that over 260,000 visitors searched for 'problems' related to fiberglass pools, indicating a significant interest in addressing these concerns before buying.

4.Question

What lesson can businesses learn from the author's approach to addressing their industry's problems?

Answer:Businesses should not shy away from discussing potential weaknesses or issues; doing so can differentiate

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them from competitors and foster trust with consumers.

5.Question

What is the fundamental question businesses should ask regarding customer concerns?

Answer:Businesses should ask how many prospective customers have questioned them about potential issues, as many others likely share those concerns.

6.Question

Why is it important for companies to talk about the issues they face?

Answer:Talking about issues humanizes the company and allows consumers to find answers directly from the source, increasing the likelihood of trust and sales.

7.Question

What significant impact did the author find from addressing problems on their website?

Answer:Addressing problems generated substantial traffic to the website and ultimately led to increased leads and sales, demonstrating the power of transparency.

8.Question

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What hypothetical reaction did potential customers have towards addressing problems directly?

Answer: Potential customers likely felt relief and gratitude, thinking, 'Finally, somebody was willing to address this question!'

9.Question

How can addressing weaknesses become a strength for a business?

Answer: By honestly acknowledging and addressing weaknesses, a business can turn them into selling points, showcasing their commitment to transparency and customer service.

10.Question

What should a business prioritize in their content strategy according to the author's findings?

Answer: A business should prioritize addressing common consumer questions and concerns to build trust and improve conversion rates.

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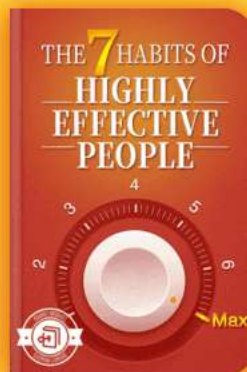


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Chapter 16 | Case Study 2 An Equipment Financing Company Becomes a Digital David and Conquers the Industry Goliaths| Q&A

1.Question

What inspired Rob Misheloff to start Smarter Finance USA?

Answer:Rob Misheloff was inspired to start Smarter Finance USA after realizing that many competitors in the equipment financing industry were misleading customers. He wanted to create a business that genuinely helped people access financial information transparently and honestly.

2.Question

How did Rob Misheloff transition from direct mail marketing to digital marketing?

Answer:Misheloff transitioned to digital marketing when he realized that his previous methods of direct mailing were no longer effective in the equipment financing market. He began leveraging the web to generate leads, finding that online content could more effectively educate and attract clients.

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3.Question

What pivotal resource did Misheloff discover that changed his approach to business?

Answer:Misheloff discovered the book 'They Ask, You Answer' by Marcus Sheridan, which profoundly impacted him and made him realize the importance of being transparent and focused on consumer education in his business strategy.

4.Question

What types of content did Misheloff create to attract leads?

Answer:Misheloff created a variety of content aimed at educating small business owners, including articles addressing common questions about equipment financing, potential scams, and the problems within the leasing industry. This approach helped build trust among consumers.

5.Question

How did Misheloff's website traffic and leads improve after implementing the 'They Ask, You Answer' philosophy?

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Answer:After implementing the 'They Ask, You Answer' philosophy, Misheloff's website traffic doubled nearly every two to three months, growing from just a few hundred visits to over 25,000 in late 2015, and he generated thousands of new leads from educated prospects.

6.Question

What specific results did Misheloff achieve in terms of revenue after applying content marketing?

Answer:In the first quarter of 2016, Misheloff closed thirty transactions totaling \$2,045,000 in fundings, resulting in approximately \$144,112 in revenues. His ability to provide transparent content directly correlated with increased sales.

7.Question

What challenges did Misheloff face when starting his new venture?

Answer:Misheloff faced significant challenges in establishing trust with potential loan clients since his initial efforts in digital marketing, such as spam emails and pay-per-click ads, were ineffective in generating the needed

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leads.

8.Question

How did audience engagement change after Misheloff began addressing difficult questions openly?

Answer:After Misheloff began addressing difficult questions and providing transparency about equipment financing, he received more engagement from potential clients who appreciated his honesty, which ultimately led to increased trust and sales.

9.Question

What is the key lesson from Rob Misheloff's success story?

Answer:The key lesson from Rob Misheloff's success story is that transparency and addressing consumer concerns directly can lead to building trust, which is crucial for success in any competitive market.

10.Question

How does Misheloff view his business size in relation to his competition?

Answer:Misheloff views his smaller business size as a

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significant advantage in the digital age because it allows for more agility and quicker decision-making compared to larger corporations, enabling him to better serve his clients.

Chapter 17 | Content Subject 3 Versus and Comparisons| Q&A

1.Question

Why are comparisons important for consumers making purchasing decisions?

Answer: Consumers are naturally inclined to compare options before making a purchase. They want to know the best and worst choices available, and having information at their fingertips enhances this desire. When faced with a significant purchase, such as a new car or home appliance, they often research multiple options, weighing their pros and cons to ensure they choose the best option for their needs.

2.Question

What was the main question potential customers had regarding fiberglass pools compared to other types?

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Answer: Many potential customers frequently asked, 'Why should I consider a fiberglass pool over a concrete one?' This question arose due to misconceptions and criticisms from competitors, leading to a need for clear, unbiased comparisons.

3.Question

How did River Pools and Spas begin to address consumer questions more effectively?

Answer: By adopting the 'They Ask, You Answer' philosophy, River Pools created content that addressed frequently asked questions from consumers, including comprehensive comparisons between fiberglass, concrete, and vinyl liner pools. This openness allowed them to establish themselves as a trusted source of information.

4.Question

What was the result of River Pools and Spas creating an article comparing different pool types?

Answer: After publishing the article 'Fiberglass Pools vs. Vinyl Liner Pools vs. Concrete Pools: An Honest

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Comparison,' the company received a significant increase in web traffic and consumer trust. Search engines rewarded their transparency, aiding them in becoming a go-to source for pool information online.

5.Question

Why is the concept of 'ostrich marketing' harmful in business?

Answer:Ostrich marketing refers to ignoring potential consumer questions and concerns, hoping they will just go away. This strategy destroys trust and fails to acknowledge consumer awareness. In the age of information, consumers are likely to research and find answers elsewhere if not provided by the company, leading to lost opportunities.

6.Question

What action can businesses take to improve customer trust based on this chapter's insights?

Answer:Businesses should actively identify and address all relevant questions and comparisons potential customers might have. This includes creating detailed content that

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answers these questions transparently and accurately across their marketing platforms, ultimately guiding consumers in their decision-making process.

7.Question

How can businesses benefit from addressing comparison-based questions in their marketing efforts?

Answer:By focusing on comparison-based questions, businesses can attract informed and well-prepared buyers. This reduces the number of 'bad-fit' leads and increases the quality of prospects, leading to higher conversion rates and ultimately boosting revenue.

8.Question

What does the author suggest companies do to develop their content around consumer questions?

Answer:The author encourages businesses to create a comprehensive list of questions they receive from prospects and customers, focusing on comparisons and concerns. By addressing these questions through blogs, videos, and other content formats, companies can align their marketing with

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consumer needs and establish trust.

9.Question

What was the initial reaction of River Pools employees to the 'They Ask, You Answer' approach?

Answer:Initially, many employees may have been skeptical about discussing competitors or challenges openly due to their fears of losing business or revealing weaknesses.

However, once they embraced transparency and began answering consumer questions, it ultimately led to greater trust and higher sales.

10.Question

Why is it crucial for companies to understand what their customers are thinking?

Answer:Understanding consumer perceptions and anxieties enables companies to tailor their messaging and content to effectively address the market's needs. This builds trust and confidence amongst consumers, ensuring they choose the company as their preferred option over competitors.

Chapter 18 | The Critical Need for Unbiased Content| Q&A

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1.Question

Why is unbiased content critical for building consumer trust?

Answer:Unbiased content is essential because it addresses the concerns and questions consumers have about products and services. When businesses openly share both the pros and cons of what they offer, they demonstrate honesty and transparency. This approach fosters trust because consumers feel informed and confident in their purchasing decisions. For instance, if a company provides a detailed comparison of its products along with potential drawbacks, consumers are more likely to believe that the company genuinely cares about their interests.

2.Question

How can businesses effectively overcome the challenge of sounding biased in their communication?

Answer:Businesses can overcome bias by practicing

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disarmament. This involves acknowledging the limitations of their products openly, stating upfront who their offerings may not be right for, and providing a balanced view that highlights both strengths and weaknesses. For example, a pool company might say, 'We specialize in fiberglass pools, but depending on your needs, a concrete pool might be a better fit for you.' This approach not only builds credibility but also aligns with consumer desires for transparency.

3.Question

What steps can a company take to implement a successful ‘They Ask, You Answer’ strategy?

Answer: To implement this strategy, a company should start by brainstorming a list of questions customers frequently ask. They should then create content that answers these questions in an informative and unbiased manner. This content can take the form of articles, videos, or FAQs on the website.

Regularly updating and expanding this content helps ensure that the business remains relevant and that it continuously earns consumer trust. By proactively addressing the concerns

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of consumers, businesses can position themselves as trusted resources.

4.Question

Can you provide an example of how transparent content led to increased sales?

Answer:Yes, a clear example comes from a swimming pool company that published an article answering the question, 'How much does a fiberglass pool cost?' Prior to this, very few companies addressed pricing openly, fearing it would scare customers away. However, by providing a transparent discussion around costs and factors influencing them, that article generated unprecedented traffic and qualified leads, resulting in over \$3 million in sales within just a few years. It demonstrated that consumers appreciate honest information and are willing to engage with companies that provide it.

5.Question

What are the potential dangers of 'ostrich marketing' and why should businesses avoid it?

Answer:‘Ostrich marketing’ refers to ignoring customer

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questions and problems in hopes they will go away. This approach can damage trust and customer relationships because it assumes consumers are uninformed. In reality, consumers will seek answers elsewhere, often leading them to competitors who do address these concerns. Businesses should avoid ostrich marketing by being proactive in addressing all inquiries and using them as opportunities to educate customers, thereby building credibility and loyalty.

6.Question

How do businesses benefit from discussing the problems associated with their products?

Answer:Discussing potential problems openly allows businesses to demonstrate transparency and reliability. When a company addresses consumer concerns head-on—like by listing common issues and their solutions—it reassures potential buyers that the business is trustworthy and knowledgeable. This practice not only fosters loyalty but can also lead to increased sales, as customers appreciate honest dialogue. For example, a company that acknowledges the

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downsides of its product while providing solutions can turn potential objections into selling points.

7.Question

Why is it essential for businesses to see themselves as teachers in their industry?

Answer:By viewing themselves as teachers, businesses can prioritize educating consumers about their products and services. This shifts the focus from merely selling to genuinely helping customers make informed decisions. A knowledgeable consumer is more likely to engage with a brand that provides valuable insights rather than simply pushing products. This educational approach ultimately enhances trust and loyalty, benefiting the business in the long run.

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Chapter 19 | Content Subjects 4 and 5 Reviews and Best in Class| Q&A

1.Question

What are the key elements of customer trust in business according to Marcus Sheridan?

Answer:The key elements of customer trust as outlined by Marcus Sheridan include honesty, transparency, and a focus on consumer education. Businesses should embrace consumer questions, openly address potential weaknesses or problems, and shift their philosophy to be more teaching-oriented, thus establishing themselves as trustworthy resources.

2.Question

How did River Pools and Spas leverage the concept of reviews and comparisons to build their brand?

Answer:River Pools and Spas created content that compared different types of pools, openly discussing the pros and cons of fiberglass versus concrete pools. By doing so, they positioned themselves as unbiased educators in the industry,

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which attracted significant web traffic and enhanced customer trust.

3.Question

What was the impact of addressing pricing openly on River Pools' sales?

Answer:By openly discussing the costs associated with fiberglass pools – something competitors avoided – River Pools experienced a major increase in web traffic and sales. One specific article about pool costs alone generated over \$3 million in additional sales, highlighting the importance of transparency in pricing.

4.Question

Why is it crucial for businesses to address potential problems or concerns regarding their products?

Answer:Addressing potential problems builds trust.

Consumers want to know the real issues they might face; by openly acknowledging these and providing solutions, businesses can prevent misinformation and uncertainty, ultimately fostering greater customer loyalty.

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5.Question

What does the phrase 'They Ask, You Answer' signify in the context of modern marketing?

Answer:'They Ask, You Answer' signifies a marketing approach where businesses prioritize understanding and responding to consumer inquiries. This method turns business communication into a teaching opportunity, fostering trust and establishing authority in the market.

6.Question

How did Marcus Sheridan's experience shift the approach at River Pools and Spas?

Answer:Marcus Sheridan's experiences of facing bankruptcy led him to embrace customer-facing transparency about costs and problems. This revolutionary approach transformed River Pools' content strategy, resulting in increased leads, sales, and brand trust.

7.Question

What strategy did CarMax use to gain customer trust in the used car market?

Answer:CarMax utilized a no-haggle pricing model and

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offered consumers a five-day money-back guarantee. This eliminated the common fears associated with buying used cars, such as the pressure of negotiation, buyer's remorse, and the risk of purchasing a defective vehicle.

8.Question

What actions did River Pools and Spas take to differentiate themselves in a competitive market?

Answer:They created unique content that answered consumer questions, tackled industry challenges head-on, and offered thorough explanations of their products. This not only improved their visibility in online search results but also positioned them as leaders in consumer education within their industry.

9.Question

How can businesses utilize customer feedback in a constructive way as per the teachings of Marcus Sheridan?

Answer:Businesses can use customer feedback to identify frequently asked questions or concerns about their products and openly address these on their websites and marketing

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materials. This creates a more informed consumer base and counters misinformation during the buying process.

10.Question

What does Marcus Sheridan suggest businesses should do to stay relevant in the digital age?

Answer:Businesses need to focus on producing meaningful content that answers consumer questions directly and transparently. By aligning their strategies with the evolving digital landscape and prioritizing consumer needs, they can ensure relevance and success.

Chapter 20 | Using Reviews to Establish Yourself as an Expert| Q&A

1.Question

Why is it important to answer the question about recommending competitors honestly?

Answer:Answering the question about recommending competitors honestly builds trust with potential customers. When you acknowledge other companies that are good in your industry, it shows you are confident in your own abilities and

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not afraid of competition. This transparency sets you apart as an expert and thought leader, making you more relatable and trustworthy in the eyes of potential clients.

2.Question

How does creating a list of competitors enhance my credibility?

Answer:By creating a list of competitors, you position yourself as an informational resource rather than just a salesperson trying to make a sale. This demonstrates that you prioritize the customer's needs and are willing to help them make an informed decision, which enhances your credibility and authority in your field.

3.Question

What is the significance of not including yourself in the list of best competitors?

Answer:Not including yourself in the list of best competitors is significant because it strengthens your integrity and credibility. If you were to list yourself among the best, it

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could seem self-serving and diminish the trust potential customers have in you. Instead, by providing an unbiased review of the competitors, you build a stronger relationship based on honesty.

4.Question

How can this strategy of transparency affect a company's brand?

Answer: This strategy of transparency can positively affect a company's brand by distinguishing it from others that may be more defensive or self-promoting. By being open and honest, a company can cultivate a reputation for integrity, which leads to stronger customer loyalty, word-of-mouth referrals, and ultimately, a healthier bottom line.

5.Question

What lesson can be drawn from the author's experience with that sales appointment?

Answer: The author's experience with the sales appointment teaches us that addressing potential concerns and questions upfront, even if they make us uncomfortable, is crucial for

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building rapport and trust. Instead of focusing solely on selling, being honest about the competitive landscape can lead to greater authority and respect in your industry.

6.Question

What overall principle does this chapter emphasize in content marketing?

Answer: This chapter emphasizes the principle of honesty and transparency in content marketing. It conveys that sharing genuine information and insights, including acknowledging competitors, can lead to a stronger connection with audience, enhancing credibility, and fostering a sense of trust that ultimately benefits the business's brand and success.

Chapter 21 | The Impact of Discussing the Competition| Q&A

1.Question

How did discussing the competition impact your visibility online?

Answer: Discussing the competition allowed our articles to rank first in Google when users searched for 'Best Pool Builders in Richmond, Virginia'. It

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positioned us as a trusted source of information, even outranking established websites like the Better Business Bureau and Angie's List.

2.Question

What was the key result of writing the article about the best pool builders?

Answer:The article resulted in profound business outcomes, generating \$150,000 in sales in its first year. It introduced us to customers we otherwise wouldn't have reached.

3.Question

How did consumer trust play a role in your sales?

Answer:By being transparent and honest in our content, we were able to establish trust with potential customers. For instance, one customer decided to buy a \$50,000 swimming pool from us after reading our article, believing in our honesty.

4.Question

What is the significance of consumer ignorance according to your experience?

Answer:Consumer ignorance is no longer a viable sales

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strategy. Buyers will always seek information about competitors, and if we don't provide that upfront, they will find it elsewhere.

5.Question

How did your competitors react to your transparency about the competition?

Answer:Surprisingly, many competitors thanked us for writing an article about them, which shows that even they recognize the value of honesty in business.

6.Question

Why is it essential for businesses to embrace discussions about their competitors?

Answer:Embracing discussions about competitors allows companies to enter important conversations, build trust, and position themselves as industry authorities.

7.Question

Can addressing difficult questions about pricing and competition lead to more sales?

Answer:Yes, addressing such questions leads to increased transparency and trust, making potential customers more

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likely to engage and ultimately purchase.

8.Question

What lessons can be learned from the story of the lady who almost signed with Pla-Mor?

Answer:Her decision to research and find our honest content before signing with a competitor shows the importance of addressing common consumer questions openly.

9.Question

How did one article transform your business's trajectory?

Answer:One article about pool costs not only drew over a million visitors but also directly contributed to over \$3 million in sales, illustrating the economic value of transparency.

10.Question

What should businesses focus on when creating content to establish trust with consumers?

Answer:Businesses should focus on answering customer questions openly and honestly, particularly about pricing, problems, and comparisons with competitors. This builds trust and credibility.

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Chapter 22 | Case Study 3 Small Retail Appliance Store Dominates Online and Makes Millions| Q&A

1.Question

How did Yale Appliance become a leading online resource in the kitchen appliance space despite being a smaller brand than major manufacturers?

Answer: Yale Appliance became a leading online resource by focusing on customer needs and addressing their questions through informative content such as educational articles and buyer's guides. Instead of competing directly with larger brands through traditional advertising, they prioritized transparency and honesty in their communications, thus building trust with consumers.

2.Question

What strategies did CEO Steve Sheinkopf implement to enhance Yale Appliance's marketing approach?

Answer: Steve Sheinkopf embraced content marketing by launching a business blog in 2007, which allowed his

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company to take control of online conversations about kitchen appliances. He also focused on producing content that genuinely helped consumers, addressing their questions and concerns with transparency.

3.Question

What was the impact of Yale Appliance's shift to content marketing and transparency on their business revenue?

Answer: Since adopting a content marketing strategy, Yale Appliance's website traffic doubled nearly every year, resulting in over \$10 million in annual sales from online efforts alone, with no expenditure on traditional advertising.

4.Question

How did Yale Appliance tackle the tough questions in the appliance industry?

Answer: Yale Appliance continued to write articles addressing difficult subjects, even those that could ruffle manufacturers' feathers, such as identifying the least reliable appliance brands. By being upfront about potential issues, they built trust with customers who appreciated the honesty.

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5.Question

What advice can be drawn from Yale Appliance's success that other businesses can apply?

Answer:Other businesses can learn to prioritize transparency and honesty, engage with customer inquiries comprehensively, and produce meaningful content that addresses consumer questions to enhance their marketing approach and build trust in their respective industries.

6.Question

How did Sheinkopf's approach differ from traditional advertising methods during economic downturns?

Answer:Sheinkopf's approach involved focusing on content marketing rather than traditional outbound advertisements, which he had seen lesser returns from, particularly during the recession. Instead, he believed in providing educational content to attract and help consumers directly.

7.Question

What was the significance of the conference that influenced Sheinkopf's marketing strategy?

Answer:The conference, 'In Planet' in 2004, was pivotal as it

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introduced Sheinkopf to the concepts of content marketing and managing online reputation, which guided the transformation of Yale Appliance's marketing strategy.

8.Question

Why did Steve Sheinkopf advocate for everyone in the organization to participate in content creation?

Answer:By having everyone contribute to content creation, Sheinkopf aimed to democratize knowledge within the company and ensure that various perspectives and expertise were represented, leading to richer content and empowering employees.

9.Question

What lesson did Sheinkopf learn about consumer behavior during the recession?

Answer:During the recession, Sheinkopf learned that consumer behavior shifted towards thorough online research, making it critical for his business to provide clear, accessible information about appliances to meet their inquiries effectively.

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10.Question

How did Yale Appliance's articles rank in search engines, and what was the effect on their business?

Answer: Yale Appliance's articles began outranking major competitors in search engine results, leading to significant increases in web traffic and qualified leads, which translated into substantial increases in sales.

Chapter 23 | The Competition| Q&A

1.Question

What is 'The Triangle of Influence' and why is it important for businesses?

Answer: The Triangle of Influence is a concept introduced in this chapter that identifies three groups impacting a company's willingness to address customer inquiries: The Competition, The Bad Fits, and The Customer. It emphasizes that the competition has the most influence over what businesses talk about, leading many to avoid discussing key topics that consumers want to

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understand. Recognizing and addressing this triangle is crucial for businesses aiming to be transparent and customer-centric.

2.Question

What role does competition play in businesses addressing consumers' questions?

Answer:Competition often dictates what businesses are willing to discuss openly. Many companies hesitate to address topics like pricing, problems, and comparisons due to fears that competitors will exploit this information against them. This mentality can prevent organizations from engaging effectively with prospective customers who seek transparency and comprehensive answers.

3.Question

Why do organizations often fail to embrace a consumer-centric approach despite the clear benefits?

Answer:Organizations typically fail to adopt a consumer-centric approach due to fears rooted in a scarcity mentality and a perception that being transparent might

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disadvantage them in the competitive landscape. Many business owners think like sellers instead of educators, which contradicts the needs of modern consumers who seek honest and informative content.

4.Question

Can businesses outperform competitors by being transparent and answering questions honestly?

Answer: Yes, as several examples in the chapter illustrate, companies that prioritize honesty and transparency tend to gain consumer trust, improve their brand reputation, and ultimately, experience considerable increases in traffic and sales. The chapter showcases that open discussions about topics such as pricing and product issues can significantly enhance customer engagement and conversion rates.

5.Question

What is the significance of discussing problems and being open about weaknesses?

Answer: Discussing problems openly allows a business to build trust with customers. By acknowledging potential

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issues or concerns, companies can differentiate themselves as honest and reliable. This approach leads to informed consumers who appreciate transparency, which ultimately drives sales and customer loyalty.

6.Question

What are the implications of not addressing the 'Bad Fits' in your customer base?

Answer:Failing to recognize and address bad fits can lead to wasted resources and decreased employee morale, as dealing with unsuitable customers can create negative experiences.

Understanding who is not a good fit enables businesses to focus on ideal customers, improving overall satisfaction and operational efficiency.

7.Question

How can businesses ensure they are genuinely addressing customer needs and concerns?

Answer:Businesses should adopt a collaborative approach by involving all team members in brainstorming sessions to identify customer questions and concerns. This includes

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acknowledging fears, potential problems, and even competitor comparisons. By prioritizing genuine consumer education and creating content that addresses these needs, companies can establish themselves as trusted sources.

8.Question

Why is it more beneficial for businesses to generate content based on customer inquiries?

Answer:Creating content that directly addresses customer inquiries not only answers their questions but also positions the business as an industry expert. This approach attracts more qualified leads and builds consumer trust, ultimately leading to improved conversion rates and repeated business.

9.Question

What should companies do to change the way they communicate with their customers?

Answer:Companies must shift from a self-centric communication style to a consumer-centric approach that genuinely focuses on the questions and due diligence of prospects. This means addressing common concerns openly,

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providing clear value propositions, and engaging with consumers as educators.

10.Question

What role does transparency play in the success of a business according to this chapter?

Answer: Transparency is portrayed as fundamental to building trust with customers and differentiating oneself in a competitive market. Businesses that openly share information about their products, including pricing and potential drawbacks, often see a significant boost in customer engagement, loyalty, and overall sales.

11.Question

How can a business effectively address its competition in its content?

Answer: A business can effectively address its competition by providing comparative analyses that highlight the strengths and weaknesses of itself and its competitors. By doing so transparently, it demonstrates confidence in its offerings while educating consumers, allowing them to make informed

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decisions.

Chapter 24 | How They Ask, You Answer Saved River Pools and Spas| Q&A

1.Question

What was the business situation of River Pools and Spas in March 2009?

Answer:In March 2009, River Pools and Spas was facing the risk of losing their business. They were struggling financially after the recession and needed a solution to survive.

2.Question

How did the concept of 'They Ask, You Answer' impact the company's traffic and leads?

Answer:After implementing 'They Ask, You Answer,' River Pools and Spas started generating content that addressed every question from customers. This led to a rapid increase in organic traffic and leads, doubling their site traffic within three months, and eventually reaching over 600,000 visitors per month.

3.Question

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What financial transformation occurred from 2007 to 2014 at River Pools and Spas?

Answer: In 2007, the company did about \$4 million in business with \$250,000 spent on advertising. By 2014, even after a recession when most competitors struggled, they achieved \$5.5 million in business with only \$20,000 in advertising.

4.Question

What lesson did Marcus Sheridan learn about simplifying communication in marketing?

Answer: Marcus learned that trying to sound smart can often lead to confusion and ineffectiveness in communication. Instead, by simplifying information and focusing on clear understanding, he was able to connect with his audience and establish authority.

5.Question

Why did River Pools and Spas become a leader in the pool industry despite being a small company?

Answer: By continuously providing valuable,

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easy-to-understand content, River Pools and Spas positioned itself as a trusted source of information about swimming pools, leading to a significant increase in traffic, inquiries, and ultimately sales.

6.Question

What insight does Marcus find valuable in answering customer questions?

Answer:Marcus emphasizes that businesses should think like teachers, focusing on understanding and effectively communicating answers to customer questions. This creates a deeper connection and builds trust.

7.Question

What was the overall sentiment Marcus Sheridan expressed about the challenges faced in 2008?

Answer:He expressed gratitude for the challenges faced during the 2008 crash, as they forced him and the company to innovate and connect better with customers, resulting in long-term success.

8.Question

How can the principles of 'They Ask, You Answer'

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influence ROI in marketing?

Answer: The principles can significantly increase ROI by reducing advertising spend while boosting customer trust and sales through valuable content that addresses the audience's needs.

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Chapter 25 | How Great Content Is a Total Game-Changer for Sales Teams| Q&A

1.Question

What are some benefits of sales teams embracing content marketing and the principles of 'They Ask, You Answer'?

Answer:1. ****Producing content forces teams to**

understand buyers and their thought processes:**

Salespeople gain insight into customers' pain points and needs, enhancing empathy and communication skills.

2. ****Content production is practice for sales messaging**:** Sales teams refine their ability to answer questions and address concerns through content creation.

3. ****Content acts as a guide for training and messaging**:** Written materials create a uniform training resource for new sales employees, streamlining onboarding and knowledge sharing.

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4. ****Assignment Selling****: Marketing and sales alignment integrates better customer education in the sales process, ensuring prospects receive informed guidance.

5. ****Sales teams gain insights from prospect behavior****: By analyzing site interactions, salespeople can better understand buyer interests before contact, leading to informed conversations.

6. ****Building trust before the first meeting****: Great content fosters a relationship of trust with prospects, making sales calls more effective and focused.

7. ****Trust leads to shorter sales cycles****: More trust translates to quicker decision-making from leads, enabling sales teams to close deals faster.

Chapter 26 | A Dramatic Discovery| Q&A

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1.Question

How many pages do customers typically read before deciding to do business with a company?

Answer:On average, customers read about two to three pages.

2.Question

What does it imply when customers only consider five minutes of information as sufficient for deciding business?

Answer:It implies a gross underestimation of how much information customers are willing to consider before making a informed decision.

3.Question

What dramatic discovery did the author make in his pool company related to customer engagement?

Answer:The author discovered that customers who read thirty or more pages on the website had an 80% closing rate, whereas those who read less had only a 20% closing rate.

4.Question

What key question arises from the author's comparison

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between two groups of customers?

Answer: The key question is: "What is happening over the course of a prospect reading thirty pages that leads to such a significant increase in their likelihood to purchase?"

5.Question

How does consuming content relate to building trust with potential customers?

Answer: Every time a prospect consumes content, such as articles or videos, the trust factor increases as they are essentially self-qualifying themselves through that process.

6.Question

What analogy does the author use to describe the relationship between content consumption and customer engagement?

Answer: The author uses the analogy of going on dates; just like dating helps you discover compatibility, consuming content allows prospects to determine if they want to continue with a business relationship.

7.Question

What would happen if you could ensure a prospect

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consumes thirty pieces of your content?

Answer: If you could achieve this, the likelihood of them buying from you would increase to 80%, significantly boosting your sales numbers.

8.Question

How should businesses adjust their strategies based on the findings related to content consumption?

Answer: Businesses should focus on creating and promoting a greater volume of content, ensuring that potential customers can easily access and engage with at least thirty pieces of information before a sales interaction.

Chapter 27 | Assignment Selling| Q&A

1.Question

What is Assignment Selling?

Answer: Assignment Selling is the process of intentionally using information you have created (through text, video, or audio) that is educational about your products and/or services to help resolve the major concerns and questions of the prospect, so

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they are better prepared for a sales appointment.

2.Question

How should businesses approach content marketing according to Marcus Sheridan?

Answer:Businesses should not just post content and expect success; they must actively educate and engage prospects and customers with high-quality content to meaningful advance their sales.

3.Question

What is the main benefit of using content in the sales process?

Answer:The main benefit is that it helps prospects become more educated and makes them more likely to move down the sales funnel successfully, leading to increased sales.

4.Question

Why is it important to involve the sales team in content marketing?

Answer:Involving the sales team in content marketing ensures that the messaging aligns with what prospects are truly asking and helps foster relationships built on trust and

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transparency.

5.Question

What is the 'Triangle of Influence' in business communication?

Answer:The 'Triangle of Influence' refers to the three groups influencing a company's willingness to address customer questions: 1) the competition, 2) bad fits, and 3) the customer, with the competition being the most influential.

6.Question

What role does education play for prospects in the sales process?

Answer:Education is crucial as it helps prospects understand the value of products and services, ultimately leading to informed purchasing decisions and minimizing buyer's remorse.

7.Question

How can addressing problems and concerns in content help a business?

Answer:Addressing problems openly builds trust with customers, leading to a better experience and fewer

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misunderstandings, which can ultimately result in increased sales and customer satisfaction.

8.Question

What was the outcome of Marcus Sheridan's article about the cost of a fiberglass pool?

Answer:The article generated over \$3 million in sales revenue by being the first to openly discuss and educate prospects about the costs and factors influencing the price of fiberglass pools.

9.Question

How did Yale Appliance leverage the principles of They Ask, You Answer?

Answer:Yale Appliance created content that addressed consumer questions and concerns, allowing them to build trust and authority in their industry while significantly increasing website traffic and revenue.

10.Question

What should a company do to prevent being the 'ostrich' in their marketing approach?

Answer:A company should embrace transparency by

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addressing customer questions and concerns directly in their marketing efforts, thus fostering trust and mitigating potential issues.

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Chapter 28 | How One Remarkable Couple Changed My Perspective on the Power of Content to Sell| Q&A

1.Question

What does the story of Mr. and Mrs. G teach us about consumer behavior?

Answer:It illustrates that consumers are willing to thoroughly research and consume large amounts of information before making a buying decision. The fact that they read over 500 pages of content reflects their desire to feel informed and secure in their purchase.

2.Question

How can the number of pages a potential customer reads influence the sales process?

Answer:A potential customer's extensive research indicates that they are highly qualified leads. The more they engage with your content, the closer they are to making a purchasing decision, often requiring less direct selling from the salesperson.

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3.Question

What lesson did Marcus Sheridan learn from his appointment with Mr. G?

Answer:Sheridan learned that effective content can make the sales process much easier. By the time he met Mr. G, the couple was almost fully decided, emphasizing the importance of providing valuable, transparent information to aid consumer decisions.

4.Question

How can content become a powerful sales tool for businesses?

Answer:When content is honest and transparent, it builds trust and helps consumers feel comfortable with their decisions, turning the sales process into an effortless experience for both the customer and the salesperson.

5.Question

What is the importance of understanding consumer willingness to research?

Answer:Understanding that consumers often take the time to research thoroughly can help businesses create better

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marketing strategies that prioritize detailed, informative content, enhancing customer confidence and leading to increased sales.

6.Question

Why is it significant that Mr. G was a surgeon?

Answer:It highlights that regardless of career background, people seek substantial information to aid in their buying decisions. This shows that thorough research transcends professions and underscores the universal nature of informed consumer behavior.

7.Question

What was Sheridan's emotional response after the sale?

Answer:He felt a sense of amusement and realization regarding the minimal selling he had to do, reinforcing the idea that the customer's preparation through content was what primarily led to the sale.

8.Question

What overall message does this chapter convey about content marketing?

Answer:The chapter conveys that quality content is vital in

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today's market; it empowers consumers with the information they need, makes them more decisive, and ultimately drives sales without traditional hard selling.

Chapter 29 | Content Never Sleeps| Q&A

1.Question

What is the greatest sales tool in the world today according to the author?

Answer:Content is the greatest sales tool, particularly when it is honest and transparent.

Unlike salespeople, content has unlimited reach and operates continuously, teaching multiple people at once.

2.Question

How much time can good content save salespeople according to the chapter?

Answer:Good content can save salespeople significant amounts of time. In the author's experience, by improving their content strategy, they went from needing over 250 sales appointments to just 120 while increasing their closing rate,

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saving more than 800 person-hours a year.

3.Question

What key change did the author implement to improve their sales process?

Answer:The author implemented assignment selling and integrated content throughout the sales process, which allowed customers to engage with the content significantly before making a purchasing decision.

4.Question

What impact did improved content have on customer behavior?

Answer:Customers engaged with 105 pages on average before buying, showcasing a dramatic shift in consumer behavior that values thorough research before making decisions.

5.Question

How does the author suggest that content can impact employee morale and company culture?

Answer:By streamlining the sales process and saving time through effective content, companies can give their

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employees more time for personal life, leading to improved morale, culture, and greater overall satisfaction in the workplace.

6.Question

What is the moral of the story presented in this chapter?

Answer:The moral is that the power of content extends beyond just generating leads and sales; it's about enhancing quality of life for employees by giving them more time, which is ultimately irreplaceable.

7.Question

How did the author's perspective on sales change over the years?

Answer:Initially, the author had a traditional view focused on personal sales efforts, but after recognizing the power of content, they shifted to leveraging content for greater efficiency and effectiveness in sales.

8.Question

Why is content described as never sleeping?

Answer:Content is described as 'never sleeping' because it works continuously for the business, providing value and

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education to potential customers at any hour without requiring breaks, sick days, or vacations.

9.Question

What was one of the author's biggest realizations about consumer behavior over time?

Answer:The author realized that consumers are willing to invest significant time researching and reading content online, which flies in the face of previous assumptions about buyer behavior in the swimming pool industry.

Chapter 30 | Using Assignment Selling to Avoid Common Sales Pitfalls| Q&A

1.Question

What is assignment selling and how does it help in sales situations?

Answer:Assignment selling is a sales strategy that focuses on engaging prospects through educational content rather than traditional follow-up emails that express anxiety or uncertainty. By sending a follow-up that includes resources (like videos or articles) addressing the prospect's concerns, it

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encourages them to respond thoughtfully. This method not only reassures the prospect but also reinforces the salesperson's expertise, leading to more productive conversations.

2.Question

Why is the traditional follow-up email considered ineffective?

Answer:Traditional follow-up emails often sound desperate and lack substance. They typically ask if the prospect is still interested without providing additional value, leading to a lack of engagement. This approach can make salespeople appear needy and can push prospects further away instead of fostering a meaningful conversation.

3.Question

What are the benefits of using educational content in follow-up communication?

Answer:Using educational content in email follow-ups serves two key benefits: it reassures the prospect that they have made a wise choice in considering your solution by

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addressing their concerns and it presents your expertise in the area, helping to build trust. Additionally, it prompts a clear response from the prospect, either confirming their interest or clarifying disinterest, which saves time for both parties.

4.Question

How can a salesperson address concerns that may arise after a proposal is given?

Answer:A salesperson can address concerns by providing additional resources in their follow-up communication. This could include informative videos or articles that specifically address the concerns discussed during the sales meeting.

Doing so not only reinforces the initial conversation but also shows the prospect that their worries are taken seriously and addressed thoughtfully.

5.Question

What is the impact of a candid response from a prospect?

Answer:A candid response from a prospect, such as 'I'm not interested' or 'we've chosen a different direction,' is incredibly valuable as it saves time and allows salespeople to

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focus on more qualified leads. Time is a critical asset in sales; knowing where prospects stand helps with prioritization and strategy adjustment.

6.Question

Can assignment selling be applied to any business model?

Answer: Yes, assignment selling is versatile and can be adapted to any business model regardless of size or industry. Many successful companies have integrated this approach into their sales processes by tailoring educational content to fit their unique products, services, and customer needs, emphasizing the continuous principle of education-driven selling.

7.Question

How does the principle of using education in sales remain unchanged across different businesses?

Answer: While the specifics may differ based on the type of product, service, buyer, and sales cycle, the fundamental principle of using education to facilitate sales remains constant. Providing informative content helps build trust,

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clarifies value propositions, and enhances communication with prospects, making it a universally applicable strategy.

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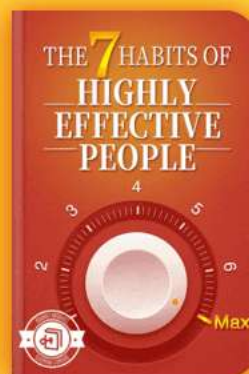
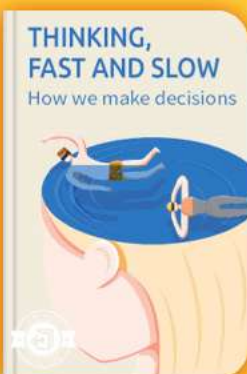


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Chapter 31 | Using Assignment Selling to Determine Compatibility| Q&A

1.Question

What is the primary goal of assignment selling in a business context?

Answer:The primary goal of assignment selling is to ensure that businesses work with well-informed and compatible clients. This is achieved by requiring prospects to educate themselves about the services offered before engaging in a conversation, thereby avoiding poor fits and streamlining the sales process.

2.Question

How does the e-book serve as a tool for determining compatibility between the Sales Lion and prospects?

Answer:The e-book acts as a filter for potential clients. By requiring prospects to read the e-book before a consultation, the Sales Lion can gauge the prospects' alignment with their philosophies. If a prospect resonates with the content, they're likely a good fit. Conversely, if they don't, it saves time for

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both parties by avoiding a consultation.

3.Question

What psychological principle underlies the approach of making the prospect feel in control of their decision-making?

Answer:The psychological principle at play is one of empowerment. By making the prospect feel that they are in charge of the decision to engage with the Sales Lion, it fosters a sense of autonomy and confidence, which is crucial in the selling process. This gives prospects the impression that they are making their own informed choices rather than being sold to.

4.Question

Why is it important for salespeople to communicate with teaching opportunities in their correspondence?

Answer:It is important for salespeople to communicate with teaching opportunities because education builds trust and credibility. By sharing valuable content in emails, salespeople can effectively engage prospects, guide their decision-making, and enhance the perceived value of their

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offering, creating a more productive sales environment.

5.Question

What does Marcus Sheridan suggest about the nature of sales conversations after implementing assignment selling?

Answer:After implementing assignment selling, Marcus Sheridan suggests that sales conversations tend to be much shorter and more productive. When prospects have engaged deeply with the content beforehand, they come prepared, leading to focused discussions that can quickly assess needs and solutions.

6.Question

How does the concept of disarmament play a role in the Sales Lion's communication with prospects?

Answer:The concept of disarmament involves acknowledging the possibility that the Sales Lion may not be a good fit for the prospect. By openly stating this in their communication, they put prospects at ease, allowing them to assess the fit themselves, which ultimately can lead to a more genuine and open conversation about needs.

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7.Question

What is implied about the relationship between sales and marketing teams in the context of assignment selling?

Answer: There is a strong implication that sales and marketing teams must work in unison without silos. Effective implementation of assignment selling requires both departments to be aligned, ensuring that the content produced is relevant and useful for prospects and is utilized effectively in the sales process.

Chapter 32 | Case Study 4 How a Start-Up Company in the Health Care Space Became the Thought Leaders of an Entirely New Industry| Q&A

1.Question

What fundamental change did Health Catalyst bring to the healthcare analytics industry?

Answer: Health Catalyst filled an informational void by implementing the 'They Ask, You Answer' methodology, which focused on educating the market rather than just promoting their products. This made them the thought leaders in a new

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industry where previously no one was answering key questions online.

2.Question

How did utilizing sales expertise influence content creation for Health Catalyst?

Answer:Health Catalyst combined insights from its senior sales team with marketing efforts to create content, which started as a collaborative process. This approach ensured that marketing materials addressed the most pressing questions customers had, leading to relevant and engaging content.

3.Question

What role did live webinars play in Health Catalyst's marketing strategy?

Answer:Health Catalyst organized free educational webinars which not only educated their clients and prospects but also established their authority in the field. They applied a content marketing mindset, focusing on teaching rather than promotion, which significantly increased attendance and engagement.

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4.Question

How did Health Catalyst ensure its events remained educational rather than promotional?

Answer:Health Catalyst adhered to strict guidelines for hosting industry events, focusing solely on providing education without making it solely a platform for promoting Health Catalyst. They monitored participant feedback to confirm adherence to their educational promise.

5.Question

What results did Health Catalyst achieve from their marketing efforts?

Answer:They transformed from a startup into a recognized thought leader in healthcare analytics, increased their website traffic dramatically, and built a substantial lead pipeline, with the expectation to host large industry events due to the growing demand for their educational content.

6.Question

How does transparency in business practices impact trust according to Health Catalyst's experience?

Answer:Health Catalyst's commitment to transparency in

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their motives and actions has made them trusted leaders in their industry. Their willingness to discuss the full landscape of healthcare analytics allowed them to build strong relationships with both clients and partners.

7.Question

What defines the essential philosophy behind 'They Ask, You Answer'?

Answer:The core principle is to obsessively focus on understanding and answering customers' questions and concerns to build trust and credibility, ultimately positioning the business as a helpful authority rather than just a vendor.

8.Question

What was the impact of addressing pricing and costs on Health Catalyst's sales process?

Answer:Discussing pricing openly on their website helped potential customers make informed decisions, leading to higher-quality leads. This transparency enhanced trust and made the sales process more efficient.

9.Question

How did Health Catalyst's marketing strategies

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contribute to their overall sales effectiveness?

Answer:By integrating marketing and sales through content-focused education, Health Catalyst ensured that prospects arrived to meetings already informed, which streamlined the sales process and increased closing rates.

10.Question

What can other companies learn from Health Catalyst's approach to marketing and sales?

Answer:Companies can benefit from prioritizing education and transparency in their marketing strategies to build trust, attract informed prospects, and ultimately drive sales effectiveness. Aligning sales and marketing around consumer education is essential.

Chapter 33 | The Power of Insourcing and Using Your Team to Create Incredible Content| Q&A

1.Question

Why is it important to produce your own content rather than outsourcing it?

Answer:Producing your own content allows for flexibility in creative output without restrictions

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from contracts. It ensures that your content accurately reflects your brand's story and expertise, as it comes directly from your team who understands the company's soul.

2.Question

What are the drawbacks of outsourcing content production?

Answer:Outsourcing can lead to a disconnect between the content produced and the brand's true voice and story.

Agencies often have fixed deliverables that may limit creative freedom and prevent companies from responding dynamically to market needs.

3.Question

What does insourcing mean in the context of content production?

Answer:Insourcing refers to using your existing employees' knowledge and expertise to create educational content for marketing, leading to enhanced buyer-centric content, better-informed sales teams, and increased brand awareness.

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4.Question

How can involving your sales team in content production benefit your company?

Answer:Involving the sales team ensures the content aligns with sales messaging and addresses buyer needs directly, leading to higher credibility and a stronger connection with prospects and customers, making them feel understood and valued.

5.Question

What is the ultimate goal when a company produces its own content?

Answer:The goal is to establish the company as a thought leader in its industry, ensuring that prospects and customers have a consistent and true representation of the brand across all channels.

6.Question

What should be the focus when creating content within a company?

Answer:The focus should be on producing high-quality, relevant, and educational content that truly reflects the

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company's identity and speaks to the needs and concerns of the audience.

7.Question

How does the analogy of an artist relate to content creation in a business context?

Answer:Just like an artist must hold their own paintbrush to create a masterpiece, a company must take ownership of its content creation to effectively express its unique value and differentiate itself in the marketplace.

8.Question

What is a key advantage of having a flexible content creation strategy?

Answer:A flexible content creation strategy allows companies to produce various types of content based on real-time feedback and needs, thereby staying relevant and competitive in their industry.

9.Question

In what ways can companies produce content without limitation?

Answer:Companies can choose to create as many blog posts,

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videos, or any other content they deem necessary, responding quickly to industry changes and customer needs without being bound by a predefined schedule from an agency.

10.Question

What does Marcus Sheridan suggest about the relationship between content, sales, and brand perception?

Answer: Sheridan suggests that the relationship is crucial; well-crafted content should support sales efforts by communicating the brand's message effectively, ensuring customers see consistency across all interactions.

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Chapter 34 | How Block Imaging Embraced a Culture of Insourcing| Q&A

1.Question

What does the excuse 'I don't have the time' really signify in a business context?

Answer:When someone says they 'don't have time,' they are often indicating that they don't see the value in the task at hand. If they recognized the importance or potential benefits, time wouldn't be an obstacle. Understanding this lets us see what truly motivates our colleagues and can help in making a stronger case for initiatives.

2.Question

How should a business view the concept of 'That's not my job'?

Answer:This phrase reveals a lack of understanding of the modern responsibilities within organizations. In today's digital age, everyone is expected to engage across silos, and productivity relies on cooperation. Acknowledging shared ownership of tasks can drive unified success.

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3.Question

What are the potential consequences of not involving sales in the content production process?

Answer:When sales teams are excluded, they miss out on crucial insights into customer questions and objections, leading to ineffective marketing content that doesn't resonate with potential buyers. This siloed approach can hinder sales conversions and overall company performance.

4.Question

What was the impact of Krista's workshop on Block Imaging?

Answer:After the workshop, there was a significant cultural shift—over fifty employees began creating content that directly addressed customer questions. The collective effort resulted in hundreds of articles and videos being produced, which dramatically increased their sales from 5% to 40% attributed to web leads.

5.Question

What does it mean when the author states 'Everyone is a teacher, and everyone's voice matters'?

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Answer: This mantra reflects a transformative approach to workplace culture where each individual is valued for their knowledge and expertise. It encourages participation across all levels, fostering a collaborative environment that enhances content richness and customer understanding.

6.Question

How did the marketing efforts at Block Imaging correlate with their financial success post-implementation of content marketing?

Answer: Krista stated that due to insourcing and a focus on content marketing, they could account for at least \$20 million in sales they otherwise would never have achieved. This illustrates a direct link between educational content and generating revenue through increased trust and visibility in the market.

Chapter 35 | Starting Off They Ask, You Answer with a Bang Company Workshops| Q&A

1.Question

How can an organization effectively embrace a culture of content marketing?

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Answer: Organizations should conduct workshops that help to unify the team around the principles of 'They Ask, You Answer.' This involves engaging employees from all departments in the content production process and ensuring they understand the importance of addressing customer questions. Just sending an email to employees to start a blog is insufficient; it requires a cultural shift supported by ongoing training and collaboration.

2.Question

What is the significance of consumer expectations in the digital age?

Answer: Consumer expectations have changed dramatically, and it is essential for businesses to recognize that buyers are increasingly seeking information online before making purchasing decisions. Companies must adapt by providing valuable content that answers consumers' questions, rather than focusing solely on promoting their own products.

3.Question

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Why is understanding how search engines work crucial for businesses?

Answer: Businesses must understand that the primary goal of search engines like Google is to deliver the most relevant and accurate answers to consumer queries. Failing to align their content with consumer searches could result in lower visibility and trust, making it vital to embrace a 'teacher' mentality in their online presence.

4.Question

How do consumers typically search for products and information?

Answer: Consumers often use specific queries related to Pricing and Costs, Problems and Comparisons, Reviews, and Best in Class when researching products. Understanding these 'Big 5' topics helps businesses create relevant content that meets consumers' needs.

5.Question

What role does group brainstorming play in content creation?

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Answer: Group brainstorming sessions help identify the common questions and concerns of prospects and customers, allowing the team to generate relevant content ideas that will resonate with their audience. This activity fosters collaboration and ensures a broad perspective in addressing customer queries.

6.Question

What impact can effective content marketing have on sales processes?

Answer: Good content can significantly shorten the sales cycle by providing prospects with the information they need to make informed decisions. This can lead to an increase in qualified leads, better conversion rates, and ultimately, greater profitability for the sales team.

7.Question

How can every employee contribute to a content marketing strategy?

Answer: Every employee, particularly those in customer-facing roles, can share their expertise and

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experiences to create valuable content. This includes writing blog posts, creating videos, and sharing insights based on their interactions with customers, which enriches the company's content assets and enhances its educational outreach.

8.Question

Why is addressing potential customer problems important for building trust?

Answer:Addressing potential problems or objections upfront enables companies to show transparency and honesty. This practice builds trust among consumers by demonstrating that the company is aware of its weaknesses and is willing to confront them rather than hiding from difficult questions.

9.Question

What is 'assignment selling' and how does it enhance the sales process?

Answer:Assignment selling involves providing customers with educational materials before a sales meeting, which prepares them better for the conversation. This approach

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ensures that prospects are informed about products/services and can lead to a more productive and efficient sales process.

10.Question

How has Yale Appliance's approach to content marketing contributed to its success?

Answer:Yale Appliance's focus on educational content, transparency, and customer engagement has established it as a thought leader in the appliance industry. By providing honest reviews and comparisons, they build trust and have successfully turned their website into a significant source of leads and sales.

11.Question

What are some essential principles to implement in workshops for 'They Ask, You Answer'?

Answer:Key principles include understanding changing consumer expectations, recognizing how search engines work, addressing the Big 5 content topics, encouraging group brainstorming, emphasizing the role of every employee in content creation, and addressing customer concerns openly to

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build trust.

12.Question

What should organizations do to avoid the pitfalls of ostrich marketing?

Answer:Organizations should proactively address the questions and concerns of their customers rather than ignoring them. Acknowledging and discussing relevant topics allows companies to build trust and prevent the negative consequences of avoiding crucial issues.

Chapter 36 | The Content Manager Qualities, Hiring, and More| Q&A

1.Question

What is the most crucial factor for successful content marketing implementation in a business?

Answer:Someone must own it. Without a dedicated content manager or team, content marketing efforts are likely to fail.

2.Question

Why is it important to have a content manager?

Answer:A content manager dedicates all their time to the

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content marketing strategy, ensuring consistent production and focus on quality, which can significantly impact business success.

3.Question

What are the key responsibilities of a content manager on a weekly basis?

Answer: Typical duties include creating new content, email marketing, analyzing site data, engaging on social media, producing premium content, enhancing the website, and training for continual improvement.

4.Question

What essential qualities should a content marketing manager possess?

Answer: They should love writing, be skilled at editing, have excellent interviewing skills, embrace social media, possess video editing skills, be likable, understand human behavior, be organized, love analytics, and think creatively.

5.Question

How does hiring journalists align with content marketing needs?

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Answer: Journalists typically possess strong writing skills and the ability to communicate complex topics clearly, which aligns well with the need for engaging and informative content in marketing.

6.Question

What is assignment selling and how does it work?

Answer: Assignment selling is a strategy where salespeople provide educational content to prospects before a meeting. This helps prospects become more informed and prepared, thus increasing the likelihood of closing the sale.

7.Question

What impact does content marketing have on the sales process?

Answer: Content marketing can lead to shorter sales cycles, higher closing rates, and more qualified leads, ultimately boosting sales team productivity and reducing time spent with bad-fit prospects.

8.Question

What is the 'Triangle of Influence' in content marketing?

Answer: It consists of competition, bad fits, and the customer.

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Competition strongly influences what a company can openly discuss, while bad fits may deter addressing concerns that should be communicated to the actual customer.

9.Question

How can businesses effectively measure the ROI of their content marketing efforts?

Answer:Using analytics tools to track visitors, leads, and sales generated from content, companies can determine which pieces of content drive the most business outcomes and improve future strategies.

10.Question

What is the significance of empathy in content marketing and sales?

Answer:Empathy allows salespeople to connect with prospects, understand their needs, and tailor content that genuinely resonates with them, resulting in more successful engagements and transactions.

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Chapter 37 | On the Importance of Tools Measuring Return on Investment, the Power of HubSpot, and More| Q&A

1.Question

What are the fundamental principles behind the They Ask You Answer philosophy?

Answer:They Ask You Answer is centered on three core principles: obsessive listening to the customer, teaching with transparency, and a commitment to solving marketplace problems. These principles ensure that sales and marketing are aligned with the actual needs and concerns of consumers.

2.Question

Why is measuring ROI important in a content marketing strategy?

Answer:Measuring ROI is crucial because it allows businesses to assess if their investments in content marketing lead to financial returns. Without knowing how much revenue is generated from marketing efforts, companies cannot make informed decisions about where to allocate

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resources.

3.Question

How did HubSpot contribute to Marcus Sheridan's journey in turning around River Pools and Spas?

Answer:HubSpot provided Marcus Sheridan with the tools and knowledge he needed for digital marketing, specifically in inbound marketing, which focused on attracting customers through valuable content rather than traditional interruptive advertising methods.

4.Question

What is the significance of tracking lead behavior in sales?

Answer:Tracking lead behavior allows sales teams to understand the interests and needs of potential customers before contact. This information helps sales representatives tailor their approach, improving the chances of closing sales.

5.Question

How can companies effectively use advanced analytics tools like HubSpot?

Answer:HubSpot allows businesses to measure ROI, track

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lead behavior, monitor SEO performance, and conduct website tests to optimize conversion rates. By understanding user interactions and responses to content, companies can refine their marketing strategies.

6.Question

What role does content play in building customer trust?

Answer:Content serves as a platform for educating customers about products and services, addressing their questions and concerns, which inherently builds trust. Transparent and honest content signals to potential buyers that the company is credible and aligned with their needs.

7.Question

Why is it important for sales teams to engage in content production?

Answer:When sales teams contribute to content creation, they bring real-world insights into customer concerns, ensuring the content is relevant and effective. This collaboration also fosters a culture of shared knowledge, enhancing the overall sales process.

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8.Question

What impact does addressing customer concerns have on business outcomes?

Answer:Addressing customer concerns directly through content can prevent mistrust and buyer hesitation. By providing answers upfront, businesses can streamline the decision-making process for consumers, leading to higher closing rates and increased sales.

9.Question

What lessons can be drawn from the story of CarMax as it relates to They Ask You Answer?

Answer:CarMax's success is attributed to their openness in addressing common consumer fears, such as high-pressure sales tactics and buyer's remorse. Their model of transparent pricing and education about the buying process has redefined trust in the used car industry, demonstrating how effective transparency can attract and retain customers.

10.Question

How does the concept of assignment selling move prospective customers through the sales funnel?

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Answer: Assignment selling involves providing educational content to prospects before a sales appointment. This process prepares the customer, reduces anxiety, and significantly increases the likelihood of a successful sale by ensuring they are informed and understand the value of the offering.

Chapter 38 | How Do I Find More Time to Make This Work within My Organization?| Q&A

1.Question

How do I find more time to make content marketing work within my organization?

Answer: Finding time for content marketing can seem daunting, but there are effective strategies to make it manageable. For instance, consider the emails you send daily that answer customer questions—these can be transformed into blog posts with minimal effort.

Additionally, you could bcc a member from the marketing team when communicating with clients, ensuring that insightful responses are captured and utilized for future content. Another method is to

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foster a culture of content creation through blogathons, where employees can dedicate a specific period to producing multiple pieces of content together. Finally, hiring a dedicated content manager can streamline efforts and maintain focus on producing quality content.

2.Question

What can I do to increase content production and effectiveness quickly?

Answer:Start talking out loud to yourself while driving or working on tasks. Use tools to record your thoughts as if you were explaining things to a customer. This method helps generate content quickly. Participate in organized content creation days, or ‘blogathons,’ to pool resources and efforts with your team. This not only produces content but also enhances team morale and collaboration. Engaging in interviews with knowledgeable team members can also yield valuable insights and content.

3.Question

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What role does insourcing play in content marketing?

Answer: Insourcing refers to utilizing your existing employees—who are subject matter experts—to produce content that is relevant and authentic to your brand. This method brings a wealth of knowledge and insight to your articles, videos, and other content, allowing for a more personal touch that resonates with your audience.

4.Question

How can I ensure that every employee contributes to content production?

Answer: Making content generation part of everyone's role can be effective. Implement a structure where employees across departments contribute to your content marketing efforts. For instance, set up a system where each employee is responsible for producing a set number of articles or content pieces per quarter. Training across teams can facilitate this by aligning everyone on key messaging and objectives.

5.Question

Is content marketing worth the investment?

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Answer: Absolutely, content marketing can yield significant returns on investment (ROI). By tracking metrics such as website traffic, lead generation, and sales that result from your content efforts, you can quantify the impact. Many businesses have reported substantial revenue growth directly linked to their content marketing strategies, proving it's a crucial investment.

6.Question

How can I maintain employee engagement in content production?

Answer: Keeping the team motivated can be achieved by recognizing their contributions, offering incentives for high-quality content, and creating a supportive environment for them to share ideas and feedback. Regularly update them on how their content impacts the company's success and foster a culture where creativity is celebrated.

7.Question

How do I turn content marketing into company culture?

Answer: To embed content marketing into your company

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culture, institute regular workshops that focus on They Ask, You Answer principles. Ensure that every team, from sales to customer service, understands their role in the content production process. Regular cross-departmental meetings can also help break down silos and encourage a collaborative approach.

Chapter 39 | Just How Important Is Video to Inbound and Content Marketing? How Does It Relate to They Ask, You Answer?| Q&A

1.Question

Why is video more important than textual content in marketing?

Answer: Video content significantly boosts engagement, as indicated by statistics: including video in an email can increase click-through rates by 200-300%, while having video on a landing page can boost conversions by 80%. Additionally, studies show that 65% of executives visit a marketer's website after viewing a video, and 64% of users are more likely to buy after watching a video. Thus,

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integrating video not only draws attention but also enhances the chances of conversion.

2.Question

How does the principle 'They Ask, You Answer' apply to video content?

Answer:The principle operates on the understanding that consumers have questions and concerns they want addressed. Video serves as a dynamic medium to provide answers, showcasing product features, processes, and addressing consumer hesitations. By using video to visualize answers, companies can better fulfill consumer needs and build trust, as consumers prefer seeing information visually over reading textual content.

3.Question

What is the significance of treating everyone as a media company?

Answer:In today's digital landscape, every business must position itself as a media company because consumers increasingly expect brands to provide valuable, engaging

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content. This means producing videos and other visual content to meet consumer questions, helping to educate and inform. If companies fail to embrace this, they risk becoming irrelevant as consumers seek more engaging experiences from competitors.

4.Question

What happens if consumers cannot see a product before purchasing?

Answer:If consumers cannot see a product—be it through video or high-quality visuals—they perceive it doesn't exist. This perception significantly affects their buying decision, as visibility builds trust and helps consumers feel more comfortable about their purchase choices. Without this visual representation, potential customers may opt to go elsewhere.

5.Question

How do businesses benefit from embracing video marketing?

Answer:Businesses that integrate video marketing experience increased traffic, higher engagement rates, and improved

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conversion rates. Videos serve to educate consumers, address their concerns, and illustrate product details effectively. Additionally, video enhances SEO, making it easier for businesses to rank higher in search engine results, driving more organic traffic and sales.

6.Question

What is the impact of transparency and honesty in video marketing?

Answer:Transparency in video marketing builds strong consumer trust. When brands openly discuss their products, address potential problems, and provide clear, honest comparisons, consumers recognize they are being valued and informed. This approach can lead to higher conversion rates, as buyers feel more confident making informed decisions.

7.Question

Why should businesses develop a culture of using video content?

Answer:By cultivating a video-centric culture, businesses can ensure their marketing efforts resonate with consumer

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expectations and behaviors. This culture leads to continuous improvement in content quality and relevance. Moreover, involving employees in video content creation helps harness diverse insights and fosters a sense of ownership in the brand's messaging.

8.Question

How can companies measure the return on investment (ROI) of their video content?

Answer:Companies can measure ROI from video content by tracking engagement metrics such as click-through rates, view durations, leads generated, and conversions attributed to video views. Tools such as HubSpot provide insights into customer interactions, demonstrating how specific video content drives sales and strengthens brand presence.

9.Question

What future trends in video marketing should companies prepare for?

Answer:Companies should prepare for the rise of advanced technologies like virtual reality, which is expected to reshape

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consumer expectations for interactive viewing experiences.

As technology evolves, consumers will demand richer, more immersive content, making it essential for brands to stay ahead in video marketing strategies to maintain consumer engagement.

10.Question

How can companies create effective video content?

Answer: To create effective video content, companies should focus on high-quality visuals that address consumer questions directly. They should also ensure that the content is educational and provides clear, actionable insights.

Collaborating with subject matter experts for authenticity and utilizing simple language enhances the content's accessibility, making it more impactful for the audience.

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Chapter 40 | How Long Will It Take They Ask, You Answer to Work?| Q&A

1.Question

How long will it take for They Ask, You Answer to work?

Answer:The timeline varies by company and industry, but creating a culture of listening and acting upon insights takes dedication. On average, expect initial results within 3 to 6 months as you engage with your audience and refine your content based on their needs.

2.Question

What does success look like after implementing content marketing?

Answer:Success looks like increased online traffic, a growing number of leads, and ultimately, higher sales and revenue, driven by a consistent release of valuable educational content that resonates with your target audience.

3.Question

What key actions should companies take to embrace content marketing?

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Answer: Companies should focus on producing content regularly, involving all departments in the process, and truly addressing the common questions and concerns of their prospects.

4.Question

Can you detail the five stages of content marketing success?

Answer: 1. Hit 'Publish' and get the sales team engaged. 2. Searchers realize you exist and start visiting your site. 3. You begin to generate leads from web traffic. 4. Sales and revenue start to increase significantly. 5. The snowball effect escalates, leading to sustained growth and market influence.

5.Question

What common challenges do companies face when starting content marketing?

Answer: Common challenges include lack of buy-in from management, insufficient resources, and resistance to embracing a new culture focused on transparency and customer education. It often requires change management to

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overcome traditional mindsets.

6.Question

What is the most important mindset for successful content marketing?

Answer:The essential mindset is to see yourself as a teacher rather than just a seller. Embrace the idea that educating your audience builds trust and drives conversions.

7.Question

What strategies can teams use to ensure everyone participates in content production?

Answer:Teams can hold brainstorming sessions to list common customer questions and assign content creation roles based on individual strengths, employing methods like blogathons or videoathons to energize contributions.

8.Question

How can businesses measure their content marketing ROI?

Answer:By using tools like HubSpot, which track website traffic, leads generated from specific content, and sales attributed to those leads, allowing companies to directly link

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their marketing efforts to financial outcomes.

9.Question

Incorporating the principles of They Ask, You Answer, what transformation can businesses expect over time?

Answer:Businesses can expect a transformation into the industry leader in trust and education, significantly improved sales cycles, and a proactive market presence as they consistently address consumer needs and questions.

Chapter 41 | Is Content Marketing and They Ask, You Answer Just a Fad?| Q&A

1.Question

Is content marketing a passing fad?

Answer:No, content marketing is a foundational principle that has existed for a long time and will continue to be essential as consumer behavior changes.

2.Question

What defines content marketing?

Answer:Content marketing is about earning trust through teaching and using valuable information to solve consumer

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problems.

3.Question

Why have some businesses failed to adopt content marketing?

Answer:Many businesses lack an understanding of content marketing, leading to inaction and a widening gap between themselves and their competitors who embrace it.

4.Question

What is the core philosophy of They Ask, You Answer?

Answer:The core philosophy is to prioritize consumer questions and provide honest answers, thereby earning their trust.

5.Question

How can discussing problems improve business?

Answer:By openly addressing industry-related problems, businesses can build greater trust with consumers and differentiate themselves from competitors.

6.Question

What are the Big 5 content subjects that help consumers?

Answer:The Big 5 includes Pricing and Costs, Problems,

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Comparisons, Reviews, and Best in Class.

7.Question

Why is video content important for sales?

Answer:Video content enhances engagement and conversion rates, allowing businesses to illustrate their products and answer consumer questions effectively.

8.Question

How has content marketing changed River Pools and Spas?

Answer:Content marketing increased their website traffic significantly, leading to a higher conversion rate and millions in additional revenue.

9.Question

What impact does trust have in sales?

Answer:Trust can shorten sales cycles, increase closing rates, and improve overall customer experience.

10.Question

What is assignment selling?

Answer:Assignment selling involves using valuable content to educate prospects before sales appointments, ensuring they

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are informed and engaged.

11.Question

How does understanding customer questions help companies succeed?

Answer:By recognizing what customers are asking, companies can produce relevant content that resonates, leading to higher engagement and sales.

12.Question

Why is it important to measure ROI in content marketing?

Answer:Measuring ROI helps businesses understand the effectiveness of their strategies and make informed decisions about resource allocation.

13.Question

What essential qualities should a content marketing manager possess?

Answer:A good content marketing manager should love writing, be skilled at editing, understand consumer behavior, and have the ability to organize and strategize effectively.

14.Question

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How can companies keep their employees engaged in content production?

Answer:By encouraging participation and demonstrating how their contributions help the company's success, including in goal-setting and content creation.

15.Question

How can a culture of content marketing transform a company?

Answer:It encourages collaboration, breaks down silos, improves customer engagement, and ultimately increases sales and brand loyalty.

16.Question

What role does technology play in content marketing?

Answer:Technology enhances the ability to track performance, measure impact, and understand consumer behavior, allowing businesses to optimize their strategies.

17.Question

How can companies effectively use video in their content marketing?

Answer:Companies should produce videos that answer

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customer questions, showcase products transparently, and engage consumers on a personal level.

18.Question

What is the significance of creating a comprehensive content strategy?

Answer:A solid strategy ensures that all departments are on the same page, promoting unified messaging and enhancing the effectiveness of marketing efforts.

19.Question

What is the worst mistake companies make with their content marketing?

Answer:Ignoring the consumer's perspective and neglecting to address their questions, fears, and needs effectively.

20.Question

How should businesses approach their competition in their content?

Answer:Businesses should be honest about their competitors, provide unbiased comparisons, and focus on delivering value to the consumer.

21.Question

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What tactics can businesses use to create better content?

Answer:Engage employees from various departments, prioritize consumer concerns, conduct thorough research, and focus on quality over quantity.

22.Question

What do consumers ultimately value when it comes to content?

Answer:Consumers value transparency, honesty, and accessible information that helps them make informed purchasing decisions.

23.Question

How does content marketing align with changing consumer behavior?

Answer:Content marketing meets the demands of informed consumers who seek transparency, education, and answers to their queries before making purchases.

Chapter 42 | How Can I Keep My Team Engaged in the Content Production Process?| Q&A

1.Question

How can I keep my team engaged in the content

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production process?

Answer: • Focus on bottom-of-the-funnel buyer questions and get it in the hands of the sales team. This ensures that the content produced is valuable and immediately adds to the sales process.

- Shine a light on superheros within the team by giving awards and recognizing their contributions, which promotes a positive culture.
- Encourage sharing of cross-department successes in meetings. Publishing positive feedback motivates others to join in.
- Celebrate milestones such as reaching certain numbers of articles or leads generated from content. This instills a sense of achievement.
- Create joint goals for the team to strive towards, encouraging collaboration and friendly competition.
- Make content training a part of onboarding new team members, ensuring that everyone knows the importance of their role in content production.

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- Make it easy for employees to share content by simplifying the process and providing tools that facilitate sharing on social media and other platforms.
- Ask for help in specific ways, giving team members clear tasks that help them feel directly involved and valuable.
- Humanize the process by reminding everyone of the real-world impact of their content, making the work feel less mechanical and more meaningful.
- Stay curious and open to new ideas, which fosters an environment of creativity and innovation.

Regularly asking the team for feedback and ideas can generate enthusiasm.

2.Question

What are effective ways to generate initial content?

Answer:• Start by brainstorming every question you've been asked by prospects and customers to guide your content topics.

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- Repurpose existing communications such as emails into blog posts, providing rich content directly from the experiences of team members.
- Organize blogathons, where team members create content collaboratively within a set time.
- Tap into the expertise of other departments by encouraging them to contribute content that aligns with customer questions.

3.Question

How can I foster a culture of content marketing in my organization?

Answer:• Conduct workshops to educate all team members about the principles of content marketing and the 'They Ask, You Answer' philosophy. Involve everyone from management to sales.

- Develop a content calendar and ensure consistency in content production to build a library of valuable resources.
- Encourage participating teams to recognize and reward contributions to the content marketing efforts, validating the

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work done by team members.

- Regularly review the performance of your content to highlight successes and identify areas for improvement; this will motivate teams to produce high-quality content.

4.Question

What role does video play in content marketing according to They Ask, You Answer?

Answer:• Video significantly increases engagement and conversion rates; for instance, emails with videos have a 200-300% higher click-through rate.

- Video allows for educational content delivery, where complex concepts can be demonstrated visually, making understanding easier for viewers.
- Creating a consistent presence through video helps to establish trust and authority in the market, serving consumers' needs by providing them with visual insights about products and services.

5.Question

What is assignment selling and how can it enhance the content production process?

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Answer:• Assignment selling is the process of using educational content as a pre-sales tool, requiring prospects to engage with that content before a sales meeting.

- This process helps to prime prospects, ensuring they arrive at the conversation well-informed, which leads to improved closing rates.
- It allows sales teams to filter out bad-fit clients early by ensuring that those who engage with content understand what is expected of them and are genuinely interested in the offering.

6.Question

How do you measure the success of a content marketing strategy?

Answer:• Track organic traffic to ensure that your content generates visitors and leads.

- Use marketing automation tools to measure where leads are coming from, correlating them to specific content that has driven conversions.
- Analyze the average amount of content consumed by

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prospects before converting to establish a baseline for future content strategies and gauge engagement levels.

7.Question

How can I empower my team to participate in content marketing?

Answer:• Make participation in content creation part of job descriptions for all employees, emphasizing the value each voice brings to the brand.

- Provide them with the training, tools and insights needed to create or contribute to content in their areas of expertise.
- Recognize contributions publicly and encourage a culture where sharing knowledge becomes a source of team pride and engagement.

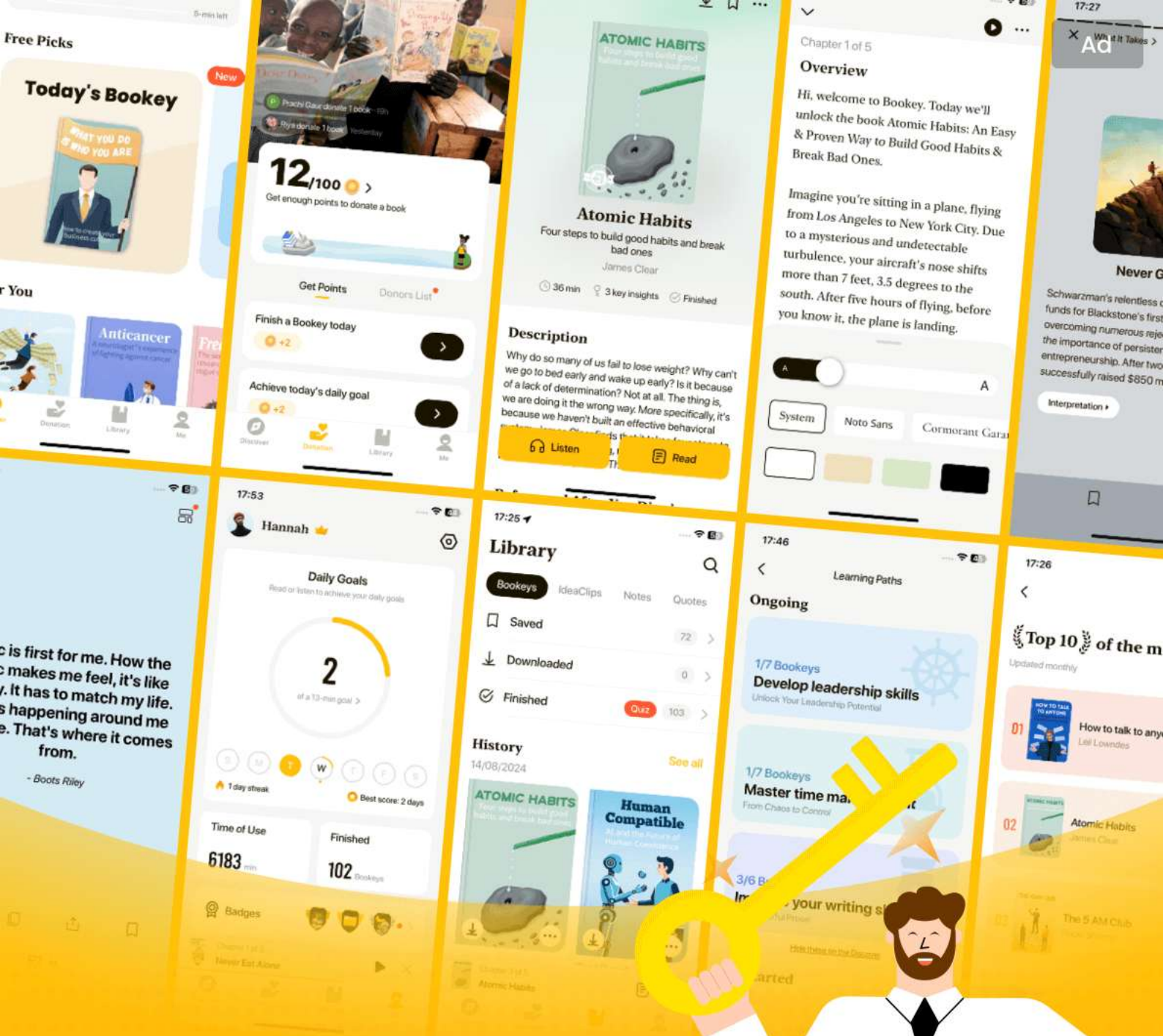
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Chapter 43 | “I’ve Been Told If We’re Not Adding Anything New to the Conversation, Then We Shouldn’t Be Talking about It”| Q&A

1.Question

Why is it important to contribute to conversations even if the topic has been covered before?

Answer:Contributing to conversations adds unique perspectives and personal experiences that others might resonate with. It's not just about the information shared, but how it is communicated. Every individual has a different story, voice, and context, which can inspire action and foster understanding among readers and listeners.

2.Question

How can sharing your thoughts and experiences improve your business?

Answer:When businesses share their insights and experiences, they build trust with their audience. This transparency encourages potential customers to engage, ultimately leading to increased business and financial

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security. Additionally, sharing content helps business owners articulate their ideas better, making them stronger communicators.

3.Question

What is the 'Gospel According to You' concept mentioned in the text?

Answer:The 'Gospel According to You' emphasizes the need for individuals and companies to express their beliefs, values, and insights in their own voice. This personal touch not only helps in establishing a connection with customers, but it also fosters internal growth and clarity within the company.

4.Question

What historical examples support the idea that repetition and varied expression are valuable?

Answer:The author references the Gospels of Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John, which, despite their similarities, provide distinct interpretations of the same events. Each author added their unique context and understanding, which enriches the overall narrative and comprehension of the

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central themes.

5.Question

What are the personal benefits of engaging in content creation?

Answer:Creating content hones one's communication skills and deepens understanding of the subject matter. It challenges individuals to think critically, research thoroughly, and articulate their thoughts clearly. This personal development translates to better interactions professionally and personally.

Chapter 44 | A Revolutionary Marketing Strategy| Q&A

1.Question

What is the overarching theme of Marcus Sheridan's experience with River Pools and Spas?

Answer:The overarching theme is the transformative power of listening to and addressing customer questions. It highlights how a simple approach can lead to profound changes in business success and personal fulfillment.

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2.Question

How did Marcus Sheridan's philosophy on marketing change after attending the conference in 2013?

Answer:After the conference, he recognized the importance of transparency, teaching, and customer engagement. He started focusing on answering questions as a core strategy, which ultimately became the foundation for the success of River Pools and Spas.

3.Question

What feedback did Marcus receive from other business owners after the New York Times article?

Answer:Many business owners expressed that the approach was surprisingly simple, and they felt encouraged to adopt similar strategies in their own businesses, as if they had been given permission to prioritize customer engagement.

4.Question

What lesson can be drawn from the statement 'simple is good'?

Answer:The lesson is that simplicity in marketing strategies, like answering customer questions, can be highly effective. It

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emphasizes that anyone can implement these strategies if they genuinely care about their customers.

5.Question

What is the significance of the phrase 'permission to do that which I've always felt we should be doing'?

Answer: This phrase reflects the internal struggles many business people face when they know they should prioritize customer care and engagement but often hesitate to do so. Sheridan encourages readers to embrace these instincts.

6.Question

How do teaching and transparency contribute to building customer trust?

Answer: Teaching provides customers with valuable knowledge, while transparency ensures honesty in communications. Together, they foster trust, as customers feel more informed and respected, which enhances their loyalty.

7.Question

What can businesses do to become the best teachers for their customers?

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Answer: Businesses should obsessively listen to customer questions, provide clear and honest answers, create educational content, and be responsive to customer needs, thus positioning themselves as trusted experts.

8.Question

In what way did Sheridan's personal life improve alongside his business success?

Answer: Sheridan found that as his business thrived, he also became more present for his family, highlighting that professional success can lead to personal fulfillment, emphasizing the importance of balance between work and home life.

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Parent-Child Communication

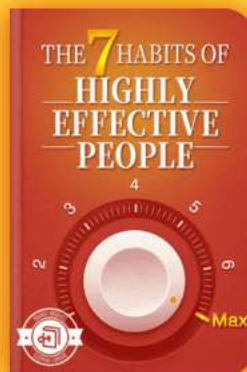
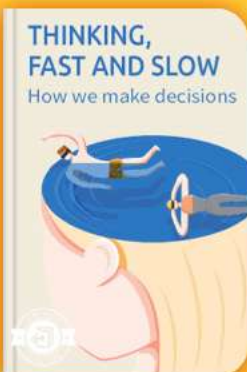


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They Ask You Answer Quiz and Test

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Chapter 1 | The Fall| Quiz and Test

- 1.The author experienced overwhelming anxiety and hopelessness when checking his company's bank balance, which was overdrawn.
- 2.After graduating in 2001, the author immediately found a job that perfectly suited his skills and aspirations.
- 3.The financial crisis in 2008 had a positive impact on the business of River Pools and Spas, leading to new opportunities.

Chapter 2 | A Massive Buying Shift and the Blur between Sales and Marketing| Quiz and Test

- 1.The traditional lines between sales and marketing have become clearer over the past decade.
- 2.Approximately 70% of the buying decision occurs before a customer engages with the company today.
- 3.Companies generally prioritize cutting back on sales when looking for growth during challenging times.

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Chapter 3 | This Book Won't Work for You If . . .| Quiz and Test

- 1.The book will be beneficial for any business, regardless of consumer behavior changes.
- 2.Having an open mindset is important to effectively applying the principles in the book.
- 3.Most businesses are fundamentally different from each other in terms of their needs.

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Chapter 4 | The Discovery of They Ask, You Answer| Quiz and Test

- 1.The author recognized the urgent need for change in his business during a financial crisis.
- 2.The author believed that traditional advertising methods like TV and newspapers were effective for lead generation.
- 3.The motto 'They Ask, You Answer' was inspired by the author's insight into answering consumer questions.

Chapter 5 | “They Ask, You Answer” Defined| Quiz and Test

- 1.They Ask, You Answer is solely a marketing strategy without implications for company culture.
- 2.Organizations that adopt They Ask, You Answer aim to become the go-to authority in their field.
- 3.The book is structured in five parts that include a detailed roadmap for implementation.

Chapter 6 | Brainstorming the Questions You Are Asked Every Day| Quiz and Test

- 1.The author brainstormed all questions received about fiberglass swimming pools over a span of

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nine years.

- 2.Many company websites successfully address and provide answers to the majority of customer inquiries regarding their products.
- 3.The author suggests that businesses should create content based on customer questions to better connect with their audience.

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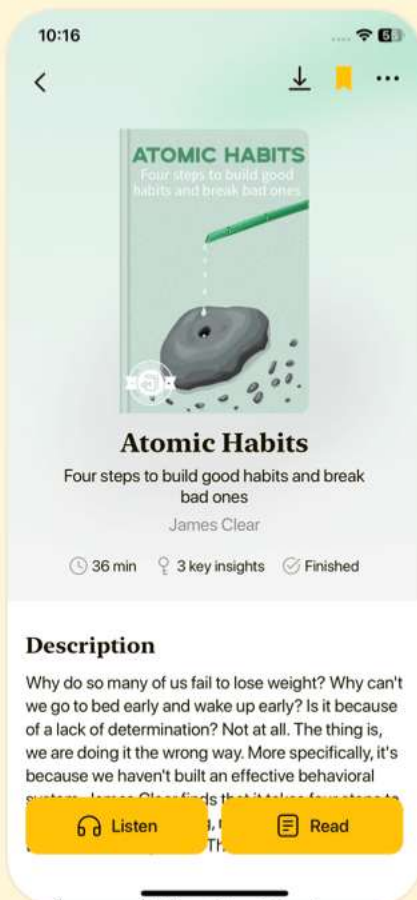


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Chapter 7 | The Ostrich Marketing Strategy| Quiz and Test

- 1.Ostrich marketing is a productive business strategy that encourages engagement with customers.
- 2.Ignoring difficult questions from customers can lead to missed opportunities for engagement.
- 3.Addressing customer questions openly and honestly can help businesses build trust with their customers.

Chapter 8 | The CarMax Effect| Quiz and Test

- 1.CarMax implemented a no-haggle pricing model to reduce anxiety for consumers.
- 2.CarMax salespeople are incentivized by a commission structure based on the number of cars they sell.
- 3.CarMax offers a five-day money-back guarantee, which is an industry-standard practice in the used car market.

Chapter 9 | The Discovery of the Big 5| Quiz and Test

- 1.The 'Big 5' content subjects identified in Chapter 9 are Pricing and Costs, Problems Versus

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Comparisons, Reviews, Best in Class, and Customer Testimonials.

2. After implementing the 'They Ask You Answer' strategy, River Pools and Spas saw an increase in web traffic and sales within a couple of months.
3. Businesses are generally quick to address the top five topics that consumers care about during their purchasing decisions.

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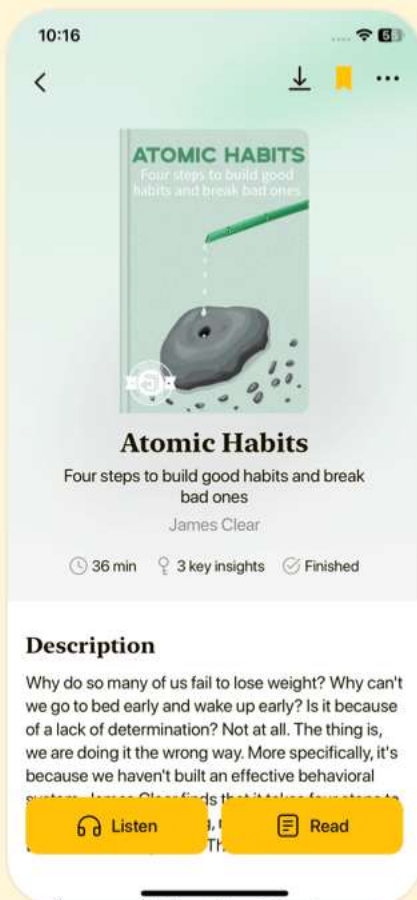


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Chapter 10 | Content Subject 1 Pricing and Costs: Why We Must Talk about Money| Quiz and Test

1. Consumers feel frustrated when they cannot find pricing information on a company's website.
2. Businesses should keep their pricing information secret to prevent competitors from knowing their strategies.
3. Transparency about pricing can lead to increased trust and customer loyalty.

Chapter 11 | How One Article about Money Generated More Than \$3,000,000 in Sales| Quiz and Test

1. Marcus Sheridan found that discussing pricing openly frustrated potential customers.
2. The article titled 'How Much Does a Fiberglass Pool Cost?' generated over \$3 million in sales for River Pools and Spas.
3. Marcus Sheridan believes that businesses should engage in 'ostrich marketing' to avoid losing sales.

Chapter 12 | Case Study 1 High-End B2B Technology Company Generates More Than

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\$8,000,000 in Additional Revenue| Quiz and Test

1. Segue Technologies initially served only the government sector before diversifying into commercial business.
2. The company's revenue increased by more than \$8,000,000 due to a focus on content quantity over quality.
3. All employees at Segue contributed to the content strategy by posting regularly on the company's blog.

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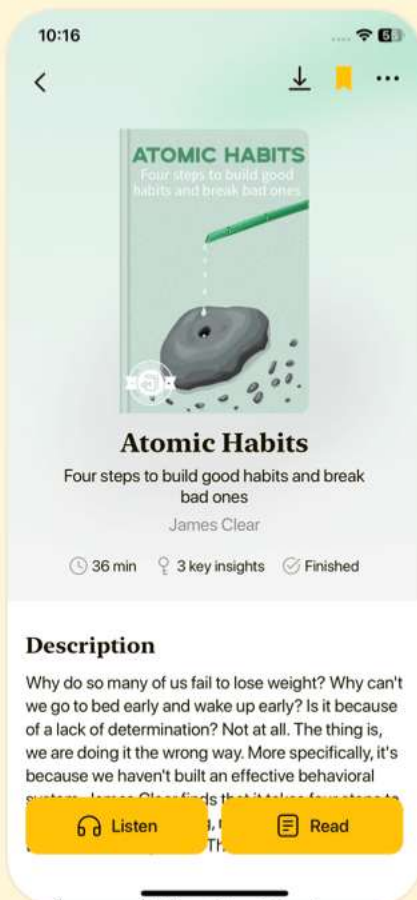


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Chapter 13 | Content Subject 2 Problems: How to Turn Weaknesses into Strengths| Quiz and Test

1. Consumers are more concerned about potential issues when making purchasing decisions than positive aspects of a product.
2. Buyers prefer to focus solely on positive reviews when choosing a product and ignore any negative feedback.
3. Addressing consumer concerns in marketing content is crucial as it can significantly influence their decision-making process.

Chapter 14 | Addressing the Elephant in the Room| Quiz and Test

1. The philosophy of 'They Ask You Answer' encourages businesses to avoid discussing negative aspects of their products.
2. Marcus Sheridan's article on fiberglass pools addressed potential drawbacks of the product.
3. Most competitors in the fiberglass pool industry openly discuss the problems associated with their products.

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Chapter 15 | How Talking about Our Problems Generated More Than \$500,000 in Revenue| Quiz and Test

- 1.The article on problems related to fiberglass pools generated over \$500,000 in revenue.
- 2.Discussing problems with products is detrimental to gaining consumer trust.
- 3.More than 260,000 visitors searched for problems related to fiberglass pools on the website in the past six years.

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Chapter 16 | Case Study 2 An Equipment Financing Company Becomes a Digital David and Conquers the Industry Goliaths| Quiz and Test

1. Rob Misheloff's company began as a reverse-mortgage direct mail operation before entering the equipment financing sector.
2. Misheloff found that his initial lead generation efforts through spam emails were highly successful and led to immediate growth.
3. The principles of 'They Ask, You Answer' greatly helped Misheloff in building trust and generating revenue for his company.

Chapter 17 | Content Subject 3 Versus and Comparisons| Quiz and Test

1. Consumers show no interest in comparing products and services before making a purchase decision.
2. Sheridan's pool company initially embraced the 'They Ask You Answer' philosophy from the beginning and directly addressed customer inquiries.

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3.Addressing competitive comparisons can lead to increased web traffic and improved consumer trust for businesses.

Chapter 18 | The Critical Need for Unbiased Content| Quiz and Test

- 1.Businesses should avoid addressing competitors in order to maintain a positive image.
- 2.Consumers genuinely care about business perspectives and ask questions to understand better.
- 3.Increasing transparency in sales communication does not significantly affect consumer trust.

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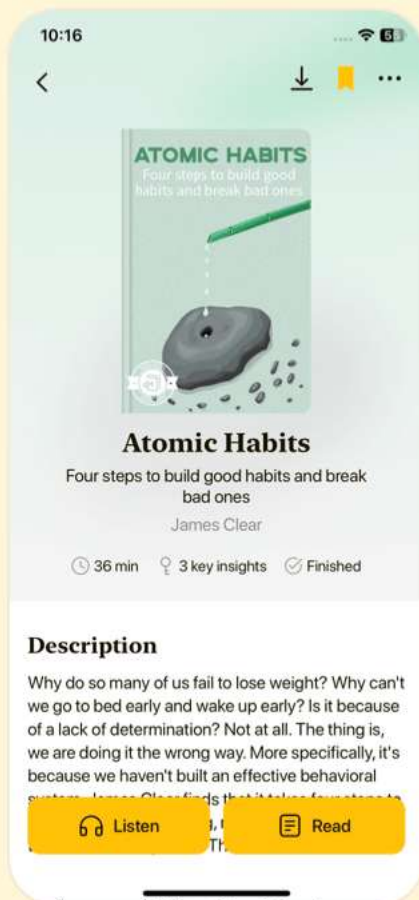


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Chapter 19 | Content Subjects 4 and 5 Reviews and Best in Class| Quiz and Test

1. Consumers prefer authoritative reviews and rankings to make purchasing decisions.
2. The author found that creating a ranking system for pool manufacturers did not benefit River Pools' marketing efforts.
3. Only the manufacturer who ranked lowest in the fiberglass pool industry was interested in the article produced by River Pools.

Chapter 20 | Using Reviews to Establish Yourself as an Expert| Quiz and Test

1. Marcus Sheridan recommends self-promotion in reviews to maintain credibility and trust.
2. Writing honest reviews of competitors can help a business build trust with potential customers.
3. Marcus Sheridan included his own company, River Pools and Spas, in his article about the best pool builders.

Chapter 21 | The Impact of Discussing the Competition| Quiz and Test

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1. Addressing competition through content marketing can improve visibility for a company.
2. Discussing competitors in marketing should be avoided since it might lead to negative customer perceptions.
3. Transparency in marketing is less effective today than it was in the past.

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Chapter 22 | Case Study 3 Small Retail Appliance Store Dominates Online and Makes Millions| Quiz and Test

1. Yale Appliance was founded in 1923 and is considered the biggest thought leader in the kitchen appliance market.
2. Steve Sheinkopf launched a business blog in 2007 to promote sales-driven narratives rather than informative content.
3. Yale Appliance's digital presence increased significantly, resulting in doubled web traffic, sales, and customer engagement since 2011.

Chapter 23 | The Competition| Quiz and Test

1. The competition is a significant influence on what businesses choose to discuss or avoid.
2. Businesses should prioritize the bad fits over their actual customers according to Marcus Sheridan.
3. Marcus Sheridan advises businesses to maintain transparency to foster trust and loyalty with their customers.

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Chapter 24 | How They Ask, You Answer Saved River Pools and Spas| Quiz and Test

1. River Pools and Spas initially relied on organic traffic for their business growth.
2. By 2016, River Pools and Spas became the most trafficked swimming pool website globally.
3. Marcus Sheridan believes that effective communication should prioritize sounding intelligent to engage the audience better.

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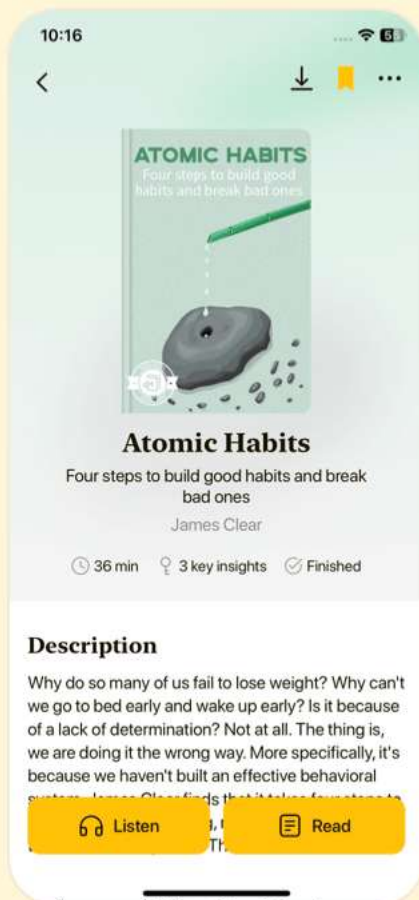


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Chapter 25 | How Great Content Is a Total Game-Changer for Sales Teams| Quiz and Test

1. Sales teams do not need alignment among leadership, marketing, and sales to successfully integrate content marketing.
2. Creating content helps sales teams better understand buyer motivations and needs.
3. They Ask, You Answer philosophy leads to longer sales cycles resulting in less efficiency for sales teams.

Chapter 26 | A Dramatic Discovery| Quiz and Test

1. Potential customers typically read only one or two pages before deciding to do business.
2. In 2012, it was found that individuals who read thirty or more pages from the website had an 80% purchase rate.
3. Engaging with content on a website is irrelevant to building trust and self-qualification among prospects.

Chapter 27 | Assignment Selling| Quiz and Test

1. Just posting content on your website is enough for achieving marketing success.

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2. Assignment selling involves educating prospects with content before sales meetings.

3. Prospects who do not engage with educational content are more likely to convert into customers.

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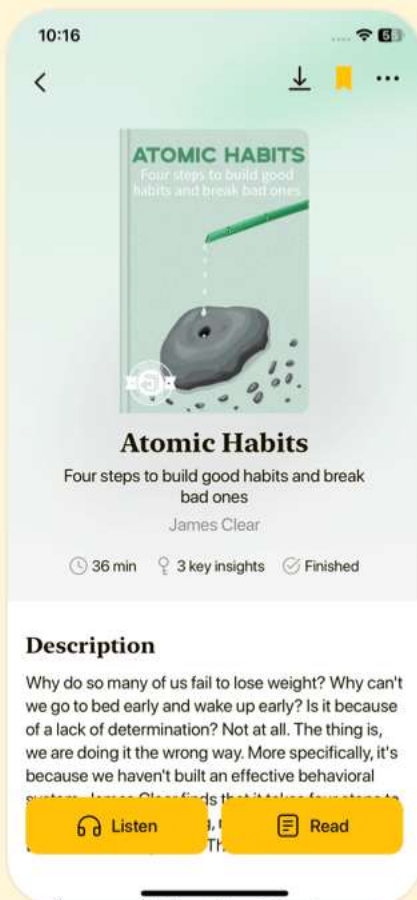


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Chapter 28 | How One Remarkable Couple Changed My Perspective on the Power of Content to Sell| Quiz and Test

- 1.Mr. G viewed over 300 pages of content before making his decision to buy a swimming pool.
- 2.Mrs. G viewed only a few pages of content related to swimming pools.
- 3.The author's selling efforts were crucial in closing the sale with Mr. G.

Chapter 29 | Content Never Sleeps| Quiz and Test

- 1.Content is the greatest sales tool in the world because it operates 24/7 and doesn't demand raises or time off.
- 2.After implementing content-driven sales strategies, the author sold fewer pools with more appointments, leading to a lower closing rate.
- 3.Customers now read an average of 55 pages before making a purchase, indicating a decline in consumer engagement.

Chapter 30 | Using Assignment Selling to Avoid Common Sales Pitfalls| Quiz and Test

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1. Chapter 30 of 'They Ask You Answer' promotes traditional follow-up emails as the best practice in sales.
2. Assignment selling is based on providing additional resources to address specific questions raised by the prospect.
3. The principles of assignment selling are only applicable to large businesses with complex products or services.

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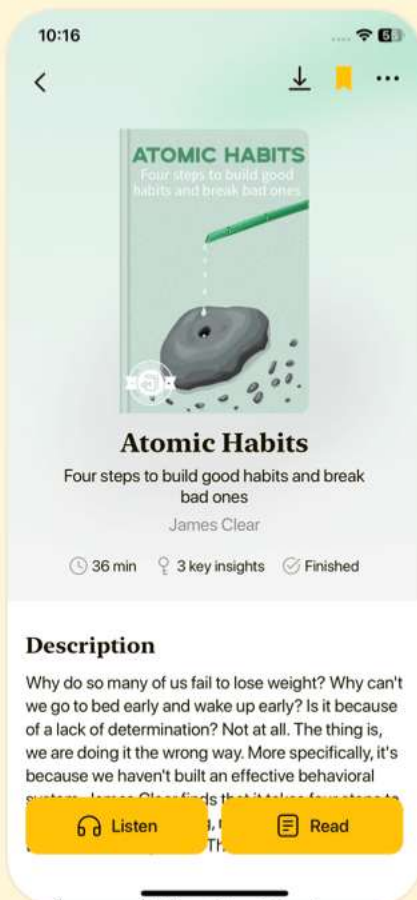


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Chapter 31 | Using Assignment Selling to Determine Compatibility| Quiz and Test

- 1.The agency's assignment selling process requires prospects to read an e-book before a consultation to ensure compatibility.
- 2.The agency believes that requiring prospects to read the e-book will deter interest from potential clients.
- 3.Sales emails from the agency are designed to be presumptive, focusing solely on qualifying leads without providing value to the prospects.

Chapter 32 | Case Study 4 How a Start-Up Company in the Health Care Space Became the Thought Leaders of an Entirely New Industry| Quiz and Test

- 1.Health Catalyst was founded in 2010 and specializes in healthcare analytics.
- 2.Health Catalyst adopted a traditional advertising approach focusing solely on promotional content.
- 3.Health Catalyst became a thought leader by responding to customer inquiries and providing unbiased information in

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healthcare analytics.

Chapter 33 | The Power of Insourcing and Using Your Team to Create Incredible Content| Quiz and Test

- 1.Outsourcing content production typically leads to better brand representation compared to insourcing.
- 2.Insourcing allows companies to create content that is a more genuine reflection of their identity compared to outsourcing.
- 3.Collaboration between sales and marketing is unnecessary for effective content production.

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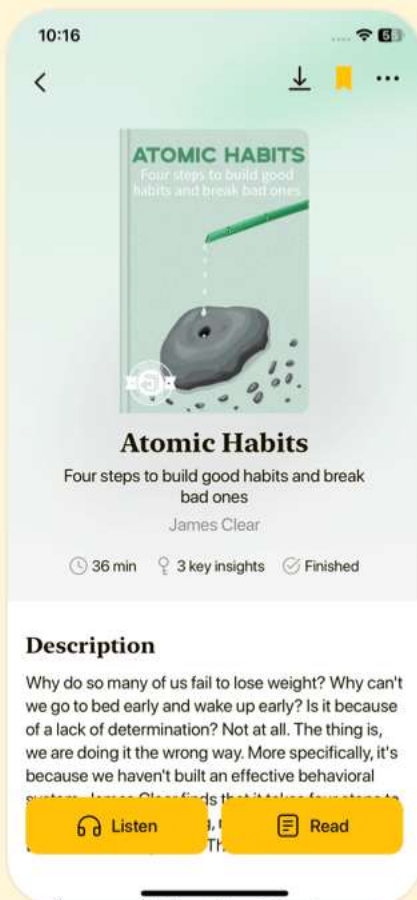


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Chapter 34 | How Block Imaging Embraced a Culture of Insourcing| Quiz and Test

1. Block Imaging faced no resistance from sales and leadership while implementing the principles of 'They Ask, You Answer'.
2. Insourcing at Block Imaging allowed over fifty employees to contribute to content creation, enhancing overall productivity.
3. Collaboration between marketing and sales is not necessary for company growth according to Krista Kotrla's experience at Block Imaging.

Chapter 35 | Starting Off They Ask, You Answer with a Bang Company Workshops| Quiz and Test

1. Workshops are essential for building a strong content marketing culture in a company.
2. Employees do not need to participate in workshops for effective content marketing implementation.
3. Understanding how Google and other search engines work is irrelevant to aligning content marketing strategies with consumer needs.

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Chapter 36 | The Content Manager Qualities, Hiring, and More| Quiz and Test

1. An organization can successfully embrace content marketing without having someone dedicated to own the effort.
2. Content managers should possess skills in writing, editing, and social media to be effective in their role.
3. A trained journalist is generally unsuitable for content marketing roles due to their focus on traditional journalism.

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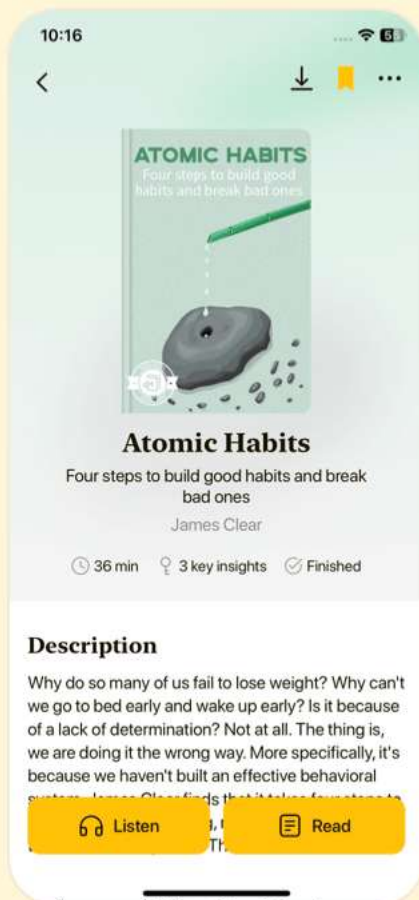


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Chapter 37 | On the Importance of Tools Measuring Return on Investment, the Power of HubSpot, and More| Quiz and Test

- 1.The 'They Ask, You Answer' philosophy emphasizes listening to customer questions and providing relevant content.
- 2.Using HubSpot does not help businesses track their marketing efforts or measure ROI.
- 3.Educational content is essential only for marketing purposes and does not assist in building customer relationships.

Chapter 38 | How Do I Find More Time to Make This Work within My Organization?| Quiz and Test

- 1.Companies often struggle to find time for content marketing, but effective strategies do not exist to produce content more efficiently.
- 2.Recording conversations and having them transcribed can help generate quick and valuable blog posts.
- 3.Hiring a content manager is optional and does not significantly impact the success of content marketing

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efforts.

Chapter 39 | Just How Important Is Video to Inbound and Content Marketing? How Does It Relate to They Ask, You Answer?| Quiz and Test

- 1.Video content is less effective than textual content in inbound and content marketing.
- 2.All companies today should consider themselves as media companies.
- 3.Integrating video into all aspects of business operations can lead to better consumer engagement and sales.

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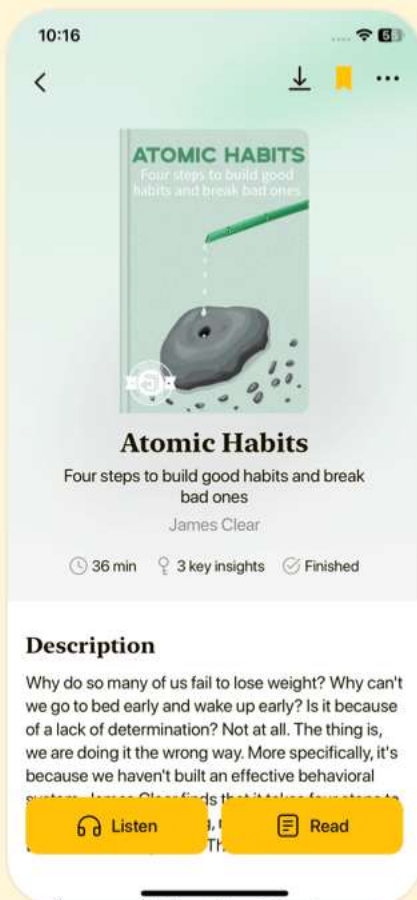


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Chapter 40 | How Long Will It Take They Ask, You Answer to Work?| Quiz and Test

- 1.Content marketing under the 'They Ask, You Answer' philosophy will show results immediately.
- 2.Companies should produce at least two to three new pieces of content weekly to succeed in content marketing.
- 3.It takes less than 18 months for content marketing efforts to result in increased sales figures.

Chapter 41 | Is Content Marketing and They Ask, You Answer Just a Fad?| Quiz and Test

- 1.Content marketing is solely about selling products to consumers.
- 2.Trust and transparency are expected to be significant factors in consumer engagement in the future.
- 3.Content marketing is merely a temporary trend that will fade away soon.

Chapter 42 | How Can I Keep My Team Engaged in the Content Production Process?| Quiz and Test

- 1.Merely instructing team members to 'start blogging' is sufficient for cultivating a sustainable

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culture around content creation.

2.Integrating content training into onboarding helps new hires understand the value of content marketing from the beginning.

3.Recognizing and rewarding team members does not have any impact on their motivation to participate in content marketing.

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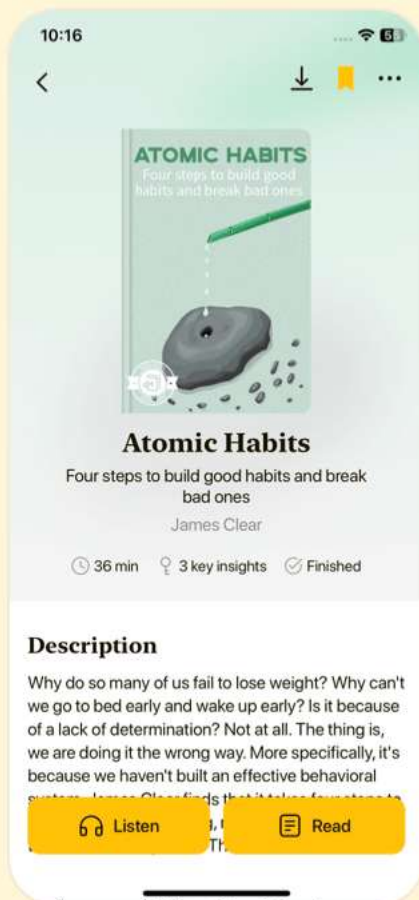


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Chapter 43 | “I’ve Been Told If We’re Not Adding Anything New to the Conversation, Then We Shouldn’t Be Talking about It”| Quiz and Test

- 1.The belief that adding additional perspectives on a fully discussed topic is pointless is a common misconception in digital marketing.
- 2.Sharing ideas that are not original does not bring any value as they have already been discussed by others.
- 3.The idea that multiple perspectives can enrich understanding is illustrated by the redundancy in influential texts such as the Gospels of the New Testament.

Chapter 44 | A Revolutionary Marketing Strategy| Quiz and Test

- 1.The marketing strategy discussed in the book emphasizes listening to customers and being transparent.
- 2.The New York Times article on the marketing strategy was widely ignored by business owners.
- 3.The author believes that simplicity in business strategies is unimportant.

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